HARVEST

Part one in the Dark Waters series

L E Fitzpatrick

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By L E Fitzpatrick

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Prologue

A waltz erupted in the rapids. The *Pursuer* bounded across the ocean, churning black sea white. Sails creaked as they turned, swaying smoothly with the wind, progressing across the watery dance floor with grace and learned sophistication. Above the homebound ship the starry sky glittered like a candlelit chandelier over the oceanic ballroom. The sound of the ocean serenaded the elegant dancer through the night.

Lars struggled with his footing as he negotiated the cabins. His inexperience had overcome him on his very first night and he had hoped he would learn quickly but a childhood in a blacksmiths did little to prepare him for a life at sea. Luckily the crew had taken a liking to him and if he stayed in the navy he would eventually grow accustomed to the sea sickness and staggered hours. At least that's what they told him.

Now he found himself wide awake and on a final mission to earn the respect of his Captain; *it's not what you know*...his father used to say. Their voyage was almost over. He needed to ensure he would return home as crew and not held up in a crate wishing he'd never left the bosom of his family. Reaching the cook's room door he pushed himself inside and fell mercifully at the feet of Coster.

Coster, as far as he could tell, took no sleep. He kept his kitchen as orderly as he kept his uniform. He beamed at Lars and grabbed him by the scruff of the neck with what seemed like giant hands. He shoved the boy on a stool in the corner and wagged his finger at him whilst preaching the benefits of caution when entering the kitchen.

"Now, my boy what can I do ye for, you wouldn't be after raiding my supplies like some rodent would ye?"

"N-No sir," Lars said nervously before gaining his composure. "I came to get a drink sir, for the Captain."

"Captain doesn't usually take a drink at night, you wouldn't be lying to me now lad!"

Lars shook his head profusely. "No sir, Captain hasn't asked for one, but it's cold tonight and I thought she might…"

"Be more inclined to keep you on?"

Lars turned away ashamed, if Coster could see through him the Captain would never be fooled.

Coster dribbled some rum in a tankard and passed it to the boy. "Tho' it won't do no good lad, this is Captain's last voyage, Mr Wicks is taking command in Hermia and he's unlikely to appreciate being woken up two hours before his morning watch."

Lars stared into the tankard and contemplated drinking the liquid himself. "But…"

Coster rested a reassuring hand on his shoulder, “You’ll be sailing back with us lad don’t you worry about that. If only to chase the rats.” He ruffled Lars’ hair affectionately. It wouldn’t be long before his own lad would be embarking on similar adventures.

“But why’s the Captain leaving?”

Coster’s laugh seemed to shake the kitchen, he patted Lars and nearly knocked the wind out of him. “Lad, Captain is the finest sailor I come across, and I come across a lot, but she’s got airs about her, you must have seen it, speaks well, writes proper.” Realising such common knowledge had escaped Lars’ attention Coster knelt beside him and spoke very slowly. “She’s the Princess of Hermia isn’t she, where’s your head been! She’s returning home, to a big palace, lots of finery and we’ll be back with the wind in our faces carrying Dukes and Earls around the islands at their fancy.” Coster sighed, he’d enjoyed the Captain’s missions, escorting trade ships and rounding up pirates.

Lars thought for a second, the rum in the tankard swirled in his hands. “I think I’ll still go on deck.”

Lars couldn’t comprehend why a Princess would want to leave all the pleasantries of royal life; the rest of the crew weren’t as ignorant. In the four years they had sailed together they had seen how Adiah was part of the sea. They had accepted her as Captain without question or disapproval and, after several dangerous but successful voyages, they adored her. They knew Adiah would miss the sea more than the sea would miss her, and the sea would pine for Adiah for a long time.

From the kitchen Lars made his way through the creaking ship. The worn-out noises of the newlyweds sounded in the Captain’s personal quarters, making Lars blush. He hastened his footsteps until he felt the cold night air on his skin. Illuminated by a scattering of gas lamps, a lonely figure clutched the helm.

A zephyr blew through the deck, caressing the face of its Captain lover. Adiah closed her eyes mournfully. She sucked the salty aroma into her lungs in an attempt to savour her last dance. When dawn broke land would ruin the horizon and Adiah’s romance would be over. She held the wheel ignoring her tiredness.

Lars had viewed his Captain as a leader, a sailor, but tonight he saw the Princess. He saw the majesty in her pretty face, the sovereignty in her bold stance. She had the world and yet in her eyes she had nothing. He approached her, softly at first to appreciate this new apparition, but as he grew nearer he hardened his footsteps so as not to alarm her.

“Mr Youngman,” she said surprised, “You’re not on duty.”

“No Captain,” Lars replied. “I thought you might like a drink, to toast your last night.”

Adiah stared at the boy’s shaking hands and expectant eyes. She took the tankard and drank half of its contents before handing it back to him, “Go on warm up. It’s important to rest when

you're off duty. We don't regulate the watches for our convenience." She sighed remembering how she would stay up for hours on end just to listen to the ship.

Eagerly Lars drank before wiping his mouth clean. "It's good of you to give your cabin away Captain."

"When you Captain your own ship you'll understand that two newlyweds are best locked away. Besides it's their wedding night. I'm just grateful I don't have to sleep in it tomorrow."
"Are you looking forward to going home?" Lars covered his mouth, realising he was taking liberties, once again too late.

Adiah glanced at the ship, "Home? This is my home Mr Youngman."

The conversation died quickly, but the two sat in a respectful silence and the *Pursuer* sailed on, ignorant to the fact her dance was coming to an abrupt finale. The black vessel in the distance was gaining on them.

Adiah turned and squinted into the irregular darkness. It was too late. The knives of the cutthroats were already gleaming; gleaming and hungry.

The black ship sliced, fearlessly through the sea, shredding the waves around it, unstoppable and determined. The crew worked relentlessly, ruthlessly. Blood poured from their battered bodies. *The Fury*'s sails swelled, suffocating the stars and stealing the wind to push them faster. Large shadows circled her, following the ship hungrily.

"Faster! You focsle-heads! Faster!" Mr Scragg yelled.

The deck was alive with grunts and cries. Sweat beaded down foreheads, backs and arms. Blood stained ropes where blisters had burst and skin had burned. The crew worked like the waves, rocking back and forth, pushing and pulling, swaying the ship as much as the tide. Their bodies pounded like mallets on flesh, abusing their stations into unquestionable submission.

Scragg, the first mate, watched them scrupulously. He eyed the weak, took note of the strong, all the while feeling the elixir tingling in his blood.

"Mr Scragg sir?" The Captain's assistant shouted. He was a boy of thirteen, gifted to the Captain after his expeditions through the Southern Tropics. He had dark blood running through him but his skin was as white as frost and the tribe had regarded him as a curse, offering him to stop the raids. The Captain had taken the boy to the *Fury* and from there they watched the tribe being slaughtered and the sea turn red with mutual satisfaction. The boy's eyes were like windows to that day and Scragg was always reminded of it when he caught the boy's attention. It wasn't an unpleasant memory.

“Captain wants to see you,” he said confidently. Scragg would have flogged a man for raising an eyebrow at him, but Ghost was unassailable in Mercy’s care. Instead he clenched his tingling fist and headed swiftly to the Captain’s quarters.

Mercy’s head was spinning with memories and dreams. The feeling made him want to vomit. He pressed himself against the walls of his cabin and slid down to the floor smiling. His heart pounded and the sea laughed around him. The wide grin on his face began to fade as the anger returned. The poison made his muscles twitch. Then his vision returned. He was invincible. Captain Mercy the hurricane, the cannon ball, the fire. He was a shark, muscular and deadly, with cold, black eyes. His skin had been weathered into leather, and where he was free of scars he was heavily tattooed with skulls and demons. Six thick gold rings hung from holes in his ears and one from the centre of his nose, ringing funeral bells whenever he moved. He wiped red streaks from his, large, twisted nose with his heavy hands.

“Captain,” Scragg said surveying the destroyed cabin. Everything had been upturned or smashed, everything except the chest with the glass vials.

Captain Mercy opened his eyes and stared at Scragg. They were all changing; it was becoming more noticeable now. Scragg had been a skinny hoe of a sailor before they took the elixir, now his body bulged with strength and power. His eyes were starting to take on a red tint where there should have been white, but they were not nearly as noticeable as the startlingly, bloody eyes of Captain Mercy. His abuse of the elixir had greatly exceeded that of the crew; he told himself he couldn’t risk an arrogant privateer growing more powerful than him, he told himself the addiction was controllable.

“Mr Scragg!” Mercy growled, “I am in the mood for a flogging.”

“Aye sir,” Scragg replied soberly.

“Ship Ahoy!”

The call brought both men out on deck. At the appearance of the Captain the crew threw themselves harder into their work, hammering the deck ferociously. It felt like the ship had suddenly lunged six feet ahead. Mercy failed to notice his crew’s efforts. His attention was fixed on a distant schooner, hovering on the horizon. A gargoyle smile cut into his grotesque face. The thirst for violence would be quenched; would be soaked.

“There she is Captain, orders.”

“Bring me survivors. Pretty ones.”

“In the brig?”

“Except her. Chain *her* in my quarters.”

Scragg grinned, “After a parade on deck?”

The Captain glanced over his First Mate. “If that would please the crew.” He stepped forward and yelled his commands to the famished ship.

PART I

One

Sunlight beamed down through the dense foliage. The shadows heated and slowly the dew began to dry around the body of a man and his wolf. A large rook dropped down to the burnt cinders of a dead fire where the small bones of a pigeon rested. The wolf watched the bird hungrily. He snorted and placed his wet nose against the man's dirty hand. There was no response.

The wolf stretched out his paws and whined to himself. He thought back to the departed pigeon he had shared with his companion and he remembered how much his friend would needlessly waste. His eyes glanced over the man; the snoring oaf had been close to unconscious for over five hours. The day would soon escape them and lunch would be out in the cold again.

There was a noise from beyond the cove they slept in. The wolf raised his ears and nudged his friend again. Reluctantly the wolf got up and licked the dirty bristles on his companion's face.

"Stop it," his friend moaned, "Stop!" He pushed the wolf away with his hands, forcing his eyes to remain closed.

The wolf persisted and finally his friend opened his bleary, bloodshot eyes and scowled at the morning. His head pounded. As he moved the world around him spun and he held onto the dirt for support. His bladder was aching, but it was going to have to wait. Egan Wey's hearing focussed on the approaching party up ahead. He examined his shambles of a camp. Grabbing his hat and rucksack of necessities, he clambered down into the roots of a large oak, concealing himself and the wolf as best he could. The marching footsteps grew louder, but Wey and the wolf were well experienced in concealment. They knew to lay still and silent, only taking the slightest breath and listening closely.

"Sir," a small voice called, "The fire's cold. Estimate travellers left at least three hours ago."

"And in which direction?" A commanding voice said.

Wey could only see the arms and legs of the uniformed men ahead of him, but he recognised them as the local militia. There were five of them in total, not a patrol and Wey noticed they were missing their swords. He smiled, it was a training party. With a silent sigh he rested back against the bark and waited patiently for them to continue with their nonsense.

"The footsteps are confusing," the trainee paused. "A dog has been here, contaminated the evidence sir."

"And therefore we must …?"

There was a long silence and finally a third voice spoke up. "We can determine that the traveller was less than half an hour from Langley and six hours from Helmsgate, therefore it is likely he is journeying to Langley. Is probably at Langley already?"

"Very perceptive Private. Course of action Private Peers?"
"To trek into Langley and question the inn keepers."
"The inn keepers?" Their Commander said surprised.

"Yes sir, by the smell of the fellow's sleeping place I would say he was a drinker and given there are no discarded bottles it is likely he will head for a drop of ale to start his day."

"Right men, step to it."

Wey listened as they stomped away. When they were out of earshot he began to laugh. He wiped the dust off his hat and jacket, noticing another hole in the leather. Unbuttoning his trousers he took a long piss over his former camp. That would certainly confuse the soldiers on their return.

They were of course mistaken; Wey was neither heading to, nor leaving Langley. Nor was he likely to go anywhere near Helmsgate. What the soldiers had never even considered was that he arrived by boat during the night, camped in the wilderness before heading for the city and he was taking such an erratic route to avoid the authorities. They were right about one thing though, he did need a drink.

"Thorin lets move out!"

The wolf whined and nudged the pigeon carcass.

"We'll see what we get on the way."

It was a blazingly hot summer's day, too hot for Wey. He trudged through the wilderness, avoiding all signs of civilisation, in his large leather jacket. After the first mile he was soaked with sweat and regretting his choice to bring rum and not water. Wey rarely learned from that oversight. The jacket, like the rum, was necessity; it held every tool of his trade in concealed pockets and linings. His sister had made it for him six years ago and the time was starting to show in the worn sleeves and collar. Still if he lived long enough he could get her to make him another one.

Thorin kept a steady pace with his friend, keeping alert for foes and, more pertinently, food. He was desperately hungry and longing to be back on the ship. The ground seemed wrong when it wasn't swaying in the sea. After three months on the water Thorin had acclimatised himself so well he hated being in his natural habitat. He waded through the foliage grumpily.

It was a two day trek to the Hermia's heart on foot, providing they got an early start. Wey accepted that it would probably be three days before he reached the city and meet his contact, but if he hurried he might get a day's whoring in to set him in the right frame of mind.

Two

Brother Carlston clasped one white knuckled hand over the carriage door, the other over his chubby, green face. The sharp vomit stench lingered around the two travellers, coupled with a faint hint of sandalwood; no priest had ever been able to purge the smell of sandalwood from their skin. Brother Carlston's eyes were squeezed shut, but even open he would have been able to see very little. For the past hour they had been travelling the forest, rife with thieves and murders. The coach driver had insisted on extinguishing all light until civilisation greeted them. Brother Carlston would have normally worried over the undesirables lurking in the shadows outside, but the coach was hurrying so quickly along the untamed track he was certain they would crash before any raid could be launched.

The coach flew over a large mound in the road. Carlston groaned as he was thrown into the air. His companion, Brother Finnian, had made no noise since stepping inside the coach, nor did he seem to move as the rocky roadway thrust Carlston into the air. They had travelled for over an hour; it felt like minutes, it felt like days. Brother Finnian fixed his gaze firmly on the floor and making it impossible to penetrate his thoughts.

"Can we slow down?" Carlston shouted to the driver who either was hard of hearing or enjoyed distressing priests. "Finn, are you all right?"

Finn raised his head as though he had only just realised where he was and where he was going. "I was just running the ritual over in my head."

"You've done it a hundred times," he said, reassuringly.

When the coach hit the cobbled street Brother Carlston's stomach finally revolted and the priest was forced to press his head out of the window and bless the street with Temple stew. He praised the gods that it was so late only the vagrants saw his indiscretion. The coach pulled into the courtyard of the First Minister's mansion. He caught Finn averting his eyes from the large fountain oppressing the grounds.

The mansion was exactly as Finn remembered. He knew each painting, each statue, by heart and yet this didn't comfort him. Carlston, although a confessed simple man, was not overawed by the grandeur of their surroundings. There were many rich gentlemen still accustomed to the old ways and many who had requested his personal attendance. His position as a priest had grounded him and he made every effort to comfort both gentlemen and their servants with equal respect. He had tried to bestow this quality to Finn, but the boy's prejudice had, at times, left him callous to those in fortune.

Carlston took charge of the duties. He had an inkling that Finn had only be requested to join him as words that should have been said a long time ago could be held in no longer. With extraordinary patience and sympathy he urged Finn through his former residence and, against his better judgement, Finn followed.

They were greeted at the staircase by a tall gentleman in a black uniform. He was deceptively old, disguising the fact beneath a trimmed grey beard. Finn recognised him immediately. He smiled, surprised to see the old soldier still in service.

"The Minister has requested a brief word with Master Finnian before we begin."

"Of course," Brother Carlston replied. He had already predicted this would be the case and had slyly packed a romance novel to pass the time while he waited. He patted Finn on the back. "Go on Brother."

Finn hesitated so Carlston gave him a shove up the first step. Slowly he followed General Balor, his father's personal guard, up the staircase and across the hall to the room his father had occupied for over forty years. Balor knocked lightly and opened the door. He stepped aside for Finn to enter first.

"He gets tired very easily," Balor explained. He held out his hand and shook Finn's with a degree of warmth. "It is good to see you Master Finnian, you look very well." With that he left, making a point of closing the door, trapping Finn inside.

The room was poorly lit, the corners had succumbing to the shadows. There was a heavy aroma of incense, an attempt to disguise the stench of death and urine that was now as embedded into the Minister as strongly as sandalwood was embedded in Finn.

Finn peered into the room, his feet standing firm, as close to the door as they could reach. He could see the bed and the drapes around it. He told himself that he was a man now, more than a man, he was a priest and the past had been laid to rest. Before him was an ailing invalid in need of his final death right. Once it was over he would return home and continue in his life without it being stained by this one occasion.

Slowly, with the courage of a warrior, he stepped over to the water bowl and began to wash his hands, drawing out the process far longer than he needed to.

"Finnian!" A voice barked from behind the velvet drapes that adorned the bed. "Is that you Finnian?"

Finn sucked in the air to steady himself. "Yes father."

"What are you doing over there?"

"I'm just preparing myself for the rite, I won't be a moment."

"Get over here," the dying man demanded.

"I just need to light some candles, to light your path."

“Don’t talk such nonsense boy. I didn’t call you here for hocus pocus!”

Finn hesitated. He tried to calm himself with breathing and mantras, but the old man was far too efficient at stirring his darker side. Drying his hands he slowly moved over to the bed and glimpsed his father for the first time in four years. The disease had ravaged the Minister’s body, making him a skeleton of his former self. His eyes were sunken and his skin sagged, as though he had spent the last four years in a pickle jar. He wore a hat on his head, but his hair was clearly thinning and grey. Finn remembered his father as a vain man who valued the radiance of his appearance. The man in the bed was almost a stranger. Almost, apart from his eyes; those cold, calculating, detached balls still glaring impatiently at the world before them.

“If you didn’t call me here so I could do my duty I shall bid you a goodnight sir.”

“When did I raise such a surly, self-righteous boy?” The Minister snapped.

“Perhaps in the time you were not raising me,” Finn muttered under his breath.

The Minister didn’t hear the comment or pretended not to. He tried to pull himself up, but only succeeded in slouching back into his pillows. The pain was immense, but the medicine that worked so effectively clouded his judgement and for now he needed to think clearly. Finn had grown. He looked like his mother, shared her striking features and fair hair, but the Minister could see his own father’s eyes in the boy and a physique shared by the Fernwick men. He looked strong, stronger than the Minister would have ever hoped, and he held himself with determination and conviction. He would have made a good politician but the religious robes he wore created a mockery of all that could have been.

“I have out lived the surgeons’ expectations. They say I am now borrowing time.” He coughed to clear the thick mucous from his throat. “I cannot leave this room. I cannot move from this bed. I have tried and with each attempt I grow weaker.”

Finn was silent; it was not in his father’s nature to give up.

“So you will understand that, if I were able, I would embark on this task alone and leave you in your preferred exile from our world.”

“You want me to do something for you?”

The Minister shook his head, “Not for me. For the Princess, for your friend, Adiah.”

Finn felt a pang at the mention of her name. It had only been two months since her death and no amount of mourning would ease the loss.

“You remember her?”

“Of course I do,” he replied, offended. “She was my best friend. Her death, well, it has been difficult.”

“She’s not dead.”

Finn looked confused. “I beg your pardon.”

“Adiah isn’t dead, she is in the Vaults.”

“The Vaults!”

The Minister raised his hand for silence. “I had the incident investigated, covertly. There was no storm recorded by any other vessel and some of the wreck has been recovered off the coast of Juliet scorched. Reliable sources have confirmed a privateer vessel crossed paths with Adiah’s ship that night but then changed course and docked at the Vaults.”

“A privateer vessel?” Finn suddenly understood. The old man had lost his mind. “Father they’re licensed by the King. I’m sure if Adiah was alive her father would know about it.”

“Of course he knows about it. He instigated it. Now the coward has locked himself up in his palace under the guise of a mourning monarch!” The Minister, in his anger now managed to sit up. “He has taken her and I don’t know why, but she is still alive and she must be saved. You must save her.” He pointed a wiry finger at Finn.

The priest sat down. The temptation to believe him was overwhelming. Adiah had been his closest friend. Her death had devastated him. She had left him and their island to live across the ocean with her uncle and her correspondence had always been filled with unbelievable adventures. He looked forward to her letters every month and remembered the sympathy he felt for her when she wrote of her return, then agony he felt himself when she never fulfilled her promise. He longed for his father to be right, but the likelihood was too incredulous.

“Does anyone else know about this?” He asked his father doubtfully.

“Balor, he has been my body in this matter.”

“Then can Balor not free Adiah himself?”

The Minister glared at Finn venomously. “You would rather an old soldier rescue her? You would put her fate in his hands rather than your own?”

Finn was silent. “If she were alive perhaps things would be different, but Adiah died.”

“And if she is alive, being tortured in the Vaults, you will leave her there? No, that is not my son. He would not leave her to such a cruel fate, even if I am just rambling like a madman, you would not let that stop you if there was but one chance I am right. You must go Finn. You must get her from that place. You must take her back to her uncle in Helena and you must look after her there.”

Now suddenly it all made sense. Finn rose, if he wasn’t so angry he would have been impressed at this latest ploy. Still on his death bed the old man was intent on destroying everything Finn valued.

“How dare you? How dare you bring Adiah into your schemes, rest her soul! I have chosen my profession. I’m a priest, father, you can’t change that. I don’t know why I bothered coming here.” He tried to move away but a thin hand grabbed him. Needle fingers pinched his wrist.

“Don’t you leave me boy,” he threatened. “I have told you no word of a lie. She is alive and she is in danger.”

“And you wish for me to rescue her, be her knight in shining armour. Why me father? You have far more capable men at your disposal.”

“You love her and you will take care of her.”

“I am a priest!” Finn snapped to his father’s surprise. “I care for the girl, truly I do but I can’t save her and your attempts to lure me out with the promise of her affection as a prize is insulting to us both.”

His father released him, suddenly more frail and helpless than he had ever been. “She’s your sister,” he said resting back in his bed as though the secret alone had been keeping the air in his lungs.

Finn touched his cheek, convinced he had just been slapped. He opened his mouth, then closed it again. “What did you say?”

The Minister closed his weary eyes. “She’s your sister, Finnian. The King has… specific tastes. After the birth of his son he found the Queen old and repulsive. He is a vicious, heartless man.”

“We are the same age,” Finn murmured, trying to make sense of the madness.

His father continued. “I grew up with Adiah’s mother. We were always close. Very close.” “Did my mother know?” He said drawing his father away from excuses.

“She suspected. Finnian your mother was a troubled woman. I tried to care for her, but we were never truly compatible.” He began.

Finn turned away. He caught sight of the window that overlooked the courtyard. He could see his father standing there, staring down at the body of his wife as blood froze on the snow covered fountain.

“She knew,” he assured his father.

“Finnian, I will not justify myself to you. You are not a man of the world. You have no understanding of these matters. And I will not ask for your forgiveness. What’s done is done. There is still a girl trapped and you are now responsible for what happens to her.”

Finn scowled. He clenched his fists, tempted to beat the old man into the next world personally.

“She must be saved. You must honour my wishes Finnian; this one dying wish must not be snubbed.”

“You will die alone,” Finn replied coolly. “You have no wife, no children by your bedside. Perhaps those that elected you will mourn your passing, but you’ll be replaced as easily as you won

your post. Nobody will feel your loss. Not like they felt the loss of my mother. I won't carry you like I carry her."

"So you will leave your own sister to rot in prison."

Finn shook his head. "You're right, I am not a man of the world. I can't understand or condone what you've done. I'm a priest, a simple man and no ounce of goodness within me would let me leave a dear friend in peril. If she is there I will save her, but for her sake, not for your dying wish."

The Minister nodded smugly. "Balor will accompany you. I have made arrangements for you to leave tonight."

"Does Adiah know?"

"I saw no benefit in revealing the truth to her. To either of you. You naturally adopted a sibling role with each other. The truth would have complicated matters." He nested back into his bed. "You should not tell her. Her legitimacy to the throne would be compromised." The Minister crossed his hands and closed his eyes. The issue was resolved.

Finn waited in silence. He had expected his father to at least express some remorse or even encouragement on his new task. He received nothing. He recalled the last words his father had said to him as he left for the Temple, they seemed more than appropriate.

"You are a disappointment," he murmured as he left.

His hands were trembling as he exited the room. Sliding down the hall wall he rested on the floor in shock. Anger and delight waged war in his head. He tried to banish the disgust he felt for his father and instead attempted to understand what needed to be done. Yes, he would try to help, although he doubted his ability to break an inmate out of prison. Could she actually be there? Could she really be alive? He had to assume she was. He knew, were their roles reversed, Adiah would not hesitate to come for him and he could not abandon her.

He had a sister. The truth struck him hard. He had been an only child all his life and now, now he had a sister. Exasperated he rubbed his eyes, comprehension eluded him once more. Adiah was his friend, but they were nothing alike. She was wild and wilful while he was introvert and reserved. She looked like the portrait of her mother that hung in the palace, petite and pretty, although the more he thought about her the more he matched their hair colour, eye colour and complexion.

"Master Finn," the General said.

Finn hadn't even noticed him standing there. Gathering his composure he quickly stood up and brushed the creases from his long black coat.

“General, my apologies. I…”

“If you are ready I have a coach waiting for us.”

“Now?”

“There is a contact we must meet. It is imperative we move as quickly as we can.”

“I should speak to Brother Carlston, he can arrange to have some things sent over.”

Balor shook his head. “Master Finn we have no time to wait for luggage. Our guide will ensure we have everything we need. I have already spoken to the priest downstairs. He understands that you are to fulfil one final task for your father.”

“Did you tell him what it was?”

“No, nor did he ask. And I would implore you Finn to be very careful who you trust. We are about to commit an act of treason and if we are caught we are likely to face the gallows. The King will pay highly for anyone who betrays us so keep your wits about you and hopefully we will have your sweetheart back with you soon enough.”

“Sweetheart?”

“Yes Finn,” Balor told him sternly. “Even priests have sweethearts.” He patted Finn on the back. “Come now, the Brother will take care of your father.”

As he moved away from the bedroom Finn fancied he saw his mother cross the hall.

Three

Every low life, scoundrel, scumbag and scallywag to sail the islands found themselves wondering the streets of Beggar's Lane at some time in their short lives. It had grown alongside its sophisticated sister like a deformed, leper brother. Whereas Hermia's city prospered with the influx of new mainland technologies, Beggar's Lane slumped further into the trench of the past, deprived, depraved and thoroughly debauched.

Inns and whorehouses held the foundation of the district, supporting the slum houses and illegal markets. A criminal could hide for days in Beggar's Lane. An honest man could get lost for life.

Wey marched through Water Street admiring the subtle changes to the buildings around him since his last visit. Sheets of tin had been attached to the holes in the Shipman. Madam Jacqueline's had curtains up in their windows, a worthy improvement. The market sellers had managed to pilfer some exotic foods from the Tropics and were charging an extortionate price for the liberty of looking at them. Thorin strutted through the street taking care to cock his leg at every available opportunity.

Wey was not a stranger to Beggar's Lane, but he was a visitor and visitors, familiar or not, were always treated with a degree of caution, suspicion and ignorance. Nobody wanted to know Wey unless Wey was there to see them. It was how he liked it; it was how Beggar's Lane had managed to maintain the stronghold for underground island trade. Then a voice called out his name and stopped him in his tracks.

"Mr Wey, I didn't think we'd be seeing you so soon."

The interruption was annoying, but manners were something a Fimorri man like himself took particular pride in. He removed his hat and smiled broadly at the raven haired woman who lustfully leaned from her balcony. Her bellowing voice stirred her comrades inside and the balcony was suddenly littered with rippling bosoms and plump lips.

Wey replied in a noble bow, the kind you reserve only for the richest ladies and lowest whores. Their beckoning cries were well rehearsed but genuine as they posed from their balcony like second-hand dolls in a display case. He made a gesture of excuses before walking away, after taking one final hungry look.

The door to the Red Dragon had been smashed twenty nine times this season, each collision had been commemorated by a new, neatly nailed plank of wood making the Red Dragon entrance look like a patchwork blanket. As Wey opened the door the stench of the bar, mingled with the filth from outside, created a sickly, sweet, putrid odour that punched Wey hard in the face. There was a steady flow of customers each hour and many full time residents, lingering on the same rotting

tables like mould. Several faces recognised Wey and avoided his eye line. The more ignorant and curious of the punters gawped at the stranger's apparent confidence in their local.

Wey marched across the sawdust covered floor ensuring the slight heel on his worn boots clinked loudly while Thorin sniffed at the beer stains, food stains and blood stains hungrily. The bar at the heart of the room was the attraction of Beggar's Lane, stocked with an array of spirits, ales and ciders to intoxicate and blind eager drinkers. Shelves of quality spirits sat in dusty coats above the bar counter, whilst half empty unmarked bottles littered the counter top.

A scuffling behind the bar was the only indication of the landlord's presence. Wey rested against the bar top and coughed. Thorin found a comfortable spot on the floor and salivated beside the spit on the fire. A bearded face peered up from behind the counter. The landlord didn't smile, but his eyes betrayed the pleasure he had from receiving an old friend.

"Mr Wey," he said already rummaging through his finer bottles.

"Mr Groader, fine weather we're having." *Any officers in tonight?*

"Aye, very fine today but we've had storms like you wouldn't believe lately." Groader found his most valued bottle of rum and began to pour two shots. He placed the bottle on the counter before climbing up on his tall stool. The dwarf always insisted that business must be performed eye to eye and was quite willing to blow the kneecaps off those who disagreed.

"But you expect the weather to hold?" *Will the officers be in tonight?*

Groader studied the door, "I think the sun will hold."

Wey smiled and gestured to one of the wooden booths in the far corner of the bar. Unlit candles wedged into old bottles sat on each of the booth tables but Groader made no effort to light them. Engulfed in suspect shadows the two crooks sat down while one of the Red Dragon's barmaids began a song and dance around the room, delighting and distracting the other drinkers. Thorin slid quietly into the booth and found a spot on the floor overlooking the main entrance and the spit on the fire.

"So we got the pigeon," Wey said filling his glass a second time and knocking the shot back.

"I take it I won't expect her home."

"You send a fat plump bird into the hands of savage pirates, what do you think we're going to do with it. I told you before send them skinny."

Groader sighed and let his proud gaze drift over the barmaid circling the room. She was his eldest daughter and, although she was not his most beautiful, she was certainly the most cunning. She would continue her performance until the musicians arrived and took the reigns, ensuring no unwanted attention was drawn their way.

"Good fee, the cargo must be valuable." Wey said snapping Groader's attention back.

The landlord nodded evasively. Wey leaned forward suspiciously. "And the cargo is?"

“A girl,” Groader replied.

Wey yawned at the monotony, “Which whorehouse?”

Groader raised a dismissive hand, “Nothing like that. Any creature spat out of hell can steal children. I would not have asked the Fimorri to help unless I needed Fimorri expertise, or rather the expertise of one infamous Fimorri scallywag.”

Pausing, Wey then smiled when he realised he was that infamous scallywag. Allowing his ego to swell he encouraged Groader to continue, ready to accept the job entirely on the fact he was an expert in them and couldn’t be seen to let his reputation falter.

“So a girl,” he said excited. “Pretty?”

“The Princess.”

“A Princess?”

“*The* Princess.”

“Of Hermia, devil a doubt she’s shark food by now!” He whispered feeling the anticipation of a conspiracy upon him.

Groader leaned in closer and reached for the bottle of rum. He filled Wey’s glass, avoiding eye contact again. Wey was something of an aspiration of Groader’s and in a moment all that he admired and sought in his own character would be replaced by a frightened, broken child.

“She’s in the Vaults.”

He half expected Wey to leave but he didn’t. He swiped the drink from the table, emptied it and then took the bottle. The shell of Egan Wey was still beaming with arrogance, but inside Groader could see him tremble.

“Then let her fascist family get her,” he grumbled.

“Her fascist family put her there, least that’s what I’ve heard. She’s obviously out of favour with his Royal Highness.”

“Who’s the contact?”

Groader gestured to the bottle clenched in Wey’s fist. “Minister Fernwick.”

Wey finished the bottle and let the warm blanket of drunken stupidity caress him. He put it on the table and tried to let his ambition overcome his fear. This was the job the Fimorri had been looking for. Finally they could hurt the islands. If the Royals wanted their Princess locked up, he would free her. If the government wanted her safe, well he would ransom her for the privilege.

“Shall I arrange a meeting?”

Cautiously Wey nodded, “Mr Groader I do believe the Fimorri have reached a turning point, let’s toast, *damnation to King Cormac*.”

Wearily Groader nodded and slid himself from the booth, “Aye and I’ll get you something to soak it all up before they arrive.”

Thorin whimpered from under the table.

“Aye you too.”

The Fimorri would have you believe they were fearless, but they knew more than most that every man has his weakness. Wey had lived through hurricanes, wars and massacres of his people. He’d seen his friends fall beside him and he’d forced the friends of others to fall. Sometimes he would sleep uneasy when he dreamt of his past adventures but when he thought of the Vaults he could not bring himself to close his eyes. Just hearing the word had conjured up memories he had tried to bury with rum and opium and anything else that would obliterate his mind. But the thoughts would now haunt him until he had got the girl free, because now he had accepted this mission they were bound together and he knew what pretty little things endured in the Vaults.

Four

The carriage arrived in Beggar's Lane seeking refuge in the small stable shack at the far side of the Red Dragon. Balor leapt from it with the grace of an experienced horseman, but winced as his elderly knees buckled under the strain. He offered a hand to Finn and helped the boy clamber down on to the shitty floor. He had expected the boy to undergo severe culture shock the moment they left the mansion but so far he was holding up.

They left the stables and were immediately thrown into the usual night time brawl. A fight had broken out from one of the whorehouses and like a snowball it was picking up every drunk and crook that happened to stumble in its path. Finn stared at the mêlée unable to comprehend it. In his school days he'd seen and even been subjected to the odd fight but this was like a volcano erupting before him. He was horrified, stunned and fascinated as bodies hurled themselves from the filthy streets into the fight only to be tossed back out again slightly tenderised.

Balor held him back in the darkness, seemingly unaffected by the scene. He checked his pistol and sword before covering himself in a worn black coat that resembled something of an old uniform, but was unadorned with any allegiances.

"So this is Beggar's Lane," Finn murmured to himself.

"You've never been?"

Innocently Finn shook his head. The fight had begun to tantalise him and he found himself incapable of turning away.

"Finnian," Balor said seriously, "We are about to meet a man who will be able to help us. He will accompany us to the Vaults and he will assist us in removing Adiah."

"Is he a soldier?"

Balor sighed, "Listen to me very carefully Finn, from the moment we step foot in that hovel we become outlaws and every solider with a royal crest on his chest is sworn to kill us."

"Then who would help us turn against the King?"

Balor almost broke a smile. The boy he had once known was fiercely smart and driven, but years of solitude had sheltered him from the crumbling authority and servitude Hermia suffered. He patted Finnian's back and gestured to the unruly mob.

"Any low life cut throat that crawled through the gutter." His eyes narrowed and he pulled Finn deeper into the stable. "*Cut throat* Finn, means cut throat. There's not a man before you that would think twice before turning on his country or turning on you. But none of these lowlifes satisfies our requirements and we have to turn to the larger demons in the more secluded bowels of hell."

Finn wondered if the old soldier was drunk.

“Our guide is Fimorri.”

It seemed likely. “Fimorri are folk law.”

“Fimorri have become folk law. Oh they’re not two headed monsters or anything so unholy but they’re as vicious as a maternal viper. Do not trust him, do not believe the fanatical stories he tells you and do not reveal anything you do not need to.”

“But if we can’t trust him…”

“Finn we have very few options. We can forget this whole sorry affair and return to wait for your father to pass, or we can put our lives in the hands of these people to bring a young woman home.”

Resolved, the two men emerged from the darkness and danced around the violence. Their purpose driven footsteps seemed to repel the chaos and they found themselves opening the patchwork door to the Red Dragon unharmed.

The inn attacked every sense Finn had. He staggered back as he tried to acclimatise his nose. Balor swiftly pulled him deeper, expelling enough confidence for the both of them. It was risky bringing Finn into the public eye whilst he negotiated with the guide, but Balor was hopeful that Finn’s absence from society had left him as much as stranger to those around him as he was to his own father. He located the Landlord and waited to be shown to their man.

The laughter and singing overpowered the fiddler trying to tout for donations of silvers and coppers from his intoxicated companions for the night. He danced, frustrated, between the tables while the merriment erupted even louder, forcing him to concede defeat and join his less dedicated musicians by the bar. With the utmost pride and care he placed his fiddle within its battered wooden case and sighed deeply. It was another slow night, to accompany a very slow week.

Taking a mouthful of ale he watched the tavern door open. Holding the black liquid in his mouth he watched the two cloaked figures move swiftly through the crowd. They headed directly to the far corner of the tavern, the dark corner. A man did not survive in this world without knowing when to become invisible and the fiddler was keen to see his fifty-second year. Swallowing the ale he averted his eyes to the remaining liquid in his tankard, resisting the temptation of watching the most unusual meeting to ever grace the Red Dragon.

If he had of looked up, if his eyes had been strong enough to see through the intentional gloominess of the Red Dragon, he would have been drawn to the man occupying the corner and noticed the glowing eyes of his protective companion. Those glowing eyes were fixed upon the table of two well dressed gentlemen picking gingerly at legs of chicken and roasted potatoes. They had overlooked the fallen chicken leg on the floor in the sawdust. The glowing eyes blinked and the wolf let out a frustrated whimper.

A carefully placed hat covered his face, but Finn could see two glowing ember eyes from beneath the table. Tales of demons and disfigured men plagued his common sense. As they were seated at the booth Finn felt fur from a warm body beneath the table. He dared a look and was relieved to see the melancholy wolf resting beneath. The man too didn't stir fear into his heart as he had almost hoped. Instead he bore a friendly, if slightly sinister smile, and smelt of rum and earth. His clothes gave the impression of poverty but they were in fact finely tailored to accommodate the life of an active adventurer.

"Mr Wey," Balor began.

"General," Wey replied looking at the younger man, "You have brought a friend."

Balor lowered his voice, "Master Fernwick. He is your employer."

Finn was about to pronounce his correct title but Balor stopped him.

"I am to protect Master Fernwick's safety," Balor explained.

"And I am to lead you into your nightmares and deliver you safely home," Wey grinned slyly, still watching the boy.

"You will receive payment when the job is finished," Balor stated firmly.

"Does he do all your negotiating?"

Finn gawped unable to find anything to say.

"Master Fernwick is not used to dealing with people like yourself."

"But of course General you are." Wey took a tiresome breath, "Shall we begin?"

"We have horses in the stable."

"Then they'll sleep well tonight. We go on foot to Grenwich."

Finally a place Finn was familiar with. He was about to voice some offer of assistance when Balor interrupted.

"Grenwich! We need to be kept away from the militia. Our boat needs to leave Dark Haven."

"The militia have been drawn to Dark Haven like flies to shit these past few days. Probably waiting for your departure, if I may be so bold. We would never venture into Grenwich, to the Marble Docks themselves and wave to all those happy soldiers as we sailed away. Before we begin you will have to trust my decisions as none other than me will be making them." Wey smiled proudly and rose. "Let's go before the devils catch us."

Business in the tavern strengthened as night drew closer to morning. The noise began to rattle like thunder as laughing and fighting rolled across the tables. The doors swung open and closed consistently as the sly occupants of the Red Dragon conducted business and partook in

various activities of their leisure. In the chaos of the night the fiddler failed to notice the darkness spit out its inhabitants. He failed to notice the wolf exit the tavern with a chicken leg in his mouth.

Five

The Red Dragon, like most of the buildings in Hermia, was linked to a series of underground tunnels spreading throughout the island like a network of veins. The sturdy built escape routes in the heart of Hermia's mansion community were thought to be a well kept secret, each nobleman certain that his was the only tunnel running under the city's paved streets. Many would be absolutely horrified to know that the network was used by Hermia's criminal underworld to such an extent that the tunnels had evolved to meet the needs of smugglers and thieves alike.

Finn had always been aware of a secret passage from his father's bedroom but had never dreamed it linked his childhood home to every other in Hermia. Balor, of course, had escorted many gentleman and ladies through these routes, together with a number of whores and suppliers of various illegal substances, but that had been many years ago and the tunnels had since advanced beyond anything he could have imagined.

Subtle markings had been carved into the walls at important intervals, but were hidden among the graffiti and sword marks, ensuring only those who knew how to read the markings would end up at the correct destination. Wey touched the wall to check his route before marching with complete confidence into the tunnel. Their only light came from a neon fungus seeping through the cracks where the damp was strongest and Finn was sure he would never find the way back to the Inn or to anywhere else for that matter.

They walked for two hours without rest, which seemed to compliment all three men who were each deeply absorbed in their own thoughts. Balor watched their guide carefully, he was sure they would make it to the Vaults before he betrayed his employers and he was resolved to slit the man's throat as soon as he was in possession of the Princess. Finn focused on the floor, trying to keep his footing in the darkness and ignoring the strange piles of bones placed on the edges of the passage. Rats ran over his boots demanding to get ahead of him and he tried to take comfort that they were not fearful of what lay ahead. Wey listened to the footsteps above, behind and ahead of him.

The quality of the passages began to improve. Glazed clay bricks became foundations, whilst the neon fungus was replaced with oil lanterns. Finn felt himself grow more relaxed in this new, sophisticated escape route; Wey felt his shoulders tense. A difficult job lay ahead of them and the commotion in the tunnels around him started to make him uneasy.

"Who lights all these lanterns," Finn thought aloud.

Wey glanced over his shoulder, "Men who know better than to talk down here." He stopped in his tracks and cursed under his breath. "Lot of militia here tonight General."

Balor hadn't heard a sound but agreed. "Does this spoil your plans?"

“Plans?” Wey said smiling, “Why I could slit both your throats here and take those pretty purses no trouble.”

Finn’s heart sank in his chest, though strangely he was only concerned with not making it to the Vaults, the prospect of being murdered seemed minor in comparison.

Wey began to laugh. “Come here let me take a look at you.” He grabbed Finn and examined his thin face. Balor drew his sabre. “Easy, old man that’s no walking stick you’ve got there. Yes we may get away with it.”

“Get away with what?” Balor growled.

“Look at the boy’s eyes, why I’d think he’d never told a lie in his life be damned. And the clothes are a pretty fine match too.” He then turned to Balor, “General, your jacket and boots if you will.”

“What?”

Sighing Wey removed his own jacket, everybody needed an explanation nowadays, nobody could take him at his word. “Lady Heeley is on her death bed, she requires a priest, or at least she would if she wasn’t sworn to the Sands. Nevertheless at times such as these one may be entitled to a change of conscience, in which, privately of course, a priest may be called in.”

“Lady Heeley is not dying.”

“Oh trust me she is, cantankerous old bitch is riddled with the pox from her whoring days.”

Balor scowled, “What are you talking about? That is a Lady of the Court!”

Wey chuckled to himself, “A Lady of the Court? That is the whore of Lord Heeley, shipped in from Helena six years ago. The real Lady Heeley met an unfortunate end at the hands of some unknown assailant three years past.”

“Surely someone would know the difference,” Finn replied.

“Ah but that’s the beauty of it, the late Mrs Heeley was a recluse, she barely stepped foot outside her bed chamber.”

“How do you know all this?”

“It’s important for an unknown assailant to know everything. Now Master Fernwick you shall be a priest and I shall play your guard. Just chant some nonsense, that should convince them. We will then have a perfect route to our glamorous harbour.”

“And where shall I be in the charade?” Balor growled.

“You shall fetch us a carriage with Thorin here and we will leave the house by the main entrance, like proper decent folk.”

“Wouldn’t it make more sense if we all got the coach together?”

“My good man, every coach entering the plaza is searched for illegal exports nowadays. Where have you been, it’s a very untrustworthy place we live in at the moment. Empty taxis often

make their way to the harbour in readiness of docking vessels. Now off you go sir, I'm sure you can navigate these tunnels better than I and if not Thorin will take you to the nearest source of food he can find."

Thorin looked up hopeful.

"Finn… Master Fernwick stays with me."

"It's okay Balor. I think if there is a need for a priest I should go."

"That's the spirit. Come now, dying ladies don't hang around forever." Wey hummed to himself in the darkness; if there was one thing Egan Wey hated it was uncertainty and a little time alone with his employer would reveal all the cards in play so he could ensure the game was his to win.

Wey pulled himself up an iron staircase and banged on a large oak door. It was several minutes before the banging was answered. It gave him enough time to check his pistols were in place and that Finn's appearance was convincing. Finally a tall, sour looking gentleman stared at them from the open door.

"Yes?" He said with suspicion.

It would have been easy to stick a sabre in him and have done with it but that could cost Wey the job so the charade had to be played out. "Brother for you sir to see the Lady," he said innocently.

The man's face softened. He nodded and ushered the two men into the basement. "Who sent for you?"

Wey was trying to think of a name when Finn stepped in. "By letter, it was signed by the Lady herself, she requires absolute confidentiality. May I be permitted entry without the other servants seeing me?"

The man nodded, but eyed Wey apprehensively.

"My guardsman. The passages are no longer safe and he is a strong pair of hands to assist in the ritual."

"I can assist," the servant replied valiantly. Finn smiled at him, he was a fellow believer.

"My guardsman was cleansed at Temple friend. Although I understand your desire to help and if time was on our side I would cleanse you myself but I fear I must see to our Lady now. Perhaps you could set some candles in the kitchen and gather anyone who would care to help, I shall join you in mourning when it is time."

"Bless you Brother."

Finn touched the man's eyes and blessed him. Wey watched in awe. Suddenly the nervous boy had come alive in his role. He shook his head in astonishment as they headed on into the fine mansion. *Damn Thespians,* he thought.

Lady Heeley's bed chamber was located at the front of the house. The house itself was poorly lit due to Mrs Heeley's confinement, if it had been well lit the ignored housekeeping would be clearly noticeable and would not be rectified until Lady Heeley was dead and the staff were looking to be employed by the new master of the house. The darkness suited the midnight visitors as they scurried through the house like mice in a pantry.

A nursemaid sat outside the bed chamber dozing on a small chair. Finn gestured to leave her be and entered the room without knocking. He surprised himself with his own confidence; as a priest, this was the first time he had ever taken charge in any religious ritual. What was more unexpected was how natural it all felt, even given the circumstances. He turned to their servant companion and rested a reassuring hand on his shoulder.

"We will return to the kitchens when it is time."

The servant nodded dutifully and allowed Finn to approach the bed chamber and remove his jacket. Wey closed the door gently and listened for the hallway to empty. When he was satisfied everyone had left he smiled triumphantly. He turned to Finn who was already lighting the oil lamps.

As the room turned from black to yellow the finery of the surroundings were revealed. Large oil landscapes covered the walls like a tapestry of the kingdom. The furniture was lavish and heavily polished, holding trinkets and valuables of no purpose. In the centre of the room a large bed, adorned with silk drapes, hid the withering body of Lady Heeley. In her prime she had been one of the most beautiful women in Hermia but now she was little more than a hag. Her once glowing skin was covered in sores and boils and she stank of decay.

Her body lay limply beneath the covers delighting Wey. He watched as Finn neared the bed to light the final lamp and approached from the other side without making a noise. He removed his pistol from his holster.

The death rite had been turned into a complex ritual of chanting and cleansing. It had the potential to last for days if required, but in fact only a small mantra was needed for the soul to return to the spirits. The grandeur was to comfort and to impress those unfortunate enough to deal with death. As the new sciences overpowered Hermia's religious following the Temple had been forced to enhance the ceremonies, much to the disgust of many of the traditional priests like Finn. Regardless of his opinions on the matter, in Lady Heeley's room he had no equipment whatsoever and he was forced to perform the most basic rite. He turned to the corner of the room and began to wash his hands in the porcelain basin.

A gun was cocked. Finn froze, his hands still in the water.

“Put your hands where I can see them and turn around,” the woman said boldly.

He slowly pivoted to face her. Although the disease had eaten away at her flesh and hair, her eyes glowed with the fire of life. She pointed her pistol with complete confidence, unashamed of revealing her modesty. For a second Wey was invisible, but Finn suddenly caught his eye and saw he had secured himself in the drapes of her bed, his own pistol pointed at the back of her head. Quickly Finn turned back to Lady Heeley eager to conceal Wey’s position.

“What were you looking for thief? Jewels, gold, secrets?” She hissed.

“I am not a thief,” Finn replied coolly, “I am a priest and I was washing my hands before I began the death rite. I apologise I if I startled you.”

She spat at him, but missed and the glob of mucus and blood stuck to the floor. “Do you think I’m an idiot. I asked for no priest, Temple horseshit offends me.”

“I’m deeply sorry to hear that. I’m obviously here on a misapprehension.”

“Drop your weapon now,” she demanded.

“I only carry a ceremonial sword,” Finn replied much to Wey’s amusement.

Lady Heeley rose to her knees, as she did the pistol pointed at her moved too. “You are no priest, a liar knows a liar.”

“I assure you my Lady I am what I say I am.” Carefully he reached inside his collar and removed the small, unique amulet, hanging from a silver chain. The stone was from the Temple, stamped with a unique seal. With several slow steps he knelt by her bedside so she could inspect it.

“By the living thunder,” Wey muttered.

Lady Heeley turned her head as the butt of Wey’s gun smashed into her temple, knocking her unconscious. She slumped forward ungracefully whilst Wey removed her weapon.

Six

The tunnels were deceptively long in places and despite Balor's haste he was not making the progress he had hoped. The wolf had tried to lead for much of the way but Balor had ignored him, now he had calmed himself he stopped and allowed the wolf to take point. Annoyingly they were breathing fresh air in minutes.

Balor made his way quickly to the theatre. There were usually plenty of coachmen about there. Unfortunately that night he was disappointed to only find one, but one was better than none at all. He nodded to the wolf and together they marched to the driver.

"You there," Balor demanded, "Charlston Plaza post haste."

"Yeah you can piss off you drunk!" The coach driver grumbled.

Although Balor spoke like an officer, with an officer walk and officer pride he was dressed as a vagrant and smelt even worse. The wolf by his side and his borrowed attire had left him at the bottom of Hermia's social network. But there was one thing that could make even a King stand on one leg. Balor began patting the inside of Wey's jacket. The scoundrel had taken his purse as well. He cursed under his breath and stared hopefully at the coachman.

"My friend, I have a large purse of gold awaiting me in Charlston Plaza, half of which is yours if we can leave this instant."

"Aye but you see I've got a pot of gold at the end of a rainbow matey and I don't expect a few coins more would see me the better."

"Listen to me coachman," Balor growled, "I am the General Commander of the Third Division and I command the use of this coach."

"But I'm the General of the Third Division," the coachman sneered.

Balor sighed, one day he would meet a coachman he could abide. He drew his pistol and aimed it at the man, who had clearly been in this situation many times before.

"Dismount your carriage sir," Balor ordered impatiently.

The coachman sighed and slowly began to clamber down from the wagon, unsubtly reaching for the rusty crowbar that had got him out of these scrapes before. When his hands clasped the weapon he felt a sharp pain on the back of his neck.

Watched closely by the wolf Balor dragged the coachman's unconscious body onto the sidewalk before claiming his transport. He beckoned Thorin up to join him but the wolf was adamant he would ride in the back. Once he'd relented, and once Thorin was comfortable he made his way to Charlston Plaza.

“You’re a goddamn priest!” Wey said in bewilderment. “Let me have a look at that again.” He examined the seal in amazement. The brand itself was incredibly difficult to fake, and the amulets were impossible to sell on so only a fool would steal one. The boy had to be the genuine article.

Taking out his hipflask Wey took a strong gulp and laughed. “You know if you had mentioned that earlier I wouldn’t have had to worry about you getting us killed.” He started to laugh as the rum tickled the back of his throat. “A Minister’s son a priest! Well Brother, I’ll be damned.”

“Finn. Just Finn, please, at least until I return to Temple.”

“Well Finn, you have certainly gone up in my esteem, word had it all you rich folk had gone the way of Sand Science. Nice to see there are still some traditionalists at heart.”

“My mother was an avid follower of the Temple,” Finn murmured trying to disguise the pain. “Mr Wey?”

“Wey, just Wey,” he teased.

“Wey, Balor said you’ve been to the Vaults.”

“Did he now. Well he might just be telling you truths there.”

“How can the stories be true then?”

“The stories?” Wey said making his way to the window.

“That the screams of men deafen the prisoners, and that no man can escape and live. That rats feed on the bodies of criminals and crows circle the cells waiting for death.”

“Oh those stories, yeah most of them are true.”

“But you’re here, you escaped.”

“But am I living?” Wey whispered and allowed himself to be distracted by the street below.

“If they’re true how could Adiah survive it?”

“Is she bonny?”

“What?”

Wey sighed and finally gave the boy his full attention. “Is she a handsome girl?”

Finn thought back to the last time he had seen her. She seemed beautiful and he had heard others call her so, but all he remembered was sadness beyond her pale blue eyes. Eventually he nodded.

“Then there’s a chance,” Wey replied. “There’s a chance she’s alive, but she won’t be the same.” Hooves sounded on the cobbles outside. “But that my friend is not my problem. Here he comes. Let’s get a move on.”

Wey grabbed the limp body of Lady Heeley and began wrapping her tightly in the bedding. He used silk scarves from her dresser to tie the sheets together. Her body breathed heavily under her shroud.

“Let’s get moving before this bitch wakes up.”

“Where are we taking her?”

“For a spot of sight seeing, she’s been cooped up awfully long don’t you think?”

“Wey!” Finn demanded.

“Insurance policy. The state is still very susceptible to a gun pointed at a rich whore’s head, even if it is pissing puss everywhere. You grab the legs, there’s a lad.”

Clumsily the two men carted Lady Heeley down the stairs of her mansion. The house was alive with noise from the servants’ quarters as the staff were awaiting the news of their mistress’s death. Moving as quickly as possible Wey opened the door and heaved the body out onto the street. Finn followed, desperately trying not to injure their hostage.

Balor sat on top of the coach and glared at the body they were carrying. He understood many would have to die to return the Princess but to begin so early was a very bad omen. Wey bundled the body inside the carriage, kicking the alive corpse until she would fit, before clambering up to the top of the coach and beaming at Balor.

“Did you have to kill her?”

“She’s not dead General, just resting. No coachman?”

“Unconscious.” Balor replied coldly.

“Dandy, shall we?” He leant down to the side of the coach, “Hop in Finn and if she starts stirring hit her with something hard!”

The coachman grunted as his body was pulled along the bumps of the cobbles.

“Careful, he’s needed alive,” the Lieutenant whispered.

His companion shrugged and heaved the body into their cart with the other four.

“What is he?” The Lieutenant asked as he took out his notebook.

“Native,” the younger man replied.

“Good we can call it a night.”

Seven

A chorus of tortured wails amplified through the caves of the jagged prison rock as though the Vaults were labyrinths for banshees and sirens. Natural springs leaking through manmade cells kept a steady, unremitting, sardonic rhythm. Black carrion birds perched on barred openings, taking abrupt solos in the horrific symphony before breaking away with slices of human flesh for their ravenous young.

In the dim light of approaching dawn the illuminated rock struck the sea like lightening. A poorly constructed wooden skirt docking yard gave refuge to the commanders of prison ships and Vault guards, all eager to partake of the whorehouses and drink holes ungoverned by the Treaty. The Vaults stood as a testament to the broken law, as much a prison for criminals, as hell is for sinners. The darkest men graced both the cells and the guards' rooms ensuring the faint hearted were quickly broken and apportioned out.

The latest hangings began to draw the crows to the gallows. The furnace fired and the night began to roar as the recently dead were burnt and honey scented smoke pooled into the starry sky. The Vaults was now a chimney, glowing from its base with sparks spilling from its head, pushing out the souls of the damned.

Adiah's cell was reserved for the desirable prisoners; the sanitation and reasonable hospitality was in no way compensation for what awaited its guests. She had been shackled to the wall for more days than she could count. The strain on her body had weakened her muscles greatly, but the sustenance she received ensured her mind was as sharp as the day she arrived.

The barred doors and hole in the wall offered no escape. Rats wandered freely, while the walls seemed to be alive with running water. She had tried to escape her restraints and the effort had almost killed her. So far the rest of the Vaults had eluded her, but soon enough she would receive the honoured grand tour of its menacing facilities. The thought both inspired and terrified her. There was no escape from the cell, but outside, amid the maidens and thumbscrews there was hope.

A long series of metal locks turning signalled the return of her cellmate. She listened with relief and sympathy as the guards returned Lars to his damp, stone bed. Most of the crew had been executed aboard the *Pursuer* when it was first captured. Strong, noble seamen were shot without mercy whilst their younger, weaker comrades were made to watch. They separated the informants, who could now be seen hanging from the gallows with traitors and pirates, and the *useful,* who had once filled Adiah's cell.

The guards in the Vaults had particular tastes and surprising patience. Lars was a favourite; the young boy had been beaten, tortured and raped so many times, but never to the point of death.

He had been returned with broken bones, bleeding and unconscious, always in a recoverable state so he could be used again and again and again. The other young men and women had been depleted quickly and disposed of promptly until only Adiah remained. She could only assume her steady composure had turned them off her, but being the youngest of four captured women she feared they were saving her for when Lars was finally spent.

Lars was tossed inside the cell. He let out a faint moan as he hit the floor. The guard, a fat, bulbous man with boils covering his scarred, misshapen face entered the cell and stamped his foot on the boy's back. Something snapped. His keys jangled on a rope tied through his filthy, bloodstained trousers. Clumsily he reached for them and moved towards Adiah.

The stench of rotten meat and piss began to choke her as her shackles were unlocked. She fell to the floor and cried out in pain as blood pooled back into her arms. The guard reached out to touch her face with his rough, chapped hands before roughly running them over her breasts. The door was open, Adiah stared at the inviting exit. She was ready to go. The guard rammed her head into the wall and spat at her.

"Limber up bitch!" He growled as he left the cell.

She lay on the floor and waited for the room to stop circling. Gradually the pain in her head started to ease. Lars made a noise. It stirred her. Quickly she pulled herself up and crawled over to her friend. He opened his weary eyes and smiled at her. The teenager looked like an old man. He'd seen far too many horrors to maintain his innocence, his body ruined beyond repair.

"The pain's gone," he whispered.

"Sleep now lad, they'll let you rest tomorrow."

"The pain's all gone," he said contentedly. "I can't feel anything."

Adiah squeezed his hands, they were lifeless. "Lars, your hands are freezing!"

"They're fine, touch them."

She released him to wipe the tears from her eyes. Carefully she lifted him up and cradled him in her arms. His body was limp, his eyes fading.

"I'm sorry Captain, I think I may be dying."

"Shhh, don't talk such nonsense. You're just tired, close your eyes and in the morning we'll sail home."

"I'm not scared anymore. I want to see me Pa, I want to tell him I sailed on a ship."

"He'll be proud of you."

"You can escape," he mumbled, "The chimney…"

She closed his eyes and rested him on the floor. Alone in the cell she sat by the window to stop the crows coming in.

Eight

Grenwich Market erupted into life as the sun rose. The returning fishermen began docking and off-loading their catch into the surrounding warehouses. Finn had the opportunity to watch the turbulence unfold before him, fascinated by the large quantity of cargo that had been stored on the small ships. He stood in the centre of the market with only Thorin by his side. The others had gone to secure their journey out of Hermia, Wey to negotiate, Balor to satisfy his increasing paranoia.

Finn felt like he had been standing in the same spot his entire life. The events of the night before, even his life in the Temple couldn't ground themselves in this new reality. He couldn't deny his excitement, nor conceal his apprehension over what awaited him beyond the horizon.

From out of the crowd a hand grabbed him and pinned him to the wall of fresh tuna he had been standing beside. The stench of salty fish from the plates made him gag, but it was preferable to the sickly aroma coming from his ostentatiously dressed assaulter. Thorin growled from behind his attacker distracting him momentarily. It gave Finn enough time to scramble free. As he did he felt the tip of a blade on his neck. He stopped and stared the stranger in the eye. He was a tall, square man, who had used a quickly earned income to cover a lifetime of squalor. He wore clothes of the current fashion but without education or grace, making him look like a vagrant who had got lucky at the Temple handouts.

"Mr Wey?" He sneered.

Finn's eyes darted around the crowd. There were no familiar faces near him.

"No sir," he finally said.

The man scowled, not wanting to believe Finn. He had known this wasn't the rogue he had searched all of Hermia for but he had to be sure. Wolves had been known to wear sheep fleece.

"The wolf yours?"

Thorin growled again, ready to pounce if the need arose, although he knew from experience that it was wiser to wait for all the discourse to be concluded first.

"Yes sir," Finn replied, "Since he was a pup. Though he's a mongrel not a wolf, people often make that mistake."

Returning his blade clumsily to its sheath he smiled revealing two rows of rotten teeth. Thorin relaxed and sidled up to Finn.

"My apologies lad, I've been searching for that murdering son of a whore for six months now."

"Murdering?" Finn covered his mouth as soon as he heard the words. He was sure he'd slipped up.

“Aye, killed half my crew and stole my cargo too. I swore if I ever came across the scoundrel I’d slit his throat from ear to ear,” he made the slitting gesture with his chunky fingers.

If he thought about Wey too much Finn would certainly find aspects to his character he frowned upon. The past few hours together were already shrouded in immoral activities, but murder? Could he really be such a man? Finn knew the answer before he even formed the question. Wey was a man with blood on his hands and he had no intention of washing it off.

“Well lad you wouldn’t be looking for work by chance, I have an opening on my vessel for just your type.”

“Ah no sir, I am…” he paused, unable to think of a convincing lie.

A commotion in the distance disturbed the whole market. Like a ripple in the water the crowd moved back then forwards towards the isolated carriage in the distance. Finn felt his face blush.

The stranger reached out to grab a young runner who was making his way quickly from the scene and drew the small boy close to him.

“What occurs?” He demanded.

“Crazy woman, kicking and screaming. They’re dragging her off to Farnworth House now!”

The stranger released the boy and shook Finn’s hand, “This my friend I must see. If you ever need work let me know, Mr Sprig’s my name.”

“Mr Sprig,” Finn shouted, “Are you sure it was a Mr Wey?”

“As sure as I am the sun will rise tomorrow.” With that he was another face in the market.

Finn slumped down to scratch the fur on top of Thorin’s head. He looked into the wolf’s eyes for answers until he heard his name being called from a nearby ship.

Balor was calling for him from a small schooner. The *Hope and Glory* sat, almost pitifully, amidst the more glorious ships of Hermia. Wey was talking to the stocky Captain, shaking hands and laughing. Even Balor seemed at ease as Finn approached, if only he knew the monster they were travelling with.

Nine

Captain Harold Hardy was extremely excited by his guests. They paid far more than was needed, which meant they were in a hurry to leave discreetly. He would of course oblige them, but Hardy was as loyal as an alley cat and upon his return to Hermia he would wait until the authorities approached him and take a handsome fee for his information. They were a strange collection of men, and he had transported many unsavoury sorts out of Hermia, so many he was considering it as an advertising slogan. The negotiator, Mr Wey, was the usual type, although surprisingly he was travelling as a passenger and not posing as crew; his type often did for free passage. The old soldier, not that he confessed to his profession, kept to himself and seemed at loggerheads with his criminal companion. Then there was the boy, almost gentle in his nature but carrying a huge weight and totally out of his depth on this shoreline. Captain Hardy was sure it was going to make for an interesting voyage.

In actual fact he was wrong. The voyage was oddly uneventful. Weather conditions were perfect and the traffic at an unthreatening distance. The schooner made good time and the crew seemed to be in good spirits. Mainly the guests confined themselves to their quarters and rarely ventured out together. The wolf however stayed on deck, at ease among the sailors. Mr Wey was seen the most and had inspected the schooner with amusement. He drank with the sailors and could understand the sailing jargon that so far eluded Captain Hardy.

Balor was also at ease on the ocean, not because he found the waves soothing, but because he knew for the moment he would not be betrayed or caught. Since the Minister had taken him into his council Balor had suffered from insomnia. The gift he kept in his breast pocket had been burning him since he received it and after locking his cabin door he removed his jacket and took out the vial of red liquid. It looked like blood and when it was presented to him that was what he thought he was holding. Now it was just wickedness. There was movement outside his cabin and quickly he restored his jacket and the vial to their rightful places.

The footsteps weren't heading his way, instead they were about to disturb Wey's peaceful slumber. He'd spent the night drinking and was now suffering badly. Resting back on the bed he tried to convince himself he felt no pain, but the throbbing in his temples was hard to ignore.

Wey's door was never locked, not because he felt safe on the boat, but because he always preferred his only exit to be free of as many obstacles as possible. Thorin was snoring beside him until a knock at the door interrupted them both. Wey groaned an indistinguishable obscenity but the knocking persisted.

"You'll be over side with a gut full of shot if you keep that up," he muttered as he pulled open the door.

Finn stood there defiantly. Obviously last night he had grown a spine and was exploiting it to its full advantage in a strict, disapproving stance.

"Finn," Wey said unable to fake a smile. "What a delightful surprise?"

"I need to speak to you."

Dropping his shoulders Wey relented and allowed the boy into his cabin. There was barely enough room for the two of them and neither were willing to sit down with the other standing over.

"What ails thee Brother?" Wey teased.

"I met a man in Grenwich, he was looking for you."

The innocence had evaporated from Finn's voice and had been replaced with something stronger. Wey knew instantly this was not a time for playing with his employer and that perhaps he had underestimated him.

"Did you indeed," he stepped away from Finn wishing he was out of the cabin altogether.

"He said you stole his cargo."

Wey rolled his eyes, there wasn't a ship in Grenwich he hadn't ripped off at least once in his life.

"And murdered half his crew."

Although there weren't too many of those.

"Was he telling the truth?"

"That depends who the talkative fellow happened to be."

"A Mr Sprig."

Behind his indignant exposure he was sighing in relief. "Oh Mr Sprig. Sprightly Mr Sprig."

"Is it true?"

"In part."

Finn was getting flustered. "Which part?"

"I stole his cargo, in a way, and I killed his crew in a way." Wey took a deep breath and watched as Finn's frown began to implode. "I take it Mr Sprig failed to mention what his cargo was? Of course he did. What dear Mr Sprig didn't tell you was his cargo was a shipment of Fimorri women captured off the mainland coast. They were being transported to be sold on the Pink Carpet."

"The Pink Carpet?"

Wey smiled at the boy's restored innocence, "When you next visit a whorehouse look down. Anyway I set them free, which would mean I did steal his bloody cargo. Unfortunately he hadn't read the rule book on Fimorri women and when they were unleashed they took vengeance on the crew members that chose to violate them. So in a way I suppose I am responsible for the deaths of eight slave capturing rapists. I'm sorry if that means we can no longer work together."

“You didn’t actually kill any of them?”

Wey thought back, “I shot two of them.” Slowly he faced Finn daring him to show disapproval. “Just like I’ll shoot anyone who gets in our way, or stab, or strangle or do whatever I need to. Do you have a problem with that Brother?”

Of course Finn had a problem. The whole concept was smashing his morals to pieces. He wanted to object, to sit down and show Wey the error of his ways but he needed Wey as he was. To retrieve Adiah he would need a ruthless hurricane.

“I do if you intend to betray us like you did Mr Sprig.”

“I was never in Sprig’s service, I was despatched by one of the fathers of the women. Sprig was merely a casualty.” Wey sat down on the bed basking in his clear victory. “Finnian you’re entering dark waters now, there are a lot of things you’re not going to like.”

Nodding his head Finn turned to leave, but stopped in the doorway.

“If you had been working for Mr Sprig, kidnapping those women, would you have betrayed him?”

In another situation Wey would have lied but on this occasion he didn’t need to. “They were my sisters Finn of course I would.”

“Good.”

“Finn word of advice, while you’re sailing with me you’re not a priest, you’re not rich and you’re not the son of a Minister. You a barnacle, and we have one goal to achieve, nothing else stands in the way you hear me.”

Finn nodded. He left the room feeling more confused than ever. He didn’t want to dislike Wey, but he felt he was obliged to do so. His crimes could not be atoned by rescuing one princess, but who else would help? Finn took a walk on deck that night, weighing up his options. He removed his amulet and let it glimmer in the oil light. He looked at the swirling, indigo water. Dark shadows moved around the boat, either sea monsters or tricks of the night. Finn watched them, feeling a deep fear and curiosity luring him into the water. The boat rocked and his amulet dropped from his hands. He gasped as it hit the water and quickly moved away from the edge of the boat before the darkness swallowed any more of him.

Ten

***H**ope and Harmony* docked in the large port of Petra off the eastern coast of Helena. The port was alive with fresh trade and excitement as the ships came and went as quickly as the wind changed. Business, pleasure, tourism and pilgrimage populated the harbour like flies to a carcass. It was a perfect chaos to get lost in, a thought that had never occurred to Captain Hardy as he watched his passengers disembark from his vessel and make for the nearest tavern. He made a note in his journal of their destination and returned to his work.

As soon as Wey felt the eyes leave his frame he led his employer out of the tavern and into the market. Quickly he advised Finn to purchase some food supplies and then led them all away from the dock into the surrounding wilderness. Thorin took point on their trek into the dense foliage, leading them into safe isolation. Petra was purely a stop gap for ships, trading in bulk rather than on an individual basis. There were few homes around the area, most located around the harbour and not within the acres of marshy woodland beyond the small village. After an hour's walking they reached a small clearing that Wey was familiar with. There was shelter from the elements but a clear view of the harbour and all that passed through it.

Balor began to gather dry wood from the nearby bushes.

"No fire," Wey said. "We're camouflaged as long as there's no light here."

"It will be cold tonight," Balor replied.

"If you're worried about your bones you can have my coat," Wey taunted.

"I was concerned about Master Finn," Balor murmured angrily.

"It's okay, priests have to meditate in the snow as well as in the sweltering heat!" Finn exclaimed proudly.

Wey made himself comfortable on the grass, Thorin joining him. Eventually Finn sat near them, but allowed himself a good view of the harbour. He'd never been to Helena and had been hugely disappointed at its similarity with his homeland. Slowly Balor bent down to sit, trying to disguise the pain in his knees.

"So what do we do now?" Finn asked apprehensively.

"Now we eat and wait for dark. Then we will pass the point of no return, we either succeed or it'll be the gallows for us all," he said cheerfully.

Neither Balor nor Finn wanted to be the first to ask what Wey had planned and both sat in the grip of a tense silence until Wey released them.

"We make for the road and hijack the first noble carriage we come across. Most folk travel with at least two guards. We will rob them and take their places on the ship they are meeting."

"How will we know they're meeting a ship?"

Wey tensed his muscles and hid his inner repulsion. “The Vaults opens its doors the first of every month to noble gentlemen with certain requirements. The journey takes three days after a stop in Juliet.”

“Are you that sure a noble man will take this path?” Balor scoffed.

“My friend,” Wey said darkly, “I’ve seen several gentlemen take this path already.”

Balor rose wincing as he did so, “I’ll be a few moments,” he said to Finn reassuringly and disappeared into the bushes to relieve himself.

Finn opened his food package and began to apportion the contents into four. Thorin licked his black lips.

“You don’t want to go back to the Vaults do you?” Finn said in a whisper.

Wey forced a laugh, “You find me a man who does, I’ll find you a doctor who will drag him off to Farnworth House!”

“I don’t want to go. I remember the stories when I was a boy. But they’re just stories.”

“Brother Finn everything you have heard about the Vaults is true and worse. The most terrifying nightmare you ever had is bliss compared to what you will see there.”

“Then why are you going back?”

He frowned, it was a question he had thought would be easy to bluff, but he found himself giving a far more honest reply. “If I can get just one person out it will make up for the six months I spent there.”

“You were there six months!”

“Once for six months, once for six days.”

“How did you escape?”

His frown brightened, “That my friend would be telling.”

Finn sighed, “I’m sorry you have to go back there,” he said genuinely, “And I’m sorry the thought of it brings you so much pain.”

“Pain!” Wey said, “Don’t be soft lad, you don’t come out of that place with any feelings at all. Come on cut me I’ll wager the devil’s ransom I won’t flinch.” He held out a small penknife but Finn shook his head.

“Do you think Adiah’s alive?”

“It would be better for her if she died.”

Finn gulped.

“She won’t make you much of wife,” Wey told him bluntly.

“A wife!” Finn shook his head, “No I don’t want a wife! I’m a priest!”

“Then why risk a hanging for her? I’m here for the money, old Balor’s here for the blind obedience, where do you fall into this if not for the prize at the end of it?”

Glancing at the cured meat in his hand Finn replied, “We’re friends. Good friends.”

He was a terrible liar and Wey saw through him as though he were a pool of water. He bit into his fresh bread and examined the boy. In a few days the light in Finn’s eyes would fade, the weight he carried would be unbearable and nothing of his innocence would remain. Wey couldn’t decide whether it was a good thing or a bad.

Lord Grisedale sat in his coach looking at the pocket watch his father had passed down to him. It was gold plated and elaborately engraved. He studied the hands closely in the dimly lit coach. They were running on time, if Grisedale was a smiling man he would have cracked his stony face. Shuffling around in his seat he removed a child’s shoe from behind his back. The small leather boot was his youngest daughter’s. He ran his fingers over the laces before banging on the roof of the coach. Quickly the coach came to a halt.

“Baxer!” Lord Grisedale shouted in his coarse, raspy voice.

“Yes my Lord,” Baxer clambered down from the coach and poked his head through the coach window.

“This,” he said holding the boot in the air as though it were poisonous. “Remove it.”

“Yes my Lord,” Baxer said taking the tiny boot off his master.

“And the footman, have him shot.”

Baxer nodded, “Of course.”

“Make sure the new footman keeps the children out of my coach. I do not want their things with me on my excursions.”

Baxer wandered off into the bushes to dispose of the offending item.

Wey had heard the coach stop. It was still in darkness beyond the road and he knew time was running out.

“General how are those knees at stealth?” He whispered to Balor.

“What do you want me to do?”

“There will be two guards and a gentleman. You secure the gentleman, while I draw the guards’ attention.”

Balor agreed and set off, silently into the night. Wey closed his eyes and listened for a few moments until he was satisfied Balor wasn’t going to let him down with his creaking joints.

“What shall I do?” Finn asked in an excited whisper.

“You stay hidden, nobody wants to be saved tonight.”

Wey made his way onto the road and strode towards the coach as though it were a welcoming tavern. He drew his pistols as he approached the stationary coach. There were two

guards, as he had predicted and the passenger looked to still be in the carriage itself. There were several reasons the coach could have stopped and Wey considered and discarded each of them as his invisibility began to fade. Whatever the reason he could accommodate it.

"Good evening gentlemen," Wey said pointing two pistols at the guards. It would be easier to kill them, but he didn't want to get blood on their clothes. "Hands in the air my friends, this is a robbery. You both behave and you get to live."

There was a scuffling from the coach as Balor pulled the Lord from his seat and dragged him out into the open. He was surprisingly strong for a man of his age and, despite the Lord being twice his weight Balor held him firmly in place with a knife pressed against his throat.

"Gentlemen your clothes and valuables on the floor if you would be so kind," Wey said to the guards. "Weapons first." The guards carried only one rifle each together with a sabre, these were thrown in front of the coach. They undressed calmly, almost as though they were enjoying the whole robbery.

Wey felt a stab in his back. He straightened up and raised his hands amused. Baxer held the sword firmly, he looked at Balor.

"Release his Lordship," he demanded.

"He won't," Wey whispered, "He'd rather see me dead and steal everything for himself, here take my gun, shoot him."

"I will ask you one more time release him or I shall kill you both."

Balor readied his blade.

"Kill them Baxer!" Lord Grisedale ordered.

Wey closed his eyes; he'd heard that name before. Baxer was part of the special guard, one of the nasty ones too. He knew all of Wey's tricks and he would be able to counteract them to his advantage every time. Wey swore under his breath and braced himself for the impending pain… *of all the coaches.*

Baxer held a small flick knife in his concealed hand, he was aiming at the older man, ready to unleash both his weapons at the same time when he heard a noise. He lashed around ready to cut down the third thief and his sword clashed with another. Quickly he gained his composure and began to attack the young man, but his steps couldn't keep up. The young man would not attack him but led him further away from the coach in an ancient square dance. The experienced swordsman was no match for the priest. He could find no holes in the boy's skill or style. Infuriated and challenged he pursued his attacker and the rest of the robbery faded into obscurity.

Wasting no time Wey fired both of his weapons at the remaining undressed guards. They fell from the coach like apples from a tree. Quickly he turned to look at the fight continuing down the road. Finn moved like a divine wind. He handled a sword like he had been born with it welded

to his arm and, as it pierced through Baxer's heart, Wey and Balor realised they had underestimated their faithful companion.

"Everything okay there Brother?" Wey shouted.

Finn had dropped to his knees over Baxer's body. He had never killed a man before. The fight had consumed him beyond all consequence and now the outcome stared him hard in the face, unchangeable, unfixable. It was his choice to rescue Adiah and he would have to deal with the blood on his hands for years to come. Mourning would come when his part was over and he would make penance for every life that had to be taken. He swallowed, promising the corpse a memorial when he returned to Temple and forcing himself to show the hardness Adiah would need to be liberated.

"Everything is finished," Finn replied and he joined Wey.

"Right then, lets see if our Lordship is in the mood for a little chat." Wey came face to face with Lord Grisedale and grinned through his hatred. The Lord was defiant against his captors, until Balor cut through the first lair of skin on his purple throat.

"Well sir, your name if you will, I'd hurry if I was you, before the arthritis starts up in my friend's hand and he can't hold that blade steady anymore."

"Grisedale. Lord Grisedale."

"The Lord Grisedale and where might you be off to on this lonely night. In fact I'm quite sure I know. You're going to tell me the name of your boat, then you are going to remove your clothes and think long and hard about the type of man you are."

"You will burn in hell for this."

"Then you will be in great company my Lord. Now I believe you were kindly going to donate to us your clothes."

Reluctantly Lord Grisedale began to undress, removing his long velvet cloak, jewels and expensive wig. He stood in his undergarments, shivering in the cold.

"Get the bodies off the road," Wey ordered Finn.

When he was out of ear shot Wey drew his pistol and pointed it at the quivering Lord's belly. "Just so we're clear, if you do not tell me what I want to know I will pop a hole in your belly and leave you here to bleed to death!" He smiled. "Now the name of the boat and Captain if you please."

"*The Virgin Queen* under Captain Batty," he said through gritted teeth.

"And what did you reserve?"

His eyes narrowed.

"Come now we're all men of the world here."

"A noble girl."

“Of course,” Wey muttered under his breath. “Good night your Lordship.” He smacked the butt of his gun across the Lord’s face and watched as he fell backwards.

“Are you going to leave him alive?” Balor asked surprised.

“They’ll be after us for sure if they think we murdered a Lord.”

“He knows what we look like and where we’re heading,” Balor murmured, sensing Finn coming closer.

“Do you think he’ll be eager to tell the authorities why he had a boat waiting to take him to the Vaults? He won’t say anything. Now let’s get to it.”

Captain Batty was nervous, he didn’t like being late and he didn’t like waiting in the middle of the night like a low life criminal. He had half a mind to sail without his guests, but the money he would lose would make the past week entirely wasted. Since the Qatarians stopped trading with the islands his business had fallen beyond comprehension. He found himself taking the Vault contracts just to stay afloat and it left a very bitter taste in his mouth. Supplying the Vaults was one thing, but the gentlemen that now took an interest in his vessel were an entirely different level of evil. He was in no position to refuse them or the money, but morally he was in turmoil.

He spied a coach entering the dock and he watched as two men unloaded a large ornate trunk followed by a well dressed gentleman. They boarded the boat quickly and greeted the Captain with unusual cheerfulness.

“Captain Batty,” Wey said, filling out his guard’s uniform perfectly; “Allow me to present Lord Grisedale.”

Balor stepped forward holding Thorin on an elaborately decorated leash and collar made from the real Lord’s jewellery and clothing. Balor was suffocating under his velvet cloak, sweat ran down his face and he wiped it with a silk handkerchief. The crew on deck were looking at him through the corners of their judgemental eyes and he understood why. It made him feel filthy to be dressed in such an unsavoury way and he blamed Wey entirely.

“Cabin’s all set up,” Batty muttered gesturing to one of his men to take the luggage and show his Lordship down to his suite (the cabin he had specially equipped for men such as Lord Grisedale).

Balor and Finn went below deck and would remain there for the whole voyage. Captain Batty had no interest in mingling with his guests and he advised his crew to follow his example. Wey, on the other hand, was trying to make a contact and get a feel for the crew and their position in this whole affair. He remained on deck as the ship departed.

They were on a cargo ship, but that made sense. The ship was too small to cause much offence on the ocean. It was discreet and accommodating, but it was in no way welcoming. The

crew avoided Wey despite his obvious charisma among sailors and the Captain watched him with absolute scrutiny. When Wey finally got chance to talk with Batty he understood why.

"So you're on the Vault contracts, business must be slow," Wey said knowing Captains naturally like to complain about the state of business whether they've got dust or gold in their pockets.

Batty shrugged.

"You're making port at Juliet to pick up supplies?" Juliet, being the nearest island to the Vaults was a usual stopping port for most of the prison ships.

"We picked up supplies in Petra," Batty mumbled looking for an emergency he needed to attend to. "Nobody stops in Juliet much now."

Wey nodded logging the information in his head for future use. "Our contact in the Vaults," Wey began.

"Don't deal with Silas," Batty hissed sharply. "What your master conducts on that rock has nothing to do with me or my crew. We're just carrying barnacles from one island to another, no crime in that."

Batty stared at Wey, trying to break him with his own integrity and feeling as guilty as every man he had ever transported to that place. Wey patted his shoulder and smiled, calculating the new information into his plan. He left the Captain assured he had now secured safe passage out of the Vaults.

"I don't think he likes his costume," Finn said trying to ease Thorin's collar.

"He's not the only one," Balor said removing his cloak and wiping the sweat from his neck.

"Wey said we should leave everything on."

"Well Mr Wey is not paying me." Balor sat down on the small, but accommodating bed in his cabin. "You did very well this evening Finn."

Finn had never thought of killing anyone as a particularly positive way to spend an evening and he certainly wasn't proud of himself. The evening happened and they were still on their way to rescue Adiah, things were promising but the dark waters were turning red and Finn struggled to ignore them.

"I didn't realise they still taught combat in the Temple."

"It's part of us understanding our ability to move within the elements." Finn explained modestly. "And it allows us to hit each other without remorse. Perhaps, when all of this is done with, you'd like to sit in on a class?"

"I would be very grateful," Balor replied.

The door burst open and Wey slipped inside with a wide grin on his dirty face. He leapt on the bed, pushing Balor out of the way. Instinctively Thorin climbed beside his friend, securing the second most comfortable place on the ship.

"We dock at the Vaults in four days," he began. "We'll meet with the Honourable Harlik Silas and if we are lucky he shall take us to your girl. Wake me when we eat."

Eleven

The floor was rough and cold. It soothed the swollen bruises on Adiah's face. She pressed her skin against the surface relishing the pain and the relief. Her cell was empty; Lars' body having been disposed of and she knew her own grains of sand were slipping away. There was no fear anymore, nothing could be worse than what had been and she had begun to acclimatise herself with the nightmare. Her only concern was her death. She knew she didn't want to die like Lars, not at their mercy. She would die fighting, with dignity and she would do it when they next took her.

The Honourable Harlik Silas had managed to crawl out of the bowels of hell and create his own underworld to rule. He was a leech on the Vaults, a merciless, vicious cowardly slug. There was not a man in the world that would be condemned for cutting a hole in his fat, bloated gut and not a man in the world that didn't wish Silas was sent back to his master. Wey tried to contain himself as he stood in the rank pit of his office.

"Your Lordship," he snorted, "Only paid me half."

"My Lordship has paid you full and has given me no authorisation to negotiate on his behalf."

Silas began to laugh which petered out into an unhealthy coughing fit. "Very well, she's as he likes them anyway. Nobody else would take her now." He wiped a thick layer of mucus across his finely tailored, but filthy jacket before flattening down the few strands of black hair on top of his greasy head. It took him several moments to shift his huge bulk, but that was all for Wey's benefit. If he wanted to he could wield a sword as well any noble man or humble priest.

"What happened to Baxer?" He said as he led Wey through a tunnel of carved rock.

"My Lord dispatched him."

Silas stopped in his tracks and glared at Wey suspiciously.

"He caught him with his daughter," Wey replied in a gossiping whisper.

Satisfied, Silas continued down the tunnel, his huge bulk blocking all forthcoming light. Wey mapped the passage way in his head, he would endeavour to avoid this place but it was important to remember every available exit. They reached a crossroad in the tunnel, iron doors lining the right, oil lamps the left. Silas gestured to the far end and gave Wey the key.

"Tell your master she's the Princess of Hermia," he said gloatingly. "I will not get one as high as her for a long time."

"You do my master a great kindness," he replied smugly.

Wey ushered Finn and Balor quickly into the tunnels as Silas had showed him. The tunnel itself was sealed off from the rest of the Vaults, the prisoners being carried in transportable Iron Maidens from their cells. Wey had never been worthy of these rooms, although he knew they existed.

He stopped Finn and Balor at the door, holding the handle in a shaking fist. Neither of his companions were particularly affected by the Vaults, that was about to radically change.

"Finn you guard the door," he said, securing reassurance from Balor with one stern glare.

"Aye lad, best not to confuse her straightaway, we'll go in, explain the situation and call you in."

"But I have been trained as a doctor, I could…"

"Aye boy," Balor said patting his back. "Few minutes will hurt nothing."

Reluctantly Finn stood by the door and let his companions enter. The dimly lit corridor smothered him in silence.

Wey and Balor were men of the world. They had seen active combat, done regrettable things, watched horrors unfold. As they entered they both stopped dead. They grew cold. And afraid. And sick. Instinctively Balor threw off his disguise and tried to disassociate himself with the disfigured body on the table. Wey swallowed hard and looked at four bandaged, bloody stumps, missing arms and legs. She was strapped to the bench by her waist, to keep her from hitting the floor rather than escaping. A thin, sleeveless gown covered most of her body, but kept her cold and lucid.

"Adiah?" Balor said unable to comprehend what he was seeing.

She opened her eyes and turned to him. Opening her mouth she tried to speak, and choked on the emptiness where her tongue had been. Her eyes pleaded for mercy, left to mirror horrors she had endured.

"How could they?"

"No worse monster than a man." Wey moved to the Princess and rested a hand on her feverish forehead. "It's over now lamb, we've come to save you." The words he spoke were hollow. He felt the butt of his pistol dig into his hip.

"What do I tell Finn?" Balor murmured out loud.

The door opened before either man had time to decide. Finn strode through, trying to contain his excitement. He looked to Balor, to Wey and finally to the piece of girl on the bench in the centre of the room. The colour faded from his face as he approached. Wey was waiting for him to bolt. He held his ground, kneeling beside the girl and joined his hand beside Wey's.

"This isn't her," he whispered.

"What?" Wey exclaimed in relief and frustration.

Finn bent close to the girl, "What's your name?" He bent close to her mouth.

Leigh.

"They think you are Princess Adiah, do you know that?"

She nodded.

"I am a friend of Adiah's from Hermia, is she still here?"

Torture, for Helena.

"You have been very brave."

Kill me.

"We will look after you," Finn assured her.

Kill me.

Finn smiled sadly. "Leigh, I am a priest. It would be my honour to give you the death rite."

With tears falling from her face, she nodded and tried to smile.

Wey gently put his hand over her nose and mouth while Finn prayed. Her body jerked slightly before going limp. Wey removed his hand and quickly moved away from the body. The room, the sight of the young man grieving, the mutilated woman, were all too much.

"If she's still alive," Balor said, preventing Wey from escaping.

"Then she'll be inside." Wey hissed trying to hold his nerve. "Stay here until sunrise then take Finn to the boat."

"What are you going to do?"

"I'm going to visit some old friends."

"Wey!" Finn said abruptly turning from the bench, "Be careful."

Going back inside the Vaults terrified Wey. He would wake in cold sweats just dreaming about the place. It made him feel nauseous; it made him angry. His body urged him as far away from the rock as possible and his senses were in a frenzy at his disobedience. The euthanasia of Leigh, seeing Silas, Lord Grisedale, all of it fuelled his darker side. He ignited a fire within. A tumultuous storm brewed beneath his eyes.

Marching onto the deck of the *Virgin Queen* he was a stranger to the crew. Captain Batty flew over to him ready to evict him from the ship until he recognised the uniform and the traces of the passenger he had ferried.

"I told you I want no part in your night…"

"And I'm telling you that you want every part in this night." Wey said darkly. "I am not a bodyguard. None of us are who you think we are. We came here to rescue a girl. A girl imprisoned and we have only a few hours to get her out."

"Why are you telling me this?"

"Because you need to make penance Captain, I can see it in your eyes. You're going to help me."

Batty removed his hat, his heart pounded in excitement. “You’re going to break her out of the Vaults, that’s crazy.”

Wey grinned insanely, “Allow me to introduce myself Captain. They call me Wey.”

There was a man inside the Honourable Harlik Silas’ office that looked very much like Egan Wey. He exuded a repulsive, sinister nature like most of Silas’ contacts and was utterly convincing in his requests and motives.

“Of course we’ll be happy to oblige you,” Silas said pocketing the bag of silver coins beneath his many folds of clothing and skin and gestured to one of his men to take command of the *situation*. Silas had never been inside the Vaults and had no intention of correcting his ignorance.

Orma Potter led Wey through the hollowed tunnels of the Vaults. He took the direct route to the interrogation room, avoiding the numerous cells in the beehive prison. Potter had a swagger to his step and gloated with his guest, believing him to be a man after his own heart.

“This one is the last one we got alive from that Helena boat. I tell you she’s a fighter. Juke, that’s my superior, doesn’t much care for the fighters, but I like a bit of life. It’s better when they’re thrashing about, like a fish.”

“How many were on the boat?” Wey asked coldly.

“About a dozen, I think, but we only got the useful ones.” He withdrew a large chain of keys and selected one with large iron teeth. “Here we go,” he said licking his cracked lips.

The interrogation room hadn’t changed since Wey was last there, only this time he was standing over a young girl with eyes as black as his own. Her arms and legs were bound by blood stained ropes and she was gagged, which meant she had bitten one of the guards before. There were bruises on her face and limbs but she seemed intact and able to move.

Potter wiped the pale, blonde hair from her sweat drenched face. “Pretty too, not that they care about that.” He bent down to her ear, “Hello poppet,” he said, “We’ve come to play.”

“Me first,” Wey said adamantly and marched over to the bench, barging Potter out of the way. Without hesitation he clambered on top of the girl feeling her body tense as he did so. He moved his hands quickly, Potter didn’t notice the small knife he’d removed from his jacket, not until he’d sliced through the ropes, jumped from the bench and stabbed him in the chest. The guard fell back staring at the blade protruding from the bleeding hole in his torso.

Adiah sprung into action. She pulled herself up, freed her feet, removed her gag and leapt off the bench. One of the men was kneeling over the other, checking his pulse. There was a truncheon in the corner of the room, dirty and dented. It found its way into her hands and she mustered the strength to bring it down on the second man. Panting, afraid she looked around the room. There was

only one door, no windows and a small chimney shaft that led down to the cremation furnaces. Hesitantly she approached the bleeding man and rifled through his pockets for his keys. He died as she found them.

The metal in her hands made her want to laugh. She had planned to kill them and die herself, not escape. The excitement was confusing. A hand grabbed her barefoot. She dropped the keys and scrambled away from the door. The man she had knocked out was coming around. He tried to get up and stumbled, holding his hand out to her. She pressed herself against the chimney shaft, where they threw the prisoners that expired early. Without thinking she pushed herself inside. A small beacon of light shone many metres above her. She was so tired and weak. The furnace was quiet, there was no smoke where there should have been and it made her nervous. The man began to clamber through the shaft beneath her. Instinctively she climbed.

Wey pushed his body into the chimney. She was ahead of him, three or four metres above his head. He closed his eyes to stop the spinning concussion. Below he could hear them preparing the new fires. Each week it was the same routine, clear the bones, restock the fires, but the process was quicker than Wey had remembered. By his calculations they should have had another hour, not a handful of minutes. He lifted his arms to move and vomited as the dizziness took over.

The pain surged through his temples. He forced himself higher, moving quickly, remembering the foot holes and the difficult spots. Crackling echoed through the chimney. They weren't going to make it. She was too slow, slipping back as much as she had climbed several times. To his side there was a new crack in the chimney, Wey surveyed it quickly. It passed through two of the four chimneys. Wey grabbed her leg and brought her clambering down to the crack. She fought him back, stamping on his face and hands. Suddenly she realised the smoke was rising. She panicked. Turning to climb again she saw the gap. Blind panic drove her through it and she was unexpectedly breathing fresher air, spurring her further into her ascent.

Wey wanted to cheer in satisfaction but the smoke clogged in his lungs. He tried to squeeze through the crack but his broad shoulders stopped him. Taking a deep breath of the unpolluted air he returned to his smoking pipe and climbed without hesitation.

Adiah pulled herself out of the chimney and looked around. There was nothing but sea. Struggling for breath, she tried to compose herself. Then *he* joined her, black and coughing. She backed away from him, but he grabbed her. Even though he could barely stand he managed to hold her and suddenly they were falling off the Vaults. She closed her eyes satisfied she had done her best.

Twelve

The light was warm and there was a gentle motion beneath her. Warm, soft bedding embraced her sore body. She smelt of salt and her hair was still damp from the sea. *It's not the cell* she told herself, trying to stop the rising terror. A hand touched her forehead and she sat up ready to defend herself. Then she recognised a face she thought she would never see again.

"Finn!" She cried falling into his arms, "Finn, I…" She couldn't form any further words.

"You're safe now," he told her softly.

"How did you get here?"

"I had some help," he said smiling. "Rest now. Nothing's going to harm you."

The medicine Finn and Balor had given her made her think she was dying for the first night on the *Virgin Queen*. She bled profusely, vomited, had an awful fever, but by the morning she awoke feeling energised. Her body ached from the escape but she was invigorated after a night's rest. Warm food in her belly steadied her weakened composure. She was free. She was alive.

By the second day Finn was rewarded for his efforts. She sat up in her bed, fresh faced and ready to tell him about her time in Helena, about her uncle and her time at sea. Finn listened with enthusiasm, never daring to ask her about the Vaults, or the capture, or anything that might remind her of the terrible event, despite Balor pressing the issue.

"Does she have any idea why she was taken?" Balor whispered in the corridor.

"She hasn't said," Finn murmured, "It's not right to ask yet." He walked away from Balor and into Adiah's cabin.

She smiled when she saw him. She was wearing an old, but clean shirt and a pair of sailor's trousers, loaned to her by one of the crew. Some of the men at the Vaults had taken locks of her hair, and with her head being riddled with lice Balor had hacked off the rest. She looked almost boyish, with her figure disguised beneath her new masculine clothing.

"Finn, come in sit down, I had a dream last night, remember when we went to that ball, I dreamt that we were there, only I was dressed like this and you wouldn't dance with me." She laughed.

"If you remember you were dressed in a grand blue dress and I still wouldn't dance with you."

"That's a lie," she said, "You took two dances with me and you stamped on my feet so many times I could barely walk in the morning." Her blue eyes clouded, "That seems like a life time ago. What do you think our old selves would say if we told them we'd be sailing the seas together, dressed like this?"

Finn sat down on the bed, finally able to relax now he had done his duty.

"Thank you for coming for me," she said seriously.

"Did you think I would leave you there?" He asked alarmed.

She shook her head and looked around her cabin. "I think it's about time I meet the Captain. Would you ask him to come to me so I can thank him for his hospitality?"

Finn had found Captain Batty and sent him down to Adiah's cabin. He had barely had contact with the rest of the crew since Adiah arrived, despite their sudden generosity. He felt terribly guilty, even worse so when he spied Wey leaning against this ship's mast. He had been so preoccupied with Adiah he had forgotten the man that had actually saved her. Ashamedly he approached Wey.

"They're a good crew," Finn said to break the ice.

"Aye, not bad. Your girl okay?"

"Thanks to you, she should be fine."

Wey shrugged. "You know what she did to get herself into that mess?"

"She hasn't told me about what happened."

Wey understood perfectly. "Probably won't. Question is my friend, are you going to push her?"

"I don't understand."

"Word of advice, forget this whole thing if you want it to work. It'll always be there, can't get rid of something like that, but it'll destroy you if you let it."

Finn wasn't sure what he was being told, "I don't…"

Taking him aside Wey put his arm around the priest and Finn could smell the liquor on his breath. "When you lay with her Finn you have to forget what happened. For both your sakes."

"Lay? No, Wey, I'm not…"

Wey pressed his finger to Finn's lips, "My friend! You have to, who will have her now?"

He told himself the man had been drinking and he could imagine why, but he couldn't face that type of talk with him. Quickly he went below deck and returned to the cabin he was sharing with Wey and Balor. Memories of his own came flooding back and he realised that the return home was going to become even more complicated than the rescue.

When the Captain left Adiah found herself grow in confidence. She didn't buckle under the pressure of having another man near her. She wasn't afraid of the crew and the allure of fresh sea air grew too much for her. When Finn didn't return to her cabin she decided to find him.

Dusk had just set, leaving a magenta sky and a small scattering of stars above her. Lanterns glowed across the deck and three crew men kept second dog watch across the darkening ocean,

clasping cups of hot whisky and lime. Adiah smiled at them and they returned the courtesy, respectfully keeping their distance. She walked up the starboard watching the water lovingly, until she saw a shadow slumped in the distance. Her nerve almost buckled, she remembered him so clearly and how terrified she had been of him.

Before she could get back to her cabin he looked at her. He stared at her, seeing exactly what she was, not a princess, or a damsel in distress, but the girl on the bench ready to give up. She swallowed hard and approached the man, smelling the beer steeping into his clothes.

"Mr Wey?" She asked with a quivering voice.

"Princess," he slurred, "You must forgive me but my legs have since departed. You see the trouble with being a hero is everyone wants to buy you a drink." He gulped down another tankard of ale.

"Thank you," she said, "I am…"

"Of course," Wey continued as he had done most of the night. "Pretty girl like you, needs rescuing everyone wants to help, everyone wants to wed a princess in a tower, but they don't understand do they. They don't know what it's like. You see that Finn, nice enough kid, bit simple, but he thinks it's all going to be easy now. Marry you, live happily ever after, but you can't because you've been in that place."

"Finn doesn't want to marry me!" Adiah exclaimed.

"Sweetheart, a fellow doesn't give up his life, sail halfway across the ocean for a girl he doesn't want to bed or wed."

Adiah shook her head angrily, "You're drunk you don't know what you're talking about. Finn is my friend."

Wey held up his bottle and toasted her. "So do they still keep the heads hooked in the passageways?"

She backed away from him before turning and running back to her cabin. Her stomach churned. She was furious and scared and confused, with a head swimming with lies and truths and possibilities. The drunk was right, friends didn't behave in such a way, but Finn had always been different. The idea of being a wife, of having someone else touching her made her tremble. Then the feeling overpowered her and she vomited in her room.

Frantically she paced the floor until Finn finally arrived. He too wasn't in the best of moods and on seeing her he grew even wearier.

"Hey what's wrong?" He said trying to take hold of her and failing miserably.

"I can't be your wife Finn. I love you I really do but I could never marry you."

"Good," he replied a little stunned. "I'd hate to disappoint."

She stopped pacing. “What?”

“I can’t marry you, of course I can’t. When we get home I’ve got to return to Temple.”

“But Mr Wey said…”

“Wey?”

“He said no friend would go to the lengths you have. Not without wanting something in return.”

He cast his eyes to the floor. “Then he doesn’t know me.”

“You’re lying to me!” She exclaimed. “Finn why did you come all this way?”

“To save you.”

“Tell me the truth.”

“I honestly don’t want to marry you or anything of the sort.”

“But you’re hiding something.”

“It’s not important.”

“Finn!”

“My father told me to come.”

“If your father told you to rescue me you’d still be in Temple,” she said dismissively.

Finn took a deep breath, he had no loyalty to his father, in fact all he truly cared about was with him. “He told me you’re my sister!”

He was expecting tears, or anger. She just sat with him staring blankly at the wall.

“He told me your mother and he, well that you are his daughter.”

Gradually she smiled. “And he wanted to rescue me? You both set out to rescue me.” Tears ran down her face. “I thought my family had abandoned me. Oh Finn, are you telling me the truth? That man, that King he has nothing to do with me?”

“I thought this would devastate you.”

She leaned forward and kissed his head. “What more could I ask for in a brother?”

“Father said this should stay a secret, in case it jeopardised your heritage.”

“To hell with my heritage,” she laughed. “I’m free.”

Thirteen

The palace had been the pride of Hermia: a rare construction of island marble and Sands glass. The surrounding town cowered, being just an unworthy mass of cobbles and slate. It had shone as a beacon to the Triad of Islands and Sands; a mixture of the old and the new, glass and stone. It held treasures, unseen by most, and it held secrets like all grand buildings. Only now the secrets were unravelling into the large crystal passageways.

The palace was rotting from the inside. The walls were dirty and stained green with mould. Any riches within were worthless in the new world the palace had been dragged into, most were now scattered, uncared for or broken throughout the empty rooms. A stench carried through the hallways, telling signs of further decay. Food had been left to rot, encouraging rats that scurried across the carpets, confidently leaving a trail of piss where they went.

It had been forbidden to have Qatarian or mixed blood slaves; such an act was considered a violation of their rights. Even the mixed blood were far too valued and respected to be incorporated, involuntarily into the royal household. So the King had filled his rooms with captured natives, the savages that dared oppose the Triad. Only now they were nearly all gone and what was left had been instructed to tend to the Prince and only the Prince.

Prince Conrad sat in his father's chair in the great hall. He chewed his fingernails as he watched the soldiers around him. They were losing their usefulness and would have to be dispatched back into the general fodder of his army. It didn't matter; he was more than capable of making decisions without them. In the corner of the hall *she* sat. She had made the space her own and he knew it was best if he kept out of it. Her coherency had begun to falter again and it would take her a while to get back to his world.

He rose from his premature throne and strode over to the table, the top of which was strewn with charts. His six generals were poking at them with scrutiny. They muttered to themselves disguising the fact they were all starting to go through withdrawal and would soon be desperate for the Red once more. Prince Conrad had little patience for the addiction.

Conrad threw his bony shoulders back. His tall, slender figure was no match for the bulky men around him, but his sharp, birdlike features held an even sharper mind that could slice them in half. He wore expensive clothes, but he had been wearing them all week and saw no opportunity to change, and his skin craved cleansing water, but he needed to show determination and he needed to watch his untamed men.

The great doors were flung open. Conrad lifted his head in alarm. Pandora, his personal officer, marched in with her own trail of intoxicated naval officers. She strode with confidence to the Prince, her own body, like his, was pure from any foreign chemicals. Her black hair was tied

back and she was dressed like a convincing gentleman. She matched the Prince in height and weight, but he was her master, his word was final.

"Pandora," he said, pleased to be around a real person again, "Your mission is completed?"

"In part," she said. "Mercy took the prisoners to the Vaults. They were in less than good condition. They isolated your sister, but she was unable to provide the information you wanted, even with much persuasion."

Conrad ground his teeth. "Well that is unhelpful."

"There's more," Pandora said calmly.

"More! They should have killed her!" His eyes narrowed. "What did they do with her Pandora?"

"I received word two days after I left the Vaults that they had transferred your sister to the dungeons and had a commission for her. From a Lord."

It was a minor irritation and nothing he hadn't expected from that cretin Silas. He could see there was more.

"Go on," he growled.

"A ship docked, men disguised as nobles entered the Vaults and a prisoner was removed."

"A prisoner?"

"Mercy got the wrong girl. I inspected the body of the Princess, she was not the Princess. It appears your sister was acting as Captain on her ship and thrown in with the rest of the crew. The intruders that arrived at the Vaults took her with them."

His eyes grew wide. He flung the charts off the table in a screaming rage. "What possible reason could they have for taking her! What good is she to anyone!"

Pandora stared stony faced.

"Who took her?" He yelled. "Who took her Pandora?"

"My intelligence says it was a priest, a soldier and a Fimorri by the name of Wey. He appears to be guiding the group."

"Then get me this Wey, I want to see his head on this table immediately!"

Pandora bowed her head. "I have already despatched a ship to intercept them. Your sister your highness?"

"Bring her as well," he said, his eyes glowing with malice, "I shall extract the knowledge myself!"

Fourteen

A storm was approaching, encouraging Wey to sober up quickly. He could smell the churning sea and feel a growing breeze on his face. Captain Batty agreed with his sentiments and they plotted a course for the Isle of Juliet. If they travelled swiftly they would be safely docked before the storm hit.

The crew burst into life. Noise and chaos overwhelmed the deck. The ship began to turn towards its destination. Batty bellowed out orders and each was followed with skilled accuracy. Wey assisted the crew and the noise had stirred Balor and Finn from the cabin, who watched with impressed confusion.

"That storm is on the way lads! Let's get to dry land before she kisses us!" Batty yelled merrily.

"Wey! What's happening?" Balor shouted across the deck.

"Bad weather on the horizon General, thought it best to make port till she passes."

Balor felt a prickle of nerves up the back of his neck. Having Adiah in his care he was now desperate to return her to safety and have done with this part of the mission. He was also quite convinced Wey was about to betray them and it seemed the crew of the *Virgin Queen* and the weather itself were all ready to assist him.

"Can we help?" Finn asked succumbing to the excitement.

Before Wey could think of a reply a voice sounded across the deck, "Ship Ahoy."

The crew paused, giving way to the approaching hammering of rain on water. Captain Batty put a telescope to his eye and surveyed the blemish on the grey ocean. His face paled and he realised the seriousness of what he had done. Most of his crew had been with him for years, loyal and dedicated. They stayed despite the harder work load and the reduction in pay, despite the long months away from their families and nearly all had families desperate for their income. He swallowed.

"What are the colours Captain?" Mr James, the quartermaster murmured, his own heart beating in rhythm with the rest of the crew.

"Hermia Royal Navy," Batty replied with a dry mouth.

Wey eyed the ship suspiciously. Hermia's Navy rarely patrolled the North Sea, not without specific request or purpose.

"Hide the Princess," he murmured to Balor, "You know where they won't find her."

Balor nodded.

"General, make sure the crew don't see," he said under his breath.

“You think the crew have betrayed us?” Finn gasped.

“Master Finn,” he said purposely dropping the Brother, “I will betray you when they start hammering pins under my fingernails.” He launched himself up to the poop deck, Finn behind him. “Captain, prepare for boarding.”

“Are you mad man?”

“What do you have to hide Captain? You’re just a cargo ship making your way to Helena aren’t you?”

“And the girl?”

“What girl?” Wey replied sternly. “If they don’t believe you they will search the ship, but how can they find what isn’t here?”

Knowing he had no choice the Captain yelled his orders at the terrified crew and watched as they tried to go about orderly business with eyes as guilty as every sinner in the Vaults.

“Finn come here,” he took his small knife and punctured some holes in Finn’s shirt and coat. “Get in with the crew and try to blend in as best you can.”

“What’s happening?”

“The Navy is going to board, they’re going to ask our Captain about the recent visit to the Vaults and then they’re going to leave. We will continue to make port for Juliet and then we get off this ship for good. We’ve cursed these sailors long enough.”

Fifteen

Commodore Hastings clenched his fists tightly around the ship's helm. He could barely contain his fury, or his lust. His ship tore through the ocean, like a cutlass through silk, towards the *Virgin Queen*. His crew, his naval force, was working rhythmically, salivating droplets of red liquid from their mouths. Hastings had stopped breathing and as his mind dizzied he remembered to inhale.

One of his crew had fallen overboard and thrashed about in the sea desperate to catch up with his ship until he was pulled beneath the waves and devoured by the elements. Hastings had watched the officer fall but held no thoughts other than the capture of the men on *that* ship. The capture of the dangerous, treacherous men who would seek to harm his ruler, who would prevent him receiving his reward. He wiped away the red crystals forming under his nose with the back of his fraying sleeve.

All of the officers were tattered and weathered. Their uniforms were unkempt, stained and pinned together carelessly. The men themselves operating as a single unit, as it had been drilled into them to function, but the unit itself was disorientated and unstably driven towards one goal; forsake all else.

"Prepare to board!" Hastings yelled.

Captain Batty waited at the helm of his ship casually. He had composed himself and in turn his crew had followed in kind. He waited calmly as the ship drew nearer and then his eyes opened wide when he saw what was about to happen. The navy ship collided with his own, knocking several of his crew off their feet. Shocked and outraged he surveyed the ship with surprise. The deck was in disarray, unclean, cluttered and pillaring dangerously supported masts. The crew glared at him hungrily. He afforded a quick glance to Wey, who was gawping, like the rest of his crew at the sight and he wasn't convinced Wey was acting.

There was no communication from either side. Batty had been boarded once before by the Hermian Navy and this bore no comparison. A sickly Commodore and several men clambered aboard using a makeshift plank, leering at the trade sailors. Mr James, being the eldest of the crew took the opportunity to introduce the crews to each other. He approached one of the soldiers, as was the tradition.

"Mr James Quartermaster under Captain Batty of the *Virgin Queen*."

The shot made everyone jump. James fell to the floor, half his skull spattered across his friends and crew mates. Finn felt the moisture hit his face and froze. The half-headed body oozed blood and brain onto the deck. Wey shook his head at Captain Batty who was reaching for his weapon. The crew dropped everything in their possession and held up their hands.

“I am Captain of this ship!” Batty shouted, brimming with anger and distress. He tried to ignore the corpse of a man he had known for over twelve years as the officers were doing. “What is this about?”

“Line up the prisoners!” Hastings shouted.

Wey again gave Batty a warning look to comply. The *Virgin Queen’s* crew huddled together and were pushed into a line across the deck. The youngest was forced to sit by his dead mate and sobbed uncontrollably. Finn and Wey kneeled beside each other, their hands tied tightly behind their backs. Wey spotted Thorin waiting beneath the ship’s netting. Only his glowing eyes visible.

Hastings strode up the deck, his eyes were bloodshot and his nose had started to ooze red liquid again.

“We know you are harbouring criminals on this boat Captain!” He yelled. “If you tell us where they are I will let you and your crew live.” That was a lie and nobody believed it.

Batty thrust his head back and said steadily: “This is a cargo vessel, we are heading for Helena under the contract of the Westwick Brewery. Feel free to search for any stowaways but I assure you I can vouch for every one of my crew’s honesty and integrity. We are all law abiding, tax paying, sea folk Officer.”

Hastings began to laugh, “Search the ship!”

One of his officers remained, manoeuvring himself behind the captured crew. He was smiling insanely.

“I ask you again Captain.”

Wey spotted a figure on the navy ship. She was dressed in a uniform and appeared on deck for just a second, before disappearing below. Wey suppressed a smile. Finn had spotted her too and couldn’t believe the Officers seemed oblivious to her arrival.

“She’ll be safe for the minute,” Wey whispered.

“Captain!” Hastings screeched in a voice that sounded as though his vocal cords were shredding inside his throat.

“This is a cargo vessel, we are heading for Helena…”

A shot was fired. The young lad stopped sobbing as his body joined Mr James. Their blood mingled together, seeping into the deck like wood stain. Finn was sure the other men would cave now. He wanted them to speak up and save themselves. The responsibility had never been theirs and now they would die helping!

“Captain tell me where Mr Wey is!”

Wey’s ears pricked up. They were after him personally. He tried to stop his frown, tried to organise he thoughts. He stared at the navy ship, at the girl he had just handed over to them and he knew he had been betrayed.

“Balor,” he hissed through gritted teeth.

The barrel of a freshly loaded gun pressed against the back of his neck. He was about to speak, when his words were stolen from him.

“I’m Wey!” Finn shouted boldly.

They moved unnaturally fast, hauling Finn up and dragging him over to the main mast. Tying him to it, they slashed his shirt, and viciously flogged him before Wey could react. This was wrong, this was all wrong. Finn ignored the questions being yelled at him: *Where are the others? Where is the girl*? He ignored the pain and began his mantras.

“Batty,” Wey whispered desperately, “These are not real soldiers.”

Batty was in a catatonic state. He heard Wey’s words and he looked up at the soldiers ransacking his ship. He glanced over at his crew and knew that they were all going to be murdered. One girl had brought about their downfall. He smiled; there were no regrets.

Batty pulled himself up, eight of his crew, eight ordinary sailors, followed. They stared the armed soldiers in the face and, hands tied behind their backs, they attacked.

Wey dragged himself up and cut his hands loose from the cutlass of one of the fallen soldiers. He stabbed the officer flogging Finn, who collapsed to the floor, unable to stand. Wey unbound his hands and he fell free of the mast.

“Why did you do that you stupid bastard?” Wey yelled shaking him conscious.

“Get Adiah. Protect her, please, Wey,” Finn said pushing him away.

“Thorin!” Wey yelled, “Guard that boy with your life,” he said before leaping across to the navy ship.

The soldiers were untrained beasts descending on the sailors. They tore, bit, stabbed and ripped at the sailor’s bodies. The sailors had nothing to lose. They withstood everything and fought back with the weapons of the fallen. They could not win, but they could hold out and as the rain plummeted down on to the blood soaked ship they knew they had another fighting their cause.

The sea picked up quickly, separating the two boats. Uncoordinated soldiers charged at the gap between the ships, many being crushed under the rising waves. A wave hit the navy ship while the wind anchored its unmanned sails and it began to capsize under the storm. Wey stumbled across the deck, attacking the small force that confronted him. He cut through each of them, taking small wounds from each battle. With both ships unmanned they collided, the *Virgin Queen* began to take on water.

Wey hurried through the enemy ship. Soldiers tried to cling onto the boat as the waves crashed over them. Lightening struck the sky. Wey skidded below deck. He clambered through the mess below, wanting to call out and being concerned about drawing the wrong attention. There

were so many places to hide. The ship struck another wave. Lightening flashed again and Wey could smell fire nearby. He hurried, being thrown into walls and barrels.

When the boat overturned she knew she was in trouble. Balor had told her she was to lay low on deck until the search was over. He said to watch the boats and wait until the soldiers started to return, then jump ship and wait for them to find her. It seemed impossible at the time and more so now. She hid from the soldiers, instead of blending in, unnoticed. Now she was lost. Memories swamped her, forcing her to stop and panic. She'd watched half her crew being murdered by *him*; the ogre, and she was powerless.

Someone was down in the brig with her!

Wey felt the plank of wood hit the back of his head. He stumbled but maintained his consciousness. Pulling himself up he quickly turned to catch the plank.

"If you keep hitting me I'm going to stop saving you," he growled.

She dropped the wood, unsure of whether seeing Wey was a blessing or not.

"Where's Finn?"

"Being a hero," Wey answered distastefully. "You can swim right?"

She scowled.

PART II

One

"Drink this, it'll help." Water touched Finn's lips.

"Laura have you been here all day?"

"Just this afternoon, he stirred earlier."

"Ma says be down for dinner. She's got some scraps for the dog too."

"Maybe he'll be awake by then." A door closed. "That was Da again, if you were wondering. We got some mackerel for dinner, Ma cooks it up beautifully." Sigh. "I wish you'd wake up soon. Right let me read some more."

The fire in his bed chamber had reclined to tired embers allowing the chill to return once more. Moonlight seeped into his room illuminating his frosty breath from the bed sheets. He slipped out of the thick velvet bedding, his bare feet numbing on the cold marble floor. Finding the door handle he tiptoed out into the hallway. Snow was falling thickly from a black sky, like fallen stars surrounding his home.

Finn's feet padded softly to the courtyard. Snow fell heavier, creating a blanket of silence around him. He stepped out into the white, ignoring the pain of the ice against his soles. The world was slowing and with each step he aged, until he was an elderly man in an eight-year-old body.

His beautiful mother lay in the fountain, folds of her purple dress protruded from underneath her icy duvet. The finger tips that poked through the snow were blue against the frozen red ice around the buried wrists. Finn stepped closer until he could see her violet lips, pursed into the air. Her eyes glared up accusingly at the balcony of the Minister's bedroom, fixed, unforgiving, forever. Finn followed the gaze until he saw his father, frozen at his bedroom door. One of the servants screamed and pulled him from the cold.

Two

Wey rested on the sand. He told himself he needed to move, but his body was in conflict. If he reached out he could feel Adiah near him. He thought she was alive, he just need to confirm it. Almost all his weapons were lost at sea, except for his pistols, which were secured in their holsters, but with gunpowder as wet as his boots they were utterly useless.

Slowly he began to roll over and inspected Adiah's deep breathing from a distance. He remembered the dive from the ship. They had clutched onto the topside of a barrel for over an hour before the storm eased. By that time she was exhausted and he had no choice but to drag her across the ocean himself.

Dawn would break soon and he needed a new plan. He pulled himself up and began to search for some firewood. The light could draw unwanted attention, but the hypothermia would kill them both.

He collected driftwood and tried not to think about Finn or Thorin. His wolf had been at his side for years and he wasn't sure whether rescuing Adiah over him was a wise thing to do. There was a chance, he knew there was a chance and he would hold onto it as long as he needed to keep going.

When Adiah awoke she was alone. The dark sea lapped at her feet tenderly. She was shivering and hungry. Her mind was confusing the two attacks, she saw Finn and Lars, dead, alive; she wasn't sure. There were two men after her; Wey and the giant. Now she was alone. She pulled her knees up to her chest and stared out at the deceptively tranquil ocean.

"I'm going to come near you so please don't do anything that's going to draw blood."

She looked behind her and watched as Wey built a fire further up the beach. He lit it quickly and the warmth drew her closer.

"You hurt?"

She shook her head staring at the flames.

"No me neither," Wey said checking himself, "Nothing noticeable anyway, nice of you to take an interest though." He poked the fire.

Finn's actions were playing heavily on his mind and his mood. He couldn't believe the boy's stupidity. Now he was indebted and it annoyed him greatly, almost as much as Balor's betrayal.

"What happened to Finn?" Adiah finally said once she'd separated the two incidents.

"Finn?" Wey shook his head, "The stupid bastard said he was me and got a flogging. Why would he do that?"

"Were you in trouble?"

Wey waved her comment away, when was he not in trouble. “He owed me nothing.”

“You saved me,” she replied coldly.

“Yeah and he paid me to do that. Mind you he hasn’t fully paid me yet.”

“Finn spoke very highly of you,” she said dubiously. “But he would do that for anyone. He did it for me.”

“Well I just hope he doesn’t expect the same gratitude,” he said, gauging her reaction.

Adiah turned away and ignored the comment. “Is he dead?”

Wey shrugged, knowing if he said yes he would be admitting Thorin was dead too. “Ship sank,” he said blankly. “But Thorin was with him and he’s come out of worse.”

“Whose Thorin?”

“A friend.”

The flames licked at the sky, ceremonially welcoming their mother sun. The sunrise itself was disguised behind the cliffs around them, but the pink clouds in the sky twisted beautifully overhead, keeping them quiet and at peace for a little while.

Wey patted his damp leg, “Right let’s get moving.”

“What!”

“Come on we haven’t got all day.” He jumped to his feet.

“Where are you going?” She asked as he moved away.

“To eat, to warm and to drink.”

She stayed put knowing he wouldn’t leave her.

“Are you coming?” He said impatiently.

“No. I’m staying here.”

“Forever?” He mocked.

“You’ve done your job. I’m safe, now you can go.”

He stomped through the sand back to her and yanked her up by her arm. “Princess, unfortunately I am indebted to your bonny lad to keep you safe and as he is still holding a nice fortune for me I’ll be keeping you by my side until I find him. So you will come with me, you will do what I say and you’ll pretend to have a merry ol’ time whilst you‘re at it.”

She glared at him, “Or what?”

“Or I will tie you up, put you in a sack and carry you! Now I’m in the mood for a spot of breakfast, what do you think?”

“I hate you.”

He blew her a kiss.

Juliet sat on a pillar of cliffs and hills. From the shore line of the island it was a treacherous journey up the rocky barrier. Wey studied it closely before dismissing it as an option. He had confidence in his own abilities, but absolutely none in Adiah's. She had barely spoken to him since she awoke and, although he was finding the silence blissful, it was beginning to concern him. If she let the shock set in, they'd never make it out of Juliet and he was desperate to return home and be rid of the whole sorry affair.

"Looks like climbing is out of the question," he said cheerfully. "Right lets try somewhere else." He led her away from the cliffs.

Adiah followed. She had no choice but that didn't mean she had to accept it. Every time he spoke or looked at her she remembered the Vaults and it was tearing her apart. She wanted Finn back, so much she could barely contain the tears and the longer she spent away from him the less likely it seemed she would see him again.

They walked until the sun began to set and then a little further, fuelled by Wey's misguided optimism. Eventually he succumbed to the night and permitted them to rest and make a fire. He had foraged throughout their walk, although the bounty was quite pitiful. As he began to divide it up he realised he was making Thorin a portion. Quickly he stopped himself and tried to shake off his silliness.

"Eat," he told Adiah, passing her the cooked limpets and muscles.

"Not hungry," she murmured.

"You have to eat if we're going to make it to civilisation tomorrow," he replied nonchalantly.

She turned away from him defiantly.

Taking a deep breath he calmed his irritation, "Princess, I am well aware this isn't caviar and quail eggs, but I assure you it tastes inoffensive and might just put some meat on your bones."

"I said I am not hungry!" She growled.

He laughed, "Sorry, I must have been unclear darling. Eat the food or I will force feed each mouthful and anything you happen to spew up in the process." He watched victoriously as she began to nibble on the pieces of shellfish he handed to her. "That's a good girl. Now see not so bad is it."

The food went down but weighed heavily on Adiah's stomach. The drugs Finn had given her were still working in her gut and even the thought of eating made her queasy. Wey didn't understand. The brute could never comprehend what she had been through and his endless battling with her was driving her to despair. His barbaric methods were going to get them both killed and she wasn't going to stand for it. She swallowed hard and resolved to take charge. She was a Captain once and a Princess before that, he was not going to ignore her.

“We need to find Finn,” she said boldly, “We’ll search the coast for him tomorrow at first light.”

Wey raised his brow and his face turned into an impish gremlin in the firelight, “Will we indeed.”

“Yes we will. This is not a joke Mr Wey. Finn saved your life you owe it to him to make sure he’s okay.”

“Funny, saving lives doesn’t count for a whole lot anymore. I assumed I could just treat him with contempt if he should show his face again.”

She folded her arms, “Who the hell are you anyway? You’re not the sort Finn would associate himself with.”

Tilting his head he caught a glimpse of the fire in her eyes. Suddenly what little they left her with was growing again. He leaned back in admiration.

“Just a humble servant Princess; just a servant.”

“Servants do as their masters tell them.”

“Aye. When my master shows up wake me will you.” He settled in for the night by the fire.

“You are insufferable.”

“Smoke and mirrors, Princess. Get some sleep you don’t want to enter Juliet looking like a bunter.”

“We’re searching for Finn tomorrow,” she said to the snoring man on the opposite side of the fire.

Three

Finn opened his eyes feeling the cold of the snow he had dreamt. He rubbed the sleep from his face and saw a woman's hands attached to his arms. There was a pain in his head and darkness he couldn't understand. Somebody touched him, forced a cup of water to his lips. He could hear a voice, a soft familiar voice that calmed him. Quenching his thirst he drew his attention to the source.

His breath was suddenly taken when he saw her. He must have seen beauty before, but there were no memories, no feelings of admiration he could conjure up from his past. She was a flower, the sun, the night sky and better still. Her hair flowed in thick locks of chestnut and her eyes shone like galaxies. She held his hand in her own, grounding him in reality, grounding him in the small empty room with the vase of poppies by his bed.

"Where am I?" He gasped, his own voice sounding too deep.

"You're safe, on a farm in Juliet," she said softly. "My father pulled you out of the sea in the storm. Are you a sailor?"

"I…" He paused. "I don't know."

"Do you know your name?"

"Finn, Finnian Fernwick."

"Do you remember anything else?"

When he closed his eyes he could see the snow again. He shuddered involuntarily. "I was a boy. Eight." He scratched his head, feeling long strands of hair, where he had expected short. "I can't remember."

"What about your dog, do you remember him?" She gestured to the wolf at the end of the bed.

Thorin grunted in acknowledgement before returning to his sleep. Guiltily Finn shook his head.

"Da says the dog saved your life. Kept your head out of the water until they got you onto the boat."

"I'm sorry," Finn replied, "I don't remember anything."

She smiled sympathetically, "I'm sure you will in time. Are you hungry?"

He nodded although he felt sick rather than hungry.

She rose eagerly, "Wait here, I'll be back in a second."

"What's your name?" Finn asked quickly.

"Laura."

Four

The second morning on the beach was much more welcoming to the strangers. It was a warmer day, with a sincere promise of good weather to come. Wey was up first and poked the dying embers of their fire with a piece of charred wood. Adiah slept soundly through all of his bustling and deliberate attempts at disruption. Eventually he relented and knelt beside her.

She was nothing but skin and bones, although he could see traces of old muscle in her arms that shouldn't have graced the body of a noble woman. He also saw a tattoo on the top of her shoulder of a silhouetted ship. The mark had probably saved her life, upon seeing it (and they would see it) nobody would suspect her of being anything more than a common sailor. Gently he rested his hand on her arm. She leapt away from him, putting one hand in the burning embers. She yelled and tried to run. Wey leapt after her and tackled her to the ground.

"Get away from me!" She screamed.

"I'm not going to hurt you," he told her honestly and calmly. "You know me, I'm Wey and I'm here to protect you. In a second I'm going to get off you and you'll be free to go wherever you want, but you are going to come with me and I'm going to make your hand better. Understand?"

She nodded. Slowly he released her and helped her to her feet. Her surroundings began to make sense and embarrassment set in. Wey led her to the shoreline and cleansed her sore hand in the waves. She flinched every time he touched her and saw his hands were trembling too.

He looked at himself and sighed, "Need a drink. Let me have a look."

She showed him her palm and he was careful not to touch her more than was necessary.

"It's not too bad. Keep it clean, when we make it to civilisation we'll dress it."

"We were going to look for Finn," she murmured, her eyes glassy and distracted.

"Aye we will but not today. Another night out here would likely kill us and then we're no good to anybody."

In silence they agreed and began to look for another way off the beach. It took them several hours before they came across a possible route up. A crack had appeared through the cliff, big enough for them to fit inside and jagged almost like stairs. Wey and Adiah stared at it, both trying to assess the other's capabilities.

"Shouldn't we be moving?" Adiah said finally.

"Not with your hand like that Princess."

"I can withstand a little pain."

Wey shrugged, too eager to be off the beach to question her further. It should have been an easy assent but Adiah's disability and inability to be touched made everything impractical. Wey used all of his strength to heave her up through the crack and for the first time was grateful that they

starved her in the Vaults. She was stronger than he thought, but lessons on rock climbing had never been considered suitable for noble ladies and she stumbled several times with inexperience. They were half way up and Wey could feel himself getting tired.

"I can't do this," he gasped looking down at her. "You're going to have to hold on to me."

"I don't need your help."

"And I don't need to scoop you up and carry you back home in a satchel. If you hold onto me I can be up there in minutes," he replied panting. "I can't keep coming down after you."

"I…" She realised she could neither make it up or down without his help, still the thought of going near him chilled her. "Okay," she said determinedly.

He wrapped her arms around his shoulders and began to haul her up the fissure like a marsupial. Her displeasure was apparent with every move he made but she resisted the urge to battle against him. Finally his hands reached the grassy surface of the cliff top and gave one final push. Collapsing on the floor he released Adiah and closed his eyes.

"Rum, we need rum."

From the cliff top they could see the entire island. Adiah stood up in amazement, fields of blood red flowers unrolled in front of her, surrounded by an arch of naval ships engulfing the small isle. She had been to Juliet before and could remember the barley, wheat and corn fields fondly, but these were now just blemishes amidst a crimson blanket.

"Mr Wey," she said kneeling beside him. "Mr Wey look at this."

Wey lay sprawled on the grass with his eyes closed. As he heard his name he slowly opened his eyelids and blinked in the sunshine.

"Look at the fields," she insisted.

He quickly scrambled to his feet and took in the scenery aghast. He had never seen anything like it and he had seen many strange sights in his time. The number of ships docking and embarking beggared belief, the port was busier than all of its sister harbours put together; hastily extended to accommodate such trade.

"What the..?" He scratched his head dumbfounded.

"I've never seen flowers like these before," she murmured.

"Something is very wrong." He dusted his hands, "Coincidences."

She frowned confused.

"Don't much like them," he explained. The numerous ships in what should have been calm waters unnerved him. They couldn't all be searching for a missing prisoner, even if they knew the prisoner was Adiah. He sat back down on the cliff top closing his eyes again and was surprised when she joined him.

"Why do you think your father had you imprisoned?" He said abruptly.

“My father had me imprisoned!”

“Oh,” he pursed his lips, “Thought we were all on the same page.”

“Why would he do that?” Her head began to swim once more.

Wey thought about. She was certainly involved, but he couldn’t place her in the confusion around him. Thinking more deeply he remembered Leigh. He remembered her words but couldn’t make sense of them.

“I think they asked Leigh about Helena,” he said thinking aloud.

“Leigh, you spoke to Leigh, she’s alive!”

He paused, mouth ajar and made a quick mental note to shut up in the future. “Eh, they thought she was you.”

“She was in my room when they boarded. It was her wedding night.” Her lips were trembling. “What happened to her?”

“They tortured her, she was almost dead when we found her. She begged us to end it.”

Her eyes narrowed suspiciously. “You killed her?”

“I took mercy on her.”

“You killed her! She was my friend.” She began to cry and he made the mistake of trying to comfort her. In an instant she was hurtling through the field creating clouds of scarlet pollen in her path. Wey groaned and began to run after her, certain she was going to be the death of him.

He caught her quickly and knocked her to the ground, this time standing over her panting while she writhed on the floor in tears.

“It was a mercy killing you can ask your beloved. He’d have done it himself if I weren’t there. Now will you stop running off, my feet are killing me!”

He waited patiently while she cried herself dry, taking the opportunity to catch his breath and crave everything intoxicating. Adiah rose, wiping her face and forcing her anger for Wey to hide the pain she was suffering.

“Let’s just get you home so I can be rid of this whole mess,” Wey grumbled.

Five

Laura Joupe was eighteen, she'd lived on the island of Juliet all her life. Now she barely recognised her homeland. Her family's farmland had been confiscated by the state, relegating them and their neighbours to being at best an untalented fishing community, barely scraping together enough catch to feed the workers. Times were worse than hard and with blooming crops of boasting, royal red poppies across the landscape the farmers of Juliet blamed the state of Hermia for their predicament. When Laura's father pulled Finn from the water and saw the lashes upon the boy's bare back he, like the rest of the crew, knew Finn was a fugitive. In better times they would have handed him over, trusted their leaders to do the honourable thing and thought no more about it. That was before the state betrayed them, bringing famine and sickness to their doorstep. Taking Finn into their care marked the beginning of their short protest.

He was ushered into the Joupe household, theirs being the smallest family of the fishermen and having less mouths to feed. The daughter and wife cared for him and waited for him to awake and tell of the injustices he too had faced at the hands of their cruel leaders. And, now awake, they were all delighted at the pleasant countenance of their guest and particularly relieved he had little idea of the crimes he had committed, or the nature that had committed them.

"Maybe you were a pirate?" Laura said as she combed Finn's hair.

He felt his legs, "No wood there," he teased. "Although there is an ache in my shoulder where a parrot might have sat."

Laura stopped her combing to feel Finn's shoulder. "No this definitely feels like a bell ringers knot. Oh how droll if you were a bell ringer."

Finn laughed, "What's wrong with ringing bells?"

"Ding, dong, ding, dong, yawn."

"Maybe I'm a farmer."

"Now that would make Da happy."

"Maybe I'll just give up my mystery life and become a farmer anyway."

Laura looked suspiciously at him. "Oh really?"

"Well it's a good job, sitting upstairs all day talking and grooming."

"You say it like it's a bad thing."

Finn grinned aware that the confidence he felt was more alien than the memory loss.

Mrs Joupe yelled from below. Laura rolled her eyes. She slumped off the bed and mooched over to the door.

"Don't go anywhere," she teased.

“I long for your return,” he replied winking. As she left he took the opportunity to scratch the back of Thorin’s head. Although he had no memory of the wolf’s name he was starting to develop a fondness of the heavy pressure at the foot of his bed.

“What do you think to her then boy?”

Thorin yawned.

He looked at his hands, “No wedding band, that’s a good sign.”

Six

It took them most of the night, avoiding random patrols through the fields as they went. Hermia's Royal Guard seemed to have taken up a permanent residence on the island and were making sure everyone was aware of it. Finally Wey spotted the edge of a black dense forest.

Adiah looked as though she had walked through a massacre; her face and hair were stained red with blood coloured pollen. The sticky substance had coated her clothes, making them feel slimy against her skin. She was exhausted and hungry but determined to keep up with Wey's hasty pace and defiant not to break her silence. She reached the trees and prayed that Wey would stop and almost thanked him when he finally turned around and dropped to the floor.

"We camp here for the night," he said exhausted. Without looking back at his companion he quickly made a bed for himself amid the softer moss. After a few hours rest he would be able to search the forest for food and recover from the week's exertion.

Adiah stood over him unsure of how to proceed. She had expected more from her self-assured guide than a night in the dirt under the stars and contemplated continuing through the forest herself. Eventually she thought better of it. It was dark and without Wey she was almost totally blind. Reasoning with herself, she rested her head close to a large beech tree and let the cold air from the night chill her skin. She began to shiver.

The chattering of teeth and fidgeting started to grate on his already worn nerves.

"Princess," he whispered, "Lay over here."

Adiah didn't move.

"We're too close to the road for a fire, but we can share body heat."

"I'm warm enough," she replied stubbornly.

Wey shrugged, "Suit yourself."

Adiah awoke and could smell Wey on her. She bolted up in confusion and found herself alone with his jacket wrapped around her. Pausing to listen she heard a humming and the sound of a small stream of water. Wey's shadow lingered in the distance. Out of spite she was about to cast the jacket away but the warmth it gave her was enough to smother her pride and she found herself putting it on.

"Sleep well?" Wey said, carrying a rabbit carcass and an armful of sticks.

"What's that?"

Wey grinned proudly, "Breakfast." He dropped the sticks to the ground. "You get on with the fire, I'll skin bunnykins."

She tried; there was no way she was going to admit defeat without making an attempt. Wey seemed to be waiting for her to fail and the more she tried the more he snickered.

"I can't do it."

"Oh, you should have said," he replied smiling. He knelt down. "Watch carefully," he said as he quickly whittled wooden shavings and built a pyramid of sticks. "This is your job from now on." He rubbed sticks together until they began to smoke and gently he covered the smoke with shavings and then with larger sticks as flames began to lick the air.

With the fire burning Wey skinned the rabbit and made a feeble spit.

"I thought we couldn't have a fire," Adiah grumbled, salivating at the smell of the cooking meat.

"Not at night, they'd spot it, but we should get away with it for an hour."

"And what about tonight?"

"Tonight we'll move deeper into the forest," he said. "Where they'll never see us."

"What about Finn?"

"Princess, I dragged you several miles across a violent ocean, pulled you up a cliff and walked for hours through a field of syrup! I am sober, hungry and sticky. A man has his limits."

"So we're just going to forget about him?"

"No, we're going to get our energy back and then we're going to find out what the bloody hell is going on here before we do anything. Lesson for you Princess, know all hands before you make your move."

"But Finn could be hurt."

"Aye and he could be dead, in which case we've wasted valuable time." He said as he apportioned the meat. "Keep you safe, that's what he told me. Now eat up."

Wey wasted no time in moving them on. With his belly full he found himself in a slightly better mood and continued to tease Adiah when she stumbled, still keeping a steady eye on her to ensure she didn't get herself into trouble. He was quite amused at her attempts to match him, in fact he was charmed by it. She certainly wasn't what he had expected and that excited him.

Around noon they reached the site Wey had been looking for. It was a small clearing in the trees, with a built fire and a degree of shelter from the elements under a manmade canopy of linen and sticks. The dominant tree hanging over them had been marked with two slashes. Wey ran his fingers over them. He exhausted no time in digging at the roots and removing a battered wooden box. Adiah watched him with distrust.

The contents of the wooden box were very similar to the contents of many similar boxes throughout the islands. He withdrew two bottles of brown liquor seated on some dried foods.

Pulling the cork from one of the bottles with his teeth, he spat it to the floor, before taking a long, satisfying gulp. As he offered it to Adiah he felt his old self return.

"You planned this," she said horrified.

He looked at the camp and back at her, "I am good Princess, but not that good."

"Then who made all this?" She accused.

Wey took another mouthful. "Nomads," he said shrugging. "They leave little camps, fill the boxes when they leave for the next traveller."

"I don't believe you."

"That's a shame. Might be an idea to get that fire started."

"Who the hell are you!" She said, outraged. "What right do you have to order me about! Do you even know what I've been through!"

Wey sat the bottle on the ground and marched over to her. She flinched as he tore his jacket off her shoulders. "Nobody likes a victim sweetheart." Adorning himself with his favourite garment he picked up the bottle. "Stay here, I'll be back later."

"Where are you going?"

He winked as he disappeared into the tree line. He made and set basic traps to catch some food and foraged from the plants around him. A man could eat very well off the fat of the land with the right knowledge and Wey was in the mood for a feast. As he climbed an apple tree he realised he could see the camp and Adiah tending to the fire. He watched her with total fascination. Her skin and clothes, like his, were tinted red, making her stand out among the green foliage like winter berries. Wey felt his mouth go dry.

"Oh this is not good," he murmured to himself.

The day passed far too quickly. Wey had avoided the camp as best he could, only stopping back every few hours to check she was still alive. She was never pleased to see him, reassuring him that she was recovering quickly from her time at the Vaults. It had taken him months to trust again and he saw that, although she clearly didn't like him, she was trying to trust him. He liked to think it was just him, that perhaps they had a special connection, something she could never have with Finn. As he approached the camp for the final time that night he banished those thoughts, Finn had saved his life, twice now and that bought him a degree of respect.

Adiah poked the fire as he approached. She had cooked much of what Wey had brought her using the cooking pot left by the last traveller. Impressed, Wey sat down and helped himself to the broth she had made.

"You're going to give me some answers," she told him calmly but bluntly.

He raised his brow amused.

“Where did Finn find you?”

“He didn’t, his father did.”

“And what were you supposed to do for his father?”

Wey leaned back on the grass. “Escort his son to the Vaults, rescue an argumentative, ungrateful princess and return to Hermia for payment.”

“And who are you?”

“Wey,” he replied.

She pulled his pistol from beneath her shirt. “I am not a fool Mr Wey and I don’t like being teased. So you will tell me exactly who you are and what your intentions are.”

He licked his lips, revelling in the moment. Slowly standing, he raised his hands. “I am Fimorri.”

“Liar.”

He shrugged, “Believe what you want.”

“Your name?”

“As I told you Wey.”

“Just Wey.”

He sighed, “Egan Wey.”

“And your friend, the one with Finn.”

“Thorin, my wolf.”

Adiah’s heart sank, “You left him with a wolf!”

“Nobody I trust more. If Thorin survived the storm your beloved will have too.” He took a step closer, “And my intentions are like every Fimorri man in my situation, to survive.”

“At any cost?”

He took the pistol from her hand, “We’ll have to wait and see.” He turned the pistol on her. “While we’re getting to know each other, there’s a tattoo on your arm, where’d you get it?”

She swallowed and pulled her clothes around herself. “From my first voyage as Captain, two years ago.”

“Captain,” he didn’t doubt her at all. “Well Captain if you don’t mind I think we’ll say goodnight.” He pulled the trigger.

She flinched as water sprayed her face. Wey laughed.

Seven

The Joupes asked Finn to stay in his room away from the window. The Royal Guard didn't seem to be hunting anyone, but they were growing paranoid and suspicious which made Mr Joupe anxious. He had visited Finn three times, the first to welcome him into his home, the second to provide him with some clothes and the third to discuss Finn's plans.

Joupe was aging rapidly. He was in his fifties but his skin was like leather and his eyes dark and sunken. He retained a kind face and an honest smile, any other marks of happiness were gone. Together the two men sat in the bedroom, in awkward silence.

"You still remember nothing?" Joupe asked, still dumbfounded at the idea.

"Just memories from my childhood."

"No idea why you were on the wrong side of the Guard?"

An image struck Finn. He saw a large ship approach the vessel he was on and a naval force that unleashed an unwarranted attack on his crew. He shouldn't have been there. He knew they were after him and yet they killed the others.

Finn pressed at his temples. "I was coming from somewhere, a ship was helping me."

"Pirates?" Joupe asked warily.

"No, sailors, honest sailors. But the soldiers started shooting. Something was wrong with them, they weren't right." He winced at the growing headache. "I am a good man, I'm sure I am, but they were after me. I can't, I just can't remember why."

"Never mind lad," Joupe said relieved.

"But I swear Mr Joupe, sir, they shouldn't have started shooting at us, we weren't armed."

This didn't surprise him. "There's something amiss with the whole lot of them. Friend of mine has two boys in the army, both of them stopped writing, stopped visiting. Then they pile in here with their confiscation notices, patrol the fields and suddenly we're living like the bloody natives." Joupe shook his head, beaten by the world around him. "They'll come for the house soon enough and I've heard things, things about souls going missing on the island. Said to have left with no words to friends or neighbours."

"You think the soldiers are responsible?"

Joupe shrugged, "I worry my family might be in trouble and those we once trusted might betray us." He ground his remaining teeth. "I have a confession. I did not volunteer my house out of kindness Finn. When we pulled you from the water I saw one thing I do not have; a son. If I had a son I could ask him to take Laura away from this place."

"Surely you could take her yourself."

The tiredness in Joupe's eyes betrayed him. "If I'm wrong and I leave we lose everything."

“But if you’re right and you stay you’ll lose everything.”

“Aye, but Laura won’t. She’s taken a shine to you boy and in another time I might have taken offence, but I like you and I’m in need of your help.”

“I don’t understand.”

Joupe began to utter the words he had dreaded since he held his baby girl for the first time. “You have permission to take my daughter’s hand. She has a respectable dowry, of which I shall provide three years in advance to see you both off this island.”

Words clogged in Finn’s throat. He wanted to make a suitable comment on Joupe’s generous offer, nothing would suffice. He felt like the starving beggar being permitted into the banquet and handed a silver plate to help himself. The prospect of a lifetime with Laura made him delightfully giddy and yet his logical mind pulled on his restraints. He had no idea who he was, where his loyalties lay or if he had prior commitments. But then, finally, he remembered the miserable child wandering the empty halls of a broken home and he knew, with one handshake, the memory would never be repeated.

“Sir, I appreciate your offer, in fact I doubt I have ever been made such an offer in my life, but I can’t accept without Laura’s opinion on the matter. Your daughter is a credit to you, being as independent as she is. I couldn’t take her hand if she didn’t want me to.”

Joupe shook Finn’s hand and, after a fit of coughing, exited the room.

Finn sat still staring at Thorin in amazement, the wolf, as usual, didn’t share his enthusiasm, only perking up when Laura entered as he received his tickle and sweetbread. Then he settled down and went back to waiting.

“Hey,” Laura said coyly.

“Hey.”

“Da spoke to me.”

“Me too.”

“And you’re still here, I half expected to catch you escaping out of the window,” she teased.

“Why would I be escaping?”

“After Da forced me on you, like some piece of meat. I’m sorry; he’s got some funny ideas. Things on the island have made him go a bit crazy.”

Finn found himself controlling his nerves. His whole body suddenly calmed, much to his own surprise. He reached out for Laura’s hands.

“I’ve only known you for a few days, but I only want to know me with you.”

Laura’s cheeks reddened. She bit her lower lip nervously. “What are you saying?”

“I don’t want to escape from you.” He bent forward to kiss her, dreading the memories that could appear. No flashes disrupted their embrace and he revelled in his first kiss, taking in her taste, her smell, her feel and committing them to his mind forever.

Laura pulled away smiling, “What Da told you, about taking me away. I’m not leaving them, I can’t.”

“That didn’t settle with me either.” Finn replied. “I’d like to stay, if you’ll have me, perhaps I can deter the soldiers if they come.”

Delighted Laura put her hands around her betrothed. “Oh I’ll have you alright.”

Eight

*A*fter a week Wey decided they had spent enough time in the forest and after replenishing the camp they moved quickly through the dense foliage. The rest and isolation had restored them both and they bounded through the forest like young, albeit argumentative, fawns. Birdsong was interrupted by their bickering as they progressed through the trees and only stopped when they reached Juliet's hot springs.

Inviting pools of steaming water tempted both travellers, who were still filthy from the fields. Wey was ready to jump in when he remembered he had company. He stopped and looked to Adiah. She too was eager to cleanse her skin and be free of the sickly sweet aroma of the red flowers.

"You can have that one," Wey said gesturing to the spring enclosed within a thick hedge. "Shout, if you need me," he said removing his clothes.

Although Wey had very little scruples when it came to his nakedness, he was aware that Adiah may not have been as comfortable and made every effort to conceal his body and forced himself to avoid seeing hers.

He dropped his legs in the pool and slowly eased himself in. It was so warm it almost hurt, he dunked his head to acclimatise to the temperature. From his pool he could see Adiah's bare legs kicking at the water. With tremendous force he looked away, annoyed with himself.

"Egan," she called.

The sound of her voice pronouncing that name made his heart sink. He couldn't even reason why he told her, Wey had been his name for all intents and purposes, nobody except his mother and sisters called him Egan.

"Did you know this was here?"

"Honestly, I forgot all about it."

The warm water and serenity of the location seduced the pair into a dangerously relaxed state. Adiah closed her eyes and didn't glimpse the shadow moving in the distance. When Wey realised someone was looking over him it was too late. The vagrant extended a pistol at Wey's head. He was snarling like a rabid dog. The man was old, far too old to be picking fights with men like Wey.

"Afternoon," Wey said calmly, stirring Adiah from her meditation. "Just you and me here sir, no need for any trouble."

The man hissed like a venomous lizard. This was a creature that couldn't be reasoned with. Wey saw Adiah emerge from the bushes, dressed and clutching a huge rock in her hands. Quickly he rose startling the vagrant as she crashed the rock over his head. He dropped to his knees, the

pistol out of his reach. Wey leapt onto him, ready to secure him to the ground. The vagrant was strong, ridiculously strong and Wey found himself being overpowered by a man old enough to be his grandfather. Adiah hit him again, this time he collapsed.

"Is he dead?" She yelled in shock.

He checked his pulse. As he removed his hands he felt the plant residue on his finger tips. "Yeah. Let's get out of here."

He stood up and she turned away. "Egan, your clothes."

He dressed quickly, not for her, but because he noticed the vagrant's body excreting a blood like liquid from his facial orifices. He'd seen a lot of death in his time, but nothing like what lay before him. Taking her by the hand, he dragged her immediately away from the body and from the springs.

They didn't move far through the forest and Wey could still see the steam rising from the hot springs over the surrounding bushes. He allowed Adiah a little time to rest while he paced between the trees, trying to think of all the possible poisons that would cause a man to bleed in such a way. He shook his head dismissively, he was no physician; the man could have been suffering from any type of ailment, it was best not to frighten himself without due course. His ponderings were interrupted by a sniffling sound. He stopped and looked, alarmed, at the Princess.

She had her head in her hands as she sat slumped against an old tree. She sobbed uncontrollably, finally confronting the torment of the past weeks. Faces, now lost, returned to her, both haunting and comforting. She felt the bruises on her body and the bruises on her soul, and she felt guilty for the healing process she was fortunate enough to undergo. An arm wrapped around her, she had surrendered so much she didn't even flinch, instead she buried her head into a man that brought so much darkness back and she allowed herself to be beaten.

When there was nothing left to give she wiped her face and sunk sheepishly back into the bark of the tree, wishing she could grow roots and stay there for eternity. "Sorry, you shouldn't have to see me like this."

Wey shrugged, "I might argue you shouldn't have to see me wrestling naked with a tramp."

It made her laugh.

"What's this? A smile, don't tell me I've melted the ice queen!"

She elbowed him in his ribs, remembering a time when she used to do that to Finn and her smile slowly ebbed away. "I've never killed a man before," she said to disguise her true despair.

"Well if it helps I think he was on his way out anyway."

"I miss my ship and my crew."

Wey nodded in total understanding and agreement. He squeezed her shoulder and helped her up. "Come on Captain there are lots of ships out there."

"Not where I'm going," she mumbled.

"You're not tethered pigeon," he told her as he released her. The dark Wey gleamed behind his cunning eyes. "You don't have to return to Finn."

Without a moment's thought she shook her head, "No we have to find him, he's all I have left."

Wey sighed, defeated and a little ashamed of himself.

Their march through Juliet became ferocious. He took a wide lead, carrying a storm on his shoulders. His head ached with confusion and he knew the only way to return to his old self, a self he could live with, was to return to the mission. There could be no more bonding detours, no more touching moments of disappointment. He had a job to do, a job that he lived for and a people to support.

Adiah noticed very quickly that their path had taken direction. She voiced questions that Wey either couldn't hear or chose to ignore. His mood had drastically changed and she was pretty sure it was because of her. His earlier kindness prevented her taking immediate offence. Then he ignored her pleas for rest she started to lose her patience.

Heading away from civilisation, they took a secluded footpath winding around the forest. Wey took several unexpected turns. Soon he would be back at sea and Adiah would be off his hands. As he thought of the plans for her he forced a smile and tried to stifle the burning in his gut.

Ground roots became like snares, clutching at their feet as they climbed uphill. Wey almost lost his footing twice. He stopped himself from warning Adiah and when she finally stumbled to her knees he felt a mild satisfaction.

"Keep moving," he said impatiently.

She tried to stand but her foot had become tangled with the roots and her hand, still sore from the beach, was entirely useless. He was forced to help her and roughly yanked her foot free, lacerating the skin. She didn't wince or object like he thought she would, like he hoped she would, instead she grabbed a firm hold of his wrist.

"Where are we going?" She said sternly.

He stared at her dark eyes, testing her.

"Egan, where are you taking me?"

"You call me Wey," he murmured, sounding more ferocious in his head than aloud. "People call me Wey."

She pulled herself up, using him to support her weight, until they were nose to nose. "*Mister* Wey," she hissed, "You're going to tell me where we're going or I'm going to march into Juliet and name you as my abductor!"

“Off you go then *Princess.* When they throw you back in the Vaults you can forget this ever happened. Means nothing to me.”

She raised her eyebrows and then shrugged as she turned to leave him. He caught her hand as she expected and swung her back. He wanted to slap her, to kiss her, to do anything that would stop the future from unfurling. His hands were shaking and his mouth arid, in a few more steps all would become clear and yet he didn’t want to give in to her.

“Well?”

“There’s a house near here.”

“Who’s house?”

He sighed and yielded to her. “A friend, she’s been expecting us.”

“You said this wasn’t planned.”

“Believe me, being shipwrecked and stranded was never part of the plan, lucky for you I am very adaptable. But we were always coming here, all of us, we were just going to take a carriage and secure a ship first.”

Adiah allowed him to take the lead once more, although now he wasn’t so eager to be away from her.

Nine

The night Gerin Regan had not returned home shattered many Fimorri womenfolk. His absence and the absence of his crew left a large hole in the Barge. The single fruit of Gerin's labour was not discovered until a year later when his prodigal nephew returned with a full and true account of his peers' heroic end. Fimorri men, although famously full of health and vigour, had a tendency to live very exciting and tragically short lives.

Gerin's wife would have been with him on the night of his death had it not been for her young son. In her head she often played out the scenarios where her part would have saved him, knowing deep down had she followed her heart that night, her son Llew would be orphaned.

The Triad had ordered for the capture of her people and in the initial years it was obeyed mercilessly. Fimorri numbers were cut to almost desperate levels and the clan began their exodus to the safety of the ocean. Resolved in their new roles as outsiders the Fimorri adapted and adapted brilliantly. They became a new threat to the islands and then a new target. When the first ships were taken it was Gerin who had decided to retaliate. He created the infamous *Mirages*; he never lived to see their success.

Rhoma shook her head to banish away the thoughts. Fifteen years did nothing to ease the pain. She had taken steps in her widowhood, steps to avenge against those that meant her people harm and steps that took her so far from home she had forgotten where she belonged. A series of strokes in the last year rendered her housebound, but not yet an invalid. She was still useful and, for as long as she was able, she would continue to be.

Thoughts of Gerin had been rekindled when she had heard the news of her brother's death. She had been expecting him and now she understood she would never see him again, once again at the hands of the Triad. Wiping her eyes she caught the shadow of her son moving through the house. Unlike the other Fimorri boys Llew had been confined to land during his teenage years and remained his mother's sole companion. That, like everything else, would not last.

People of Juliet referred to Rhoma as the "sorceress." Most of Juliet had appeared at her door, or had been subjected to some bogus curse and in doing so had provided Rhoma with the vital information her people needed. She took what was necessary, the names of ships, political details, financial setups and illegal operations, she memorised everything and she passed them on to her people so that they might prosper.

The dwelling she had made home was everything Juliet wanted. It was a small stone building with a good thatched roof. Trinkets and worthless treasures cluttered the exterior, spilling from the entertaining room, out of the hall and into the garden. Chimes hung alongside pheasant

carcasses and beside carefully crafted animal bones. The house looked dilapidated, with cracked paint and an overgrown garden, but the roof, windows and doors were well looked after. Visitors often remarked how the house was odd, even creepy; nobody ever realised its strangeness was the result of a well built, clean house being filled with irrelevant rubbish.

Llew Regan was a huge figure of interest among the more morbid young women of Juliet, who lived in gothic fantasies and were desperate to break their fathers' hearts. He avoided the town and its collection of pretty girls as though they had the pox, longing instead to be at sea. He had been close this year to flying the nest and joining his uncles, aunts and cousins, but a new mission reached their home and he could immerse himself in Fimorri work without destroying his mother for a while longer.

Llew rested his head on his mother's shoulder and kissed her cheek. He began to make her tea, while she watched soberly. News of her brother's death reached them a day ago and she had just finished informing her kin. She wore black, once again, to commemorate all that had been lost.

There was a knock at the door. Llew stopped, looking to his mother. She waved her hand for him to continue. Slowly she advanced towards the door, allowing her limp to dominate her walk and forcing a stoop to her back. Ensuring the house was sealed off from prying eyes she pulled back the door and received her unwanted visitor. When her eyes met his she began to cry, dropping her stick and falling into him.

"Egan," she said before hitting him then hugging him some more. "You made it!"

"Aye, if I knew you were this desperate to see me I'd have come sooner."

Rhoma viewed the horizon, "Get in quickly, where are the others?"

"Very long story."

"Llew get out the rum!" She yelled.

"Who died?" Wey asked toying with her black shawl.

"You did. Come in," she showed them into the entertaining room and pulled open the curtains to let the light in.

Adiah looked around the room, spying organisms in jars and deciding closer inspection was ill advised. There was a seating space, intentionally set at a large table facing away from the door. Rune stones cluttered the table top, beside the skull of a goat. The objects unnerved her but she found the smell of hanging rosemary and the isolation from the elements thoroughly charming. She sat down and was served tea by woman with a thick head of dreadlock hair. In her day she had probably been a very attractive woman, but there was a droop in the left of her face from her last stroke. She was stronger than she pretended, and dressed far older than she actually was. In fact, the more Adiah inspected her, the more the woman seemed like her house.

Rhoma sat down and made a point of listening to the unfortunate events that had occurred since their departure from the Vaults. She nodded and offered a sympathetic look to Adiah when it was required, but gave Wey glances only a sister could. By the time Adiah had finished her tea she understood who Rhoma was. Their faces were not entirely alike but their expressions and similar tones gave them away. Having guessed their secret she sat back in quiet amusement.

"Well it sounds like you've had a time of it. Llew!" Rhoma shouted.

Llew poked his head through the curtain that separated the room with the kitchen.

"Adiah has hurt her hand, there is some salve in my basket. In the meantime, Wey you can use my birds."

The siblings stood up. Adiah grabbed Wey's hand, afraid. Once again he felt his heart melting. Forgetting where he was he put his own hand over hers and smiled.

"I won't be a minute and you could eat Llew for breakfast."

"Where are you going?"

"To catch us a pigeon. Relax yourself, we're safe here."

"You're going to keep your clothes on this time?" She felt her cheeks redden as she said it.

Wey smiled giddily as he left the room and rejoined the elements outside. Outside Rhoma stood as tall as her brother at the pigeon coop. She waited for him to lose his stupid gaze and smacked him hard across the back of the head.

"What do you think you're doing you silly bastard?"

Wey rubbed his head, feeling six again. "What're you on about woman?"

"What happens when your cock rules your work?"

"You get a lot of chickens?"

He was smacked again.

"Don't get smart with me Egan or I'll have you bent over my leg! You and that girl, what do you think you're playing at! Silly, stupid, idiotic boy! You do not eat, drink or interfere with the cargo. Wait till Napier hears about this!"

"I haven't *interfered with* anything," he said with his hands up.

"I heard what she said."

"That was with a tramp!" Her indignant look spurred him on. "It doesn't matter; fact is my hands are clean."

"Clean they may be, but they're desperate to get dirty."

Wey tightened his lips. "Aren't I always a good boy Rhoma? Now what the hell is going on here?"

She took a moment to take in the surrounding crimson in dismay. She had already forwarded the news to her kin, but speaking it aloud added finality to it. "War."

Wey scoffed.

"At least that's what I think. Hermian militia began showing up six months ago. They forced our farmers to start growing these desert flowers and now that's all they're allowed to grow. Juliet's governors seem to be in Hermia's back pocket and they're bending over backwards to let them cultivate the land." Rhoma stared at the red patches in the distance with disgust. "They used to grow here, the flowers. You wouldn't remember, but they were used in medicine. We would use their petals in tinctures to help ease pains. Mam took it for each of us, twice as much for Meril," she said winking. "But it nearly all died out when the harsh winters came, like everything else did."

"So why would they be used for war?"

"Because they're not using the petals," she told him. "The rest of the plant is deadly. It forces the body to shut down. It's a vicious poison and the amount they are growing is enough to take out all of the islands and the Fimorri."

"You think they'll target us?"

Adamantly she shook her head, "It seems to me they're going after Helena."

Wey's mouth dropped as the pieces in his mind clicked together. "That's why they took Adiah. They wanted to find out about Helena and her King." Shaking his head he groaned. "So what now?"

"We continue, but we do it quickly. Get that girl to Napier and get what you can for her from the King of Helena, then we'll wash our hands with this whole affair."

He hesitated, long enough for her to notice.

"Wey she is an aristocratic, land stealing whore. Her father killed our brothers and sisters. Her brother still sails around the ocean slashing the throats of our children!"

"I know, I know, but they put her in the Vaults Rhom'. I saw what they could have done to her, hell I saw what they did to her. She's not…" he paused and stared back at the house. "She's not like them."

She felt like hitting him again not that it would do any good. "Helena will pay enough to feed the clan through the winter, are you going to deny them that?"

Stuffing his hands in his pockets he replied; "No."

"Good," she squeezed his shoulder encouragingly. "The militia are everywhere. You keep the girl in the den and I'll contact the *Symphony*. They won't be able to approach the island safely so we'll need some coordinates."

"Were there any other survivors in the storm?"

"Thorin? Nothing has come my way, but I haven't had a client in weeks. The whole island has been shut down. Get down into the den and stay out of sight, if they think you're dead we'd better not prove them wrong."

Wey scratched his head. “I don’t like this Rhoma, this whole thing feels wrong. They knew I was on the boat, me personally.”

“Who knew you were involved?”

“Just the usual and my clients. Some one has done the dirty on me.”

“The Minister’s son?”

“No, him and the girl have as much to lose as me. But the soldier they were with,” Wey ground his teeth. “Things are just not right.”

Adiah’s hand was gently bandaged by Rhoma’s son. She had tried unsuccessfully to coax conversation out of the lad. He did as he was asked, gently enough to do the job, not bothering to add any tenderness to show he genuinely cared about the injury. The rest of Wey’s family clearly didn’t share his interest in her welfare. She could not rely on them as allies. Making a mental note of her new situation she waited impatiently for Wey to return.

When he finally did she had expected them to leave, not be forced deeper into the house. With the bluntest instructions Rhoma showed them the small opening in her fireplace and encouraged them to crawl through the gap until they reached a small, but not uncomfortable room. Rhoma fed candles and supplies through the gap before closing it up.

For a moment they were in total darkness. Adiah began to panic. The room was too small, too empty. She reached out and touched Wey’s shoulder only to feel him move away from her and spark a flame of light in one corner of the room. He lit several lanterns hanging from the stone walls allowing the room to slowly come alive.

Bedding covered the floor, surprisingly clean and pleasantly fragranced. The room was so small Adiah was forced to sit on the floor to be totally comfortable, it was there she spied the door that dominated the far wall.

“Where does that go?”

Wey glanced at it as though it was the first time he’d noticed the large walnut panels blocking an exit. “It’s an escape tunnel,” he said. “Leads out to a small cove.”

“Strange thing for a cottage to have.”

Wey chuckled and rummaged around the room until he located the supply of Fimorri liquor. Quickly he removed the cork from the first bottle and took a long deep swallow before offering it to Adiah. She shook her head habitually so he continued to drink by himself.

“Does your sister usually hide people in her house?”

He tried not to show he was surprised she had worked it out so quickly. “Let’s just say if she charged a fee, these walls would be gold plated.”

“What does she get out of it?”

He closed his eyes and rested back on one of the mattresses, “The opportunity to help her people, what else do any of us get out of it.”

“You mean the Fimorri?” She suppressed a smirk.

Opening just the one eye he scowled. “Do I detect a hint of mockery Captain?”

“I remember the tales of the Fimorri when I was little. Giant monsters coming out the sea, devouring sailors.”

“Well some of us are just devilishly handsome monsters.”

“Seriously Egan.”

He took a deep breath and rolled over to face her. “When the Triad was formed my people, islanders who have occupied these lands long before Qataria was even dreamt about, were forced to leave. Some of us complied, accepted positions as second rate citizens in the other islands, but most of us fought. Over a hundred years ago my people went to war with the Triad. We lost over half our numbers, our homeland, everything.”

Adiah shook her head, “I’d have heard about this.”

“It was never a big event in your history, just in ours. Some people remember, most don’t. We had nowhere to go and the Triad put a price on our heads, men, women, children all of value dead. So we left and we became the Fimorri.”

“Where did you go?”

He tapped his nose.

“And now you travel round the islands taking jobs nobody else will take?”

“Among other things.”

She looked around the room feeling claustrophobic again, drawing her legs to her chest she asked: “How long are we staying here?”

“Until my Captain gets back to us.”

“Then what?”

“That, sweetheart, depends on him.”

Ten

Finn awoke breathing in the scent of his wife. Her arm was draped across his chest as she slept silently. There had been no ceremony, only the quick signing of a register smuggled onto the farm with the official to witness the event. It wasn't as Finn had envisaged, not that he could remember what he had imagined in the first place. The insanity of the situation should have been filling him with regret and yet he found himself at peace.

The memory loss bothered him less and less each day. He felt things for the first time and he felt happy. The childhood he remembered was bitter and dark. He suspected the rest of his life followed suit and the prospect of leaving it all behind for this new found existence was perfect.

Laura groaned slightly, making him smile. Gradually she opened her eyes and took in the image of her husband. She had never been like the other girls, pining after a sweetheart. She liked excitement and adventure. The marriage had happened so quickly she had been swept up in the moment and as she awoke that morning she realised exactly what she had done. For a second her heart sank and she began to feel shackles around her wrists and ankles. Then Finn smiled sweetly and she remembered who he was and how much she commanded him.

"Morning husband," she said stretching.

"Good morning wife. Should I be doing something now?"

"Like what?"

"Something husbandly?"

She giggled, "I think you did that already." Pulling her dressing gown over her slender shoulders she hopped out of bed. "Given that it's our first morning together I'll play wife, but don't you get used to it."

Laura made her way downstairs and found Thorin resting on her father's chair in the sitting room. As though it were a chore he clambered down and went to receive his breakfast. Humming as she did so she filled a bowl of scraps for Thorin and began to piece together some smoked fish for Finn. When he realised how terrible breakfasts on the farm were going to be he'd ignore the fact she never made them for him.

The house was quiet and Laura filled her breakfast tray without any interruptions. She began to make her way up the stairs but heard a sobbing from her parents' room. Placing the tray on the floor she knocked on the door. There was no answer so she pushed it open slowly.

Her father knelt by his wife's side. He held her limp hand in his own. Tears ran down his face; red tears. As Laura approached the bed a chill ran through her body. Her mother's face was stained in red dew. It had leaked from her eyes and nose and ears and mouth. Her skin still looked pink but there was no life in her cold body.

“Da?” Laura gasped.

Joupe turned his head towards his daughter; his nose ran scarlet down his face. Laura ran to him and began to scream. She felt two strong arms on her shoulders and was drawn into a strong embrace.

Finn checked the body of her mother professionally. He rubbed his fingers over the substance covering her face, clueless as to what it could be. The same substance now oozed from Joupe. Finn helped his host out of his room and into the sitting room. Laura cried by her mother’s door profusely.

“Sir, how long has this been going on?”

Joupe wiped his nose on a red stained hankie. “A few days. Mary started a day after.”

“Did she have any other complaints?”

He shook his head. “Fit as a fiddle my girls are.”

“Mr Joupe I think we need to get a physician to come and see you.”

Slowly Joupe came to his senses, “There are no more physicians on the island.”

Finn rubbed his temples. He was sure he could help, if he could remember. “Will you let me examine you? I think I might be of some use.”

Joupe removed his shirt. Blistering sweat glands under his arms left a trail of scarlet powder down his sides. From instinct Finn checked his host, unable to understand what was going on. The old man was growing weak. He was in pain, although he tried to conceal it. Finn sat him in his arm chair and took Laura outside.

“Da said the Guard would get him! Do you think they poisoned him!”

“I don’t know, I’ve never seen anything like it.”

They were interrupted by a thump from the sitting room. Joupe had fallen to the floor, his breathing shallow. He stared at the ceiling afraid. Finn tried to keep him awake while Laura clutched her beloved father’s hand as he took his last breath. He was gone. The Red stopped pouring.

Silently they placed Joupe into the bed he had shared with his wife for thirty-five years. Laura placed the bed sheets over their heads and drew the curtains, before leaving the bodies in peace. She accompanied her husband into the kitchen and sat at the table, tears flowing but without the energy to cry.

“In a week I have gained a husband and lost my parents. What did this?”

“I don’t know. I think we need to leave this place.”

She nodded. “We need to bury them first.”

“I’ll do it.”

“The Guard will see you!”

“Then I’ll do it at night.” He stopped speaking and stared at her face as a thin streak of Red ran down her cheek.

Laura touched her face and checked her fingers. “It’s happening to me too isn’t it? Finn it’s going to happen to me!”

He grabbed her, pulling her off the chair, towards the door. “Quickly we must leave now.”

“But my parents…”

“Your father said it first happened a few days ago, we may have time to get you to a doctor.”

“There aren’t any!”

“Not on this island, but if we leave now we could head somewhere. Please Laura we must try.”

“Okay, okay.”

The desperation spurred Finn through the fields. Laura was tired, but showed no other signs of being ill. She held his hand boldly, fear having subsided and been replaced by determination. When she closed her eyes, she saw her parents resting side by side for eternity. The cold breath of fate breathed heavily on her neck.

“Finn I need to rest,” she said dropping to her knees.

“I can carry you,” he replied, ready to pick her up.

“Just for a minute I just need to rest. We still have time.”

“Are you feeling unwell?”

“Nothing unusual, but *they* didn’t feel ill either. What about you?”

“I feel sick and scared,” he confessed. “I brought this on you. Everything I can remember is tarnished and bad. Then I come here and your world falls apart.” He put his arms around her. “I’m sorry.”

“This isn’t you Finn. It’s the soldiers, they have done something to us. We’re not going to make it off the island.”

“Don’t say that.”

She shook her head. “They monitor all the ships. We’ll never make it out unseen. Let’s go back to the farm.”

“Laura,” Finn said desperately.

Slowly she pulled herself up. “I want to go home.”

With every step he took he felt they were giving up. Her determination was born out of her acceptance of her fate, not his. If he forced her they might just make it, but if they didn't their last moments together would be in conflict. His heart was twisting inside his chest. He'd found love, found it for the first time, memory loss aside he knew he could have never felt such a feeling for anyone else in the world and in a matter of days he would never feel it again.

The house was dark and cold. Finn ignored the shadows and led Laura up the stairs. The door to the Joupe's room was closed. Laura felt moisture running from her nose again and a cramp in her stomach. Before Finn noticed she pulled herself into bed and covered her body in bed sheets that smelled of young lovers.

"Now what?" Finn asked, wiping clear tears from his eyes.

"We wait. Will you stay with me?"

He sat beside her and began to pray that his own nose would begin to run red. "This might not be it."

She smiled, "No, we might be lucky. But it might be the end, for me at least. You could still be fine. We would have been good together."

Finn left the room only when he had to. He stayed with her until she fell asleep and then went to bury her parents. It took two hours of digging, under the watchful eye of the wolf, to make a grave big enough and he hadn't the strength to then dig another so gently he eased the two bodies inside and covered them with soil.

He knelt beside them feeling there should be something he should say or do. Thorin mooched over to the grave. Words came back to Finn. He began to mutter his ritual and with it the memories returned. Murky waters began to purify. He looked at the ground, the sacred earth, at his hands, at the band around his finger and the Temple knowledge raced through his head.

Thorin grunted. There was movement on the horizon. Quickly they returned to the house. Finn locked the doors and windows. He dowsed his face and hands in the jug of stale water Mrs Joupe had brought in before she died. In total disorder he sat at the kitchen table thinking of the vows he had broken, utterly unrepentant.

"Thorin," he said to the wolf. "You saved my life."

Thorin eyed the old loaf of bread on the table top as just payment. Finn placed it on the floor for him and returned to his wife.

He sat in the darkness of the bedroom watching Laura sleep. He would have given up everything for her and now suddenly he had nothing, having betrayed his faith, lost his sister, all that remained was to watch his wife ebb away. Sitting in the lonely room he felt like he was drowning.

"Finn, is that you? You look different."

“I remember,” he said. “I remember everything.”

She sat up excitedly, reaching for her oil lamp. Finn helped her until they were both under a low orange glow. “Who were you?” There was anticipation in her voice.

“I was a priest,” he said nervously. “My sister had been imprisoned in the Vaults and I went to rescue her. A man was helping me, a man called Wey and his wolf Thorin. The soldiers attacked us on our way home. Wey and my sister escaped on their ship, our ship sank and I never saw them again.”

Laura wiped the moisture from her face. It was getting worse. “Then tell me about my husband,” she broke a smile, “Tell me about my priest husband.”

Eleven

They spent little over a week in the room. The confinement and boredom drew them together once more. Casual chat grew heated at times, fuelling their relationship to reach new boundaries. On other missions, when he found himself longing for Rhoma's hospitality, he would leave his charges to themselves and spend his wait in the company of his family. On this occasion the thought never even occurred to him. He didn't feel compelled to stay with Adiah, he felt drawn to her, eager to listen to her stories of sailing as though she was the adventurer and he was a closeted royal. She excited him beyond anything he had ever encountered before, perhaps because she was so like him, perhaps because she was so alien. He'd seen stronger women, more hansom women and women who enchanted him and yet she surpassed each of them.

The day the pigeon returned to Rhoma, the travellers had almost become friends. Wey read the letter from his Captain somewhat nervously. He had a time frame and coordinates to work with, neither of which were unreasonable, but both seemed too close for his liking. He had been secretly hoping the crew would have got greedy and cooked the pigeon again, delaying the return message indefinitely, but they had learnt from their last flogging. He was to depart.

"What's it say?" Adiah asked trying to decipher the strange symbols on the note.

"We need to leave the island in two days," he sighed.

"Then where do we go?"

He glanced away from her, "Hermia I suppose."

She too seemed unsatisfied with the answer and slumped down on the floor.

Wey chewed on his lower lip till it hurt. "Depends where you want to go really."

"What do you mean?"

"You're my charge, I'll take you wherever you want to go." He was telling her a dangerous truth but he couldn't help himself.

Her eyes met his own with the same dark intent. She could be rid of it all, her title, her treacherous family. She could find Finn as a free woman. She could sail again. Even the prospect of Wey's company oddly attracted her.

"I don't want to be a princess," she murmured.

"I don't want you to be a princess either," he replied. "You look much better in uniform."

"But where can I go? I have nothing."

"You have me, you can come with me."

She laughed at the idea. "And do what? Rescue ungrateful princesses?"

"If the mood takes us."

"You're serious!" She exclaimed.

Wey ground his teeth. He tried to laugh, to ease the moment in his usual way. He was too nervous and merely squeaked in discomfort. “No, I’m not serious,” he said unconvincingly. “You wait here and I’ll get us a boat.” He tried to move but his hand was caught in her own.

“Egan?” She whispered.

He shuddered at the sound of his name.

“Were you serious?”

“I don’t know. Maybe not.”

She released him. The stories he had told her were romanticised versions of the truth, but even in their barest form they were stories she wished she could tell herself. She imagined spending her days with him, laughing and arguing. It hadn’t even occurred to her before and she felt guilty she hadn’t considered where Wey now belonged in her life. He’d saved her from the Vaults, dragged her through a storm and kept her alive, would it be so easy to leave him? Did she even want to?

“You don’t want me following you around forever,” she warned.

“Don’t I?”

The quiver to his voice unnerved her. In all their time together she hadn’t even suspected his intentions. The room grew smaller around them. She wanted to run and hide from him, for the words he was about to speak to be muted forever.

“I’ll take care of you.”

She gulped, “Please don’t.”

Gathering what little courage he had left he faced her with full determination. He had stared into the barrel of a loaded pistol without a tremor in his steady heartbeat, her eyes would not conquer him. With a gentle hand he cupped her face and broke the vow to his people in one thirsty kiss.

She pushed him away in fright. Hands grabbed her body, violated her virtue. She kicked at the air around her until the wall pressed against her back. Tears built up in her eyes, tears that refused to be blinked away. He backed off, holding his arms out to try and calm the air around her. She stopped fighting and dropped to the floor ready to be overpowered once more. Her eyes lulled in his direction, defeated and compliant. She would never be able to fight him and had no strength to try. It was a small penance for her life, although not one she would ever give willingly.

“Adi’ get up,” He said aghast.

She lay there, empty and subjugated, a dying deer ready for the final shot to the head. “Adiah,” he growled, unable to contain his anger at the whole charade. He pulled her to her knees, using the wall to support her weight.

“Don’t hurt me,” she whimpered.

“I’d never hurt you,” he said battling the rising sickness in his stomach. “Do you hear me! How could you think..?” The pain in his fist as it hit the wall would not be felt until the morning, but the pain in his chest was overwhelming. He let her go and she crumpled to the floor.

Her senses slowly returned to her. The taste of his lips on her own didn’t feel so horrific. She glared up at him humiliated and afraid of his ghastly mood. He was furious, uncontrollably furious, pounding at the walls like a caged animal. There was movement in the chimney.

“I’m sorry,” she said.

“I would never! Never...” He rubbed his face anxiously.

“I’m sorry, please sit down. In the morning we can look for Finn and forget this ever happened.”

He stopped his pacing, “You think his hands would be different to mine?”

External light shone in the room. Wey caught sight of it and was drawn out like a moth. She heard him mumble to his sister and listened as a series of doors were slammed. Silence embraced the household.

Rhoma ungracefully clambered into the room. She checked that two beds had been used before she turned her attention to Adiah, her eyes full of accusation. Adiah tried to explain herself, making sure she professed Wey’s misunderstanding and ultimate innocence. She hoped that apologising would ensure her safety. Rhoma’s wide stance was hard to read.

“You thought he would rape you,” Rhoma said bluntly.

“I don’t know. I forgot where I was and who I was with. I know he would never do that to me.”

She raised her finely crafted brow, creasing the spirals on her forehead. “He cares for you, at great cost to himself. Do you understand why?”

“Because he saved my life.”

Rhoma pursed her lips. “Since they were built there have been only three escapes from the Vaults. Yourself and Egan.”

Adiah’s breath caught in her chest. “He was there?”

“Twice. The first time he was just a boy, the second a man.”

“He never told me.”

Satisfied she had a hold over the Princess she relaxed. “Now you know. He was there for six months. You were there for less then two. When you next accuse him of such an atrocity remember that.” She spat on the floor.

“I should find him.”

“He’ll be back when he’s ready.”

Twelve

They were alone for three days. Laura coaxed every story she could from him until her own life had melded into his. She knew the man she had married and she was proud of herself. The liquid that seeped from her lower body was sticky and uncomfortable, but she refused to acknowledge it. Death was close, she could taste it now and she had decided not to fight anymore. Finn still hadn't displayed any symptoms and she began to worry he would catch it from her.

"I don't care," he whispered in response. "There's nothing bad that you can give me."

Laura let her head fall on his shoulder. There was no real pain except the feeling of change inside her. It would be easy to ignore if she didn't feel so tired and weak, although that was more likely due to the lack of food.

"When it happens will you bury me beside my parents?"

Finn closed his eyes in agreement. He kissed the top of her head.

"Then you'll get off this island." She ran her fingers over Thorin's back. The wolf had joined them an hour ago, as though he knew this was his last chance. "Both of you. And you find out what caused this and make sure it never happens again." She smiled, "And you must find your sister."

"That's a lot of demands."

"I should have warned you I'm a very demanding wife. Will you go back to Temple?"

He blinked away the tears. "I'm not a priest any more."

"Then you find yourself another wife. Be happy. You know I love you," she smiled, "From the moment I saw you I knew I'd spend the rest of my life with you." More red liquid pooled from her eyes. She was blind.

"I love you too, you were the only one, ever."

She died shortly after. Her body relaxed in his grip and the liquid stopped flowing. Finn held her until night came, crying uncontrollably. When he had nothing left in him he withdrew her red stained body from the bed and carried her down the stairs. It was only when he got her outside that he realised he had nowhere to put her. Gently laying her down on the ground he began to dig. Thorin started to dig beside him and together they shifted the soil. Rain poured. Joupe's clothes clung to Finn's body. The grave filled with water and he had to stop.

He was shaking as he picked her up and lowered her down. A rite needed to be performed but he couldn't do it. The words didn't come and instead he sat in the rain and let sorrow strangle him. Thorin began covering the body with angry kicks of soil and Finn slowly followed. The earth was wet and cold. Eventually it covered the grave.

There was nothing else to do, he wiped the rain from his face. His innards were stone, hard stone. As he rose he felt heavy and dead. With his memories returned he knew the full extent of what he had lost, his first love, his first hope of happiness. He began to walk.

Thirteen

He'd show her. Good for nothing, ungrateful… This would be the last time he went out of his way. Did she even realise how difficult it was pulling her skeletal body out of the waves? Of course she didn't. He drank another mouthful of wine and his pace veered into a zigzag across the dirt track. Not good enough for her… well fine he'd get himself a whore, a real whore, one that had a bit of flesh to her. No he'd get himself two whores. He laughed at the idea; then winced as he tripped. This was his own fault, he was Fimorri and he knew better than to get involved. But that priest pulled at his empathy, taking risk after risk like some faithful wolf. Then *she* came like a storm across his beach and everything he had harmoniously ordered was in chaos. Three whores, he thought, smiling, and a goat.

He'd walked for several hours, at some point his feet began to take him into town, while his head overrode risk with the luring possibility of a tavern and voluptuous women. Yes he could run into a platoon of soldiers, but he had his pistols and dry gunpowder and his vision was not too blurry. Besides he had a second aspect to his mission and, if he needed any further encouragement to continue his trip into town, he could tell himself he needed to check the docks before they departed.

So far he had only come across two local farmers, who made a semi circle to pass him. As quickly as they were out of his sight they sighed in disapproval and continued on their way. Neither would have chance to speak to the soldiers.

Heading out of the town Wey spied two figures coming his way. One clearly that of a man, walking without purpose towards him and the other a dog with a spring in his step. Wey narrowed his eyes; it wouldn't be the first time he'd had a drink induced hallucination. The dog shadow lifted its head and began to bound. Wey dropped his bottle, the final dregs soaking the shattered glass shards. He knelt on the floor, arms opened wide. Thorin, tongue lolling out, pounced on his friend and frantically licked and chewed Wey until he could take no more.

Wey pushed him away and stood up. "You took your time, we nearly left without you."

Thorin grunted and sniffed at the broken bottle.

Finn was still in the distance. With Thorin back at his side his swagger was restored. He trotted over to Finn, stopping when he got a closer look of the priest's sallow face. For a moment he thought he'd got the wrong man. Wey grabbed hold of him to be certain.

"On my soul man I thought you were a gonner!" He released Finn grinning. Finn didn't share his enthusiasm.

"I've lost everything," he murmured in a hollow voice.

"No," Wey said gripping his shoulder. "She's alive and she's safe."

The brief flicker of interest that brushed Finn's face was quickly replaced with the pale, gaunt frown he'd worn since he left the Joupe's. Tears welled up in his eyes and he dropped to the floor. Wey stood over him awkwardly; he had little idea of what to say to sobbing women, let alone sobbing men. He fidgeted, looked to Thorin for help and eventually knelt beside the lad. Gingerly he patted Finn's back, unsure of what amount of contact was appropriate and deciding less would probably be more comfortable for them both.

Finn finally wiped his eyes and nose. He took a deep breath and turned to Wey. "I've done something you'll think foolish."

"Good, I'd hate to think you'd had a revelation while you were away."

Not even hearing Wey, Finn sat back on the road and rubbed his filthy hair. "I've given up my profession." He clicked his fingers. "Given up the Temple, gone and I can never return." He sighed. "I need to tell you about my wife."

Wey tried to force a smile: *yes your wife because of course it's you who she wants.* "Finn after a month with the woman I think I am quite acquainted."

Again Finn was deaf, he could only think of Laura and the need to vocalise her death, to make it real. "I need to tell you about Laura."

Wey scowled, "Who the bloody hell is Laura?"

The voice filtered through. Finn glared at Wey unsure of how he could explain what had happened. "She is… she was my wife. I lost her. How can I go on without her?"

"Your wife?" Wey shook his head, the wine still seemed to be in control. "When did you get married?"

"Earlier this week. I think it was a Monday."

"Well bugger me, I couldn't even manage a fondle."

"What?" Finn said, still adjusting to an actual conversation with another living being.

"Nothing. Come on I think you need to start from the beginning."

They walked side by side, as though they were life long friends. Finn talked, Wey listened astonished at the story, astonished and irritated. He had been rejected for a man who was in love with another woman, albeit a corpse, but Finn was clearly a man that could love a corpse for many years to come. Wey wanted to shake the boy and tell him about the living girl who was obediently waiting for him, faithfully waiting for her prospective lover, who would now always disappoint him because he had left his true love in a shallow grave. He wanted to cheer victoriously because Adiah would not have it all. Most of all, he felt, and it totally caught him off guard, a deep and genuine sympathy for a man he respected.

“I loved her Wey, I really loved her. I’ve never loved anyone, not like that and I never want to again. I have nothing to live for.”

“What about Adiah?” Wey finally said, unable to rest without some finality.

“Is she okay?”

“Aye, little bruised and tender, nothing to worry about. Quite a lively one.”

Finn nodded with a sad smile, “She’s not changed much.”

“You came for her,” Wey reminded him. “Journey’s not over yet.”

“You’re right, I need to get her home.” He rubbed his grubby face. “Do you think badly of me?”

Wey laughed, “Badly?”

“For breaking my vows.”

Putting his arm around Finn he chuckled. “Come with me Finnian, I’ll show you how you really break vows.”

“Where are we going?”

“We need to find a way off this island. Are you armed?”

Finn shook his head.

“Excellent, you better go first then.”

They walked at a good pace before they reached the town. The roads were almost entirely deserted and any other travellers seemed to be heading into the countryside. With a new focus Wey began to concentrate on his surroundings. There wasn’t enough movement for a usual day of trading. The roads should have been cluttered with carts of cargo and the bustle of trade. He eyed the copses of trees notorious for harbouring thieves, finding them void of even suspicious shadows. There was no sound except their own footsteps as they trod through a lonely landscape.

Then, like an explosion, the soldiers came towards them. Wey grabbed Finn and pulled him into a ditch. The two men knelt, thigh deep in mud and silage, while the soldiers passed. Thorin poked his head above the ditch and, after he had drawn no attention, Wey did the same. More than a hundred men marched by. Feet stomped the ground unnecessarily. Their uniforms were unkempt and dirty as though they had trawled through one war already. Bloodshot eyes suggested that war was nearly won, but not before one final massacre.

Slipping back into the dirt Wey frowned. “So what’s the political situation in Hermia at the minute?”

“I don’t know, why?”

“You’re the Minister’s son?”

“I’ve spent the past four years in seclusion.”

He sighed. He would have heard of political instability before now, his people thrived on such information. He was getting nervous. Clambering out of the ditch he pulled Finn back onto the road. The soldiers could just be seen heading off towards the poppy fields.

"What do you think they're doing?" Finn murmured.

"Looks to me like they're marching." Wey turned his back on them, "Let's get this done with." He led the way into the town.

Fourteen

The smell hit them before the houses came into view. An aroma of putrid, rotten flesh filled the air. Neither man gagged, or covered their noses, but neither would ever forget their revulsion of that stench. Their steps slowed. The silence was disturbed by sobbing and wailing from every direction. Large men with red stained faces dragged the bodies of entire families through the streets. Nobody seemed to notice the new comers, their eyes too clogged as the red liquid oozed from the dead and dying.

Bodies were laid side by side, under tarps and blankets. As they neared the centre of town the space had been limited and the bodies were stacked in piles with the smallest at the top. The lower bodies had begun to rot and pyres were being set up to deal with the problem, only the pyre builders looked more likely to keel over before lighting anything.

"What the hell is going on?" Wey gasped.

Finn's head turned from the bodies to the dying. His heart was pounding in his chest as memories of Laura returned. "It's the poison."

Wey went cold as he glimpsed a child sat on the kerb beside his motionless family. Red liquid seeped from his eyes. Slowly he leaned over to place his head on the breast of his dead mother. His breathing softened then stopped.

"It looks like the pollen from the poppies in the fields."

Another march was on the way. Finn and Wey quickly slipped into one of the empty houses. The hallway was dark, making the road the only visible view. There were fewer soldiers but this time they were marching people in chains. The people, although weathered and malnourished, seemed unaffected by the crimson liquid. Wey's eyes flickered through the faces, noticing similarities he'd rather not see. Then he caught the eye of a face he knew; another Fimorri, a friend of his late father. The Fimorri man saw Wey and raised his hand to his lips. Enough was said in his eyes for Wey to move further into the shadows until the march had passed.

"Oh this is not good."

"They didn't seem ill," Finn whispered.

"No, but they were of particularly good breeding."

Finn frowned.

"They were Fimorri, or plain natives at the very least."

"How do you know?"

"Look at them, pale hair and eyes. Sharp features. Traditional, handsome island folk."

"Where do you think they were being taken?"

"I don't know. Lets go, I want off this island yesterday."

The town tilted to a harbour. The harbour's heart, once a booming market, sagged and drooped into the sea. Stalls and cargo were strewn about the streets. Evidence of pillaging was just visible, but by the time the market had died most of the town had fallen with it and what was left were being rounded up by the militia. Wey's hands flexed at the sight of the deserted goods. His need to be free of the morgue town was overwhelming enough to stifle them.

The militia had been through the harbour recently, but only their sparsely occupied ships remained in the distance. Wey studied them before proceeding. If they were spotted they would be able to disappear into the town long before any more soldiers could reach them. He entered the crumbling market, his steps cautious and slow. The stalls could easily hide trouble.

Finally he saw the sea and the salt purified the air around him. He longed to return home, away from the madness. The trade ships were almost empty. Wey had hoped to find something of a crew, but all that remained were two bewildered looking sailors. They were neither use nor ornament in their escape. Instead he turned his attention to the smallest sloop, ready to depart but bereft of crew.

"There she is," he whispered, "I christen thee *Liberty*."

"So what now?"

Wey rubbed his beard. His boat was at one end of the island, his cargo the other. Usually this wouldn't be a problem, but without hiding Adiah and Finn under a cart of corpses he wasn't sure how he would get them anywhere near the harbour without the soldiers noticing.

"How do you feel about dead bodies?" He murmured to Finn.

A bustling disturbed them. Wey lashed around, pistol drawn. A barrel was pointed at his chest.

"Lower your weapon old man," he growled.

Balor's hand held the weapon firmly in place. His red eyes gleamed wildly at the two men. He blinked several times until he could gain some perspective of his surroundings.

"I'm not going to ask you again."

"Finn," Balor said, straining. "I need to speak to you."

Finn stepped back.

"Funny I thought you'd need a head to speak, obviously I was wrong."

Balor took a deep breath and forced his hand down. "Finn, we have little time."

Wey still held his position. There were few reasons to keep the traitor alive and none of them were particularly worthwhile.

"You lying son of a bitch why should we listen to a word you say?"

"You shouldn't," Balor hissed. "It's Finn I need to speak to."

“Where did you go?” Finn asked, “When the ship went down I tried to find you.”

Balor stared proudly. “I was on the other vessel.”

“Treacherous fucking…” Wey began.

“I am no such thing.”

“Well you look like one of those red eyed monsters.”

Balor closed his eyes in an effort to hide his newest weakness. “I didn’t betray you, but I haven’t been entirely honest with you. Your father didn’t dispatch me to protect you. We received information that the King of Hermia had been developing a drug and supplying the army with it. I managed to obtain a sample and have been trying to locate the source and the reason for its manufacture.”

“Well welcome to the spring of red shit!”

Balor shook his head angrily. “The drug is an import, from Qataria. Finn you must tell your father this. It is imperative he knows. The poppies are the drug in its pure form, a poison. The pollen alone is deadly, that is what has caused this damage, but the drug they supply to the army has been distilled somehow.”

“But why?” Finn asked.

“It enhances the men beyond anything imaginable. They are stronger, faster, hardier.” Balor rubbed at his temples. “Only it affects their minds, makes them easier to control and nowhere near human.” He was getting out of breath as the words became foggy in his head. “The drug is highly addictive. The more taken the more powerful the user becomes, and the more dependant. If you cut the supply of the drug the soldier will die.”

“You’re ill.” Finn moved closer.

“Or doped up,” Wey murmured. “Fancied some of this magical potion yourself did you?”

“I was here two days before I realised I was dying. The pollen had got into my body and I had no choice. I had to take the drug and continue my mission, until I understand why this is happening I cannot return to your father.”

“But if you don’t take the drug you’ll die?”

“And if I continue I shall lose my mind. I am aware of the situation.” He took another deep calming breath. “I need you to relay the information to your father in case I fail in returning.”

Finn nodded, his body had gone cold.

“Bullshit, I’ve been walking through the fields for days, nothing wrong with me. Or him for that matter,” he said gesturing to Finn.

“It doesn’t affect the natives. Fimorri, traditional islanders, you both have immunity. But those of us with mainland blood in our veins are dead.”

The militia were marching back. Balor turned sharply to them, ready to leave.

"Tell your father I will endeavour to locate the distillery."

The first soldier came into view.

"Finn move." Wey suggested.

They began hurrying through the town. Wey pulled Finn into a side alley while the marching grew louder. The wait allowed his mind to process. His face paled.

"She was covered in it Finn."

"What?"

"The pollen, I dragged her through fields of it!"

Finn almost said something, but couldn't.

"We need to go."

Without hesitation Wey leapt from the alley. The march had moved on, leaving two soldiers standing at the far end of the road hauling bodies from the houses. He'd had enough and the horses tethered to the post outside the house were an opportunity too tempting to ignore. Removing his pistol he felt his eyes darken.

The first guard was edgy, his drug supply was running low and his task was proving fruitless. He spotted Wey first, but took several crucial seconds before he made any alert.

"You're not sick!" The soldier said.

At the sound of the voice the second soldier turned.

"I wouldn't say that." Wey replied, blowing half the guard's head off. He fired his second bullet at the kneeling guard and untied the horses.

"Master Finn, your chariot awaits." He said, lifting Thorin up.

The hooves pummelling the cobbled streets were drowned out by Wey's thrashing heart. His hands clutched the reigns until they started to blister. Thorin scrambled in the saddle and growled and whimpered, but managed to stay on. Finn struggled to maintain the pace. His horse was flagging before they made it out of the town. He decided it would be better for the horse if he slowed a little.

After hours of riding Wey caught a glimpse of his sister's cottage. He almost turned around, not wanting to face the potential disaster inside. Finn was lagging behind and Wey refused to wait. He jumped free of the horse, landing clumsily on the ground and staggered until he gained his footing. Rapidly he ran to the house, flung open the door and headed straight for the secret room.

Finn saw Wey disappear. He moved his horse slowly up to the house dubiously. With great care he dismounted and tethered his horse to the house's gatepost. Thorin whined at him from the top of Wey's mount. Finn helped him and tethered the second horse as well.

Only one lamp flickered on the far wall of the room. Wey's hands were shaking. Adiah's body was motionless, her back facing him. The light danced around her, taunting him. He braved a step closer. He was a man of the world, a man who had seen more nightmares in front of his eyes than his imagination, and yet this was by far the worst. Nothing would ever make this moment right, not revenge or sacrifice. He would be like Finn, an empty shell rattling around the world waiting to die.

Resting his hands on her he rolled her over. Blurry eyed she squinted at him. Relief punched him hard in the face. He grabbed her ecstatically and she fought him irritated.

"You're alive! You're alive!"

"What! Get off me. What are you talking about? Have you been drinking? What am I talking about you're always drinking."

She rose to her knees and glared disapprovingly.

"I thought you might…" he paused and bowed his head like a naughty child smirking at the amusement of the situation.

"What's so funny? You're drunk aren't you? For heaven's sake Egan," she tugged at her hair and sighed. "You shouldn't have run off."

"I didn't run off woman, don't be so melodramatic."

"You ran off," she told him. "I know you were at the Vaults."

His smirk subsided. He ground his teeth and hoped Finn would move his backside.

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"You never asked," he replied facetiously.

"Don't be an ass."

Raising his eyebrows he met her glare. "And what good would that've done you, Princess?" He hissed. "Would you have preferred to compare notes, perhaps see who had it worse? Maybe we could get naked and compare wounds."

She rolled her eyes. "It would have been nice to know I wasn't alone. You could have helped me."

"Are you not safe and well, fed and watered? What more bloody help do you need? Here," he said snatching her hand. "It will all be okay. There, there."

His attitude was starting to upset her. "I just want to know how you deal with it and move on."

He stopped; the warmth of her hand was the only thing he could feel. "You cut it out of you like a rotten limb and you live without the parts of you it corrupted."

"As easy as that?" She said doubtfully.

“Nobody escapes from the Vaults. You died in there, I died in there. We are just ghosts, echoes of potential.”

“You and I alone?” She whispered.

“Aye,” he said exasperated. He leaned in closer.

“Wey! Wey are you in there!”

Adiah turned to the entrance. Her eyes opened wide. “Finn?” She leapt to her feet. “He’s here?”

“Yeah he’s here,” Wey said. “Could have been here five minutes later,” he muttered under his breath.

“Who are you?” Rhoma hissed holding her cutlass out. Finn hadn’t seen him but he was sure somebody else was standing behind him as well. He held up his hands and hoped Thorin might take an interest in the situation. The wolf had already settled down by the fire and showed no inclination of getting involved.

“Good afternoon, I am sorry to barge in, my friend, Mr Wey, he came in here.”

“Who are you?”

“Finnian Fernwick, madam.”

“Finn! Finn!”

He was knocked to the floor and Adiah was on top of him. He wondered what happened to the woman with the cutlass. Nobody else seemed concerned so he decided he would stay on the floor and hope the world would start making sense. Adiah hugged him, talking incoherently with excitement. Eventually she pulled him to his feet, but refused to let him go. There was no way she was letting him out of her sight again, if that meant she had to hold his hand for eternity so be it.

Wey watched from the sitting room. With one simple story the moment would be shattered and yet he couldn’t bring himself to utter a single syllable against Finn. Instead he went to get a drink.

Fifteen

*A*s the evening drew in and the stars began to awake the household convened in the sitting room. Finn and Adiah sat together, while Llew guarded the window like most nights. His mother took her place on her worn chair and Wey sprawled out by the fire, fighting Thorin for the warmth. He cradled a bottle of rum after explaining their current predicament.

Rhoma had closed her eyes. She couldn't quite comprehend what Wey had told her. Everything had changed and she blamed her guests entirely. Llew had barely heard a word said, he was trying to look focused to impress his uncle and fierce to intimidate the guests.

"Even if you get to the boat how can you possibly escape unnoticed?"

Wey shrugged taking a gulp of rum. "Create a distraction."

"A distraction, what are you going to do run up the field and shout 'look at me!'" Adiah murmured.

Wey stared at the flames from the hearth. His mind ignited, smoking a smile onto his face.

"You've got a plan?" Finn said.

"A plan, how can you have possibly thought of something so quickly?" Adiah replied suspiciously.

"Experience, intuition and blind arrogance my dear. Tomorrow night we'll burn the fields. Make our way to the ship and off we go while all our brave soldiers run around with buckets."

"That's your plan?"

"No, that's our plan. We'll stash you on the boat. Me and Finn will light the fires and off we go."

"Why do I have to stay on the boat?" Adiah shouted outraged.

"Because you're our Captain darling, where else would you be?"

She folded her arms angrily.

"Good," Rhoma said rising. "Wey, let me show you where you can keep your animals." Thorin grunted in protest and was left by the fire.

She led Wey outside into the chilling night. Wey drank deeply from his bottle until the wind was powerless against him. His smirk had faded and he straightened his composure. This was serious business after all, the militia had taken his people and that could not be drunk away.

"You think they've been taken to work the fields?" He asked.

"It would make sense. Egan this doesn't feel right."

"Get away with you woman, you've not got a sixth sense."

She clouted him on the back of the head. “Don’t doubt me. This is wrong and bad for our kind. You need to return to the Barge and let them know what’s happening. If more of our kin are being taken we may have to go to war.”

Wey snorted, “Aye, or we could just lie together in a shallow grave and save the soldiers the trouble.”

She smacked him again. “I want you to take Llew with you.”

“You want me to baby-sit,” he said folding his arms.

“None of that. He’s nearly a man now, it’s time he did his service. Napier’s agreed, you will make sure he gets there safely.”

“And you?”

“I’ll stay here, keep an eye on the situation.”

“Martyr yourself more like,” he grumbled.

“No more of your nonsense. You will do me one more favour. Get rid of your cargo, they’ll do nothing but cause you grief.”

Wey rolled his eyes, “I’ll drop them off somewhere safe, I’ll promise you that.”

“That girl has got you by the balls,” she spat.

“Why’d you tell her about the Vaults? Trying to put her off?”

With the rum coursing through his veins she would never make him see sense. Defeated she joined him.

Adiah awoke in a panic. She pushed herself up and clutched the bedding. Out of breath she tried to concentrate. There was no cell, no prison guards, she was safe. She repeated it again until she stopped shaking. The nightmares were getting more vivid. Faces from the past appeared in the present, corrupting her new security. She reached out across the room where Wey slept but his bed was empty. Then she remembered Finn. Crawling across the darkness she sidled up so she didn’t have to be alone.

“What’s wrong?” He whispered.

“Nothing, just a nightmare. Did I wake you?”

“No.”

“Is everything okay, you seem troubled?”

He had been trying to tell her all night. At least in the dark, where he couldn’t see her face it would be easier.

“I need to tell you something,” he began. “It’s complicated, I think I might disappoint you.”

“Don’t be silly.”

“I got married.”

She sat up. “What? When?”

“A few days ago.” His words were quivering from his mouth. “Her name was Laura. She died. The poison got her.”

Adiah frowned. She waited for a punch line, or the misunderstanding to be cleared up. “You got married? You?”

“I know, I know. I broke my vows.”

“It’s not that, it’s just, in all the time I’ve known you I’ve never seen you look at a girl. Did you, no wait I don’t think I want to know. Did you love her?”

He nodded and began to sob. “I’m sorry.”

“I’m sorry too. Will you tell me about her?” She bent in closer. “I’d like to hear about the girl that won my brother’s heart.”

Sixteen

The sun crashed into the sea like a burning arrow. Wey and Finn scouted the outskirts of the town cautiously. The pyres were fully constructed and abandoned. It seemed anybody left in the town had been captured or succumbed to the pollen. Wey wanted to move Adiah as quickly through the town as possible. He had risked contamination once and was adamant it was not happening again. At the edge of the town they hid their horses and began to walk.

Wey headed the group with Llew by his side. The boy walked with a straight back and kept his eyes to the ground. Many of the corpses still bore familiar faces and after he had spotted two he knew he was resolved to look no longer. His mother had explained most of the situation but he hadn't really understood the implications. Now with death as his new landscape he was quite happy to continue living with her and leave the outside world to its misery.

"Stay with me Llew," Wey murmured.

The boat came into view and still the soldiers were nowhere to be seen. Adiah had seen enough bodies in the past few months to remain unaffected, though she knew their faces would return to her when she closed her eyes. Finn was just cold.

Under the cover of darkness they rowed out to the ship. There were three bodies on deck which Finn and Wey hastily threw overboard. They quickly searched the ship to check all was in order, while Adiah acquainted herself with the vessel. She was confident she could get it out of the harbour.

A hand touched her shoulder and she jumped. "Meet your approval Captain?" Wey whispered in her ear.

"She'll do. Won't be very fast though."

"We don't need her for long. Is she ready to go?"

Adiah nodded solemnly, "The crew must have been ready to depart before they..."

"Departed? I've saved your life twice, right. Do me a favour, keep your eye on Llew. Rhoma will string me up if anything happens to him."

Surprised she turned around. "Sure." She smiled jubilantly; he was finally taking her seriously. "You will be careful won't you?"

Wey squeezed her shoulder tightly. "Where would be the fun in that?" His smile faded slightly, "No lights, keep your heads down and movement to a minimum."

He patted Llew on the back. "You protect that girl with your life you hear me. There are people paying a lot of money for her safety."

Llew dutifully nodded. He touched his weapon to assure himself he was equipped to deal with any situation. The butt of his pistol sat confidently on his hip where he hoped it would stay.

“Right,” Wey said. “Finn lets go.”

Wey made to leave until he heard a whimper. He turned around and knelt down. “Thorin I told you to watch the ship.”

Thorin growled.

“I will be back.”

He grunted.

“It is not the same as last time. For a start this time there’s going to be fire!” He scratched the wolf’s head. “Last time I promise. Then we’ll be home.”

Resolved, the wolf turned and went to sniff out some scraps.

They reached the fields, with the help of the horses, in good time. Immediately they trekked far into the centre of the fields spattering lamp oil where they could. The night was dangerously silent. There was no light, only a small streak of moonlight from the thin crescent in the sky.

“I’m out,” Finn said tossing his container into the field. A furious fire was already burning inside him, enough to get the job done without the oil. “Ready?”

“Ready,” Wey replied. “You okay?”

Finn nodded trying to convince himself.

They hurried without racing to the far side of the field. Finn kneeled to ignite the oil when the marching began again.

“Don’t these scabrous bastards sleep?”

Sneaking back in the shadows they waited. Wey closed his eyes and listened to the voices.

“Move it, come on we haven’t got all night!”

There were groans, objections, curses. Wey swallowed. Sense told him to wait; to leave those captured and save himself. He never listened to sense and suddenly found himself reaching for his pistol. Finn stopped him.

“Are you crazy?” Finn hissed.

“They’ve taken my people as slaves.”

“That’s no reason to set us all alight.”

Wey released his pistol feeling foolish. He shook his head to try and think more clearly. He could see the soldiers holding lamps. He could hear the clinking chains of the captured.

“Stay here.” With that he was standing and walking with the captured men, his head down, his hands held behind his back.

The captured saw him while the soldiers were too busy inhaling the fading pollen. There was a noise from the fields. It was Finn. The soldiers stopped the march and shone the light into the crops. Some of them reached for their rapiers, nobody watched the captured men.

Wey sidled up to the nearest man and whispered, “You look very injured friend, and you moan so loudly.”

The ragged man understood and increased his groans and whimpering. Wey quickly seized his chance.

“I have a boat ready, but you’ll have to move quickly if any of you want to live.”

Like a swarm the men descended on the soldiers. Shots were fired. Men began to fall. Wey leapt on the commanding soldier. The soldier fell to the floor and reached for his rapier. He waved it frantically, exhilaration and lust filled his red eyes. Wey removed his pistol and shot the soldier in the heart. He dropped the sword but stayed upright. Blood pooled from his chest. Wey pushed him to the floor, pounding his fists into the soldier’s head until his hands could stand no more. He grabbed the rapier and spied Finn running towards them. Quickly he tossed him the sword and watched enviously as the boy struck two soldiers with deadly precision.

The shackled men were falling. Two soldiers fired rounds at the back of the march. Wey had one shot. He turned to the only guard left holding a lantern and aimed his weapon. The fields lit up, dancing flames encircled them. The shackled men, powered by the heat, launched their last, furious attack. Wey hurled himself at the two shooters. He waited to feel the bullets hit him. They were too slow. He landed on them, pushing them closer to the fire. Smashing the butt of his gun into one of them was easy, but the other grabbed him by the throat. His strength was incredible. Wey kicked and scrambled like a hooked fish. The smoke was beginning to choke him.

Finn turned and saw his friend dangling in the air. He charged with his sword and forced it through the soldier’s ribcage. The man let Wey go and turned to his new attacker. Finn let go of the rapier and backed away. It should have killed him, so why was he was still walking, still grinning like a reptile. Wey grabbed the hilt and jammed it into the soldier’s skull. His legs wobbled and he dropped to the ground. He still crawled towards Finn with malice.

“Burn and blast your bones die already!” Wey said kicking him hard in the head with a satisfying crunch. The soldier’s neck snapped. He stopped and let the coughing take over. Only eight of the prisoners had survived, they were shackled to twelve bodies.

“Are you hurt?” Finn asked.

“Not yet.” He took one of the soldier’s swords. “Cut them out of the shackles.” He ordered.

Quickly eight men began frantically hacking at the bodies of their friends and families. Smoke engulfed them. Wey moved through the fire. He knew the end of the field was close but the smoke was making him confused. Finn ran at his side, his eyes streamed with smoke induced tears, blinding him.

The air grew fresh. They stumbled onto the road. Their horses had bolted, but with so many men behind them they would have to go on foot anyway. Taking a few gulps of air Wey started to run.

Seventeen

*A*diah sat up. The hills around them began to glow. A small spark ignited into a bonfire and before she knew it the fire had turned the island into a burning sun. It happened so quickly it made her gasp. Then shadows began to move, like spiders crawling up the hills. Llew stood beside her, eyes wide, mouth dry.

"Are you scared?" She whispered.

He shook his head.

"I am."

He turned to her, pale and confused. His mother lived on the other side of the flames, there was no going back to her. For his part tonight he could face the gallows. When he was a child the idea of living on a perpetual death warrant like Wey tantalised him, now he was terrified they were going to catch him.

"Llew," Adiah said softly, "Can I hold your hand?"

He reached out and felt warm flesh on his own. He suspected she was braver and he was silently grateful.

"Hoist that damn anchor!" She heard a voice wail.

"Llew, you heard him!" Adiah bellowed. "Capstan heave!" She screamed as she threw her entire weight into the bulk of the small Capstan. "Crowd on sail!"

Heads and then bodies appeared starboard. The entire horizon danced in front of her, licking the air with orange tongues. Finn's, flustered face was the first she saw. She waited before taking the helm for Wey. Face after face appeared. She was sure she had heard him shouting.

"Come on, come on."

His hands clutched the netting. "Move!" He yelled as he clambered swiftly onto the ship. She could breathe again. As Captain she bellowed orders. Her voice echoed throughout the ship, shouting to a foreign crew of farm labourers. Wey staggered to the helm, giving Thorin a look a smug satisfaction. He put his hands on the wheel, over Adiah's.

"Who are they?" She asked trying to ignore the relief she felt inside.

"Your crew. Get them off this island and they'll die for you."

"Them as well? They're not doing anything."

"Quick flogging will sort them out," he laughed to hide his exasperation. The island was glowing red before them.

"Just get this boat out of here." He turned to face the rest of the ship. "Llew get your arse up there and shout if you see anything that isn't water!"

Llew looked up at the mainmast and swallowed.

Rhoma had lit the fire to keep the heat in. The circulation in her feet were poor and she felt constantly cold. Wrapping a woollen shawl around her shoulders she waited. Flames danced in front of her, consuming wood that would not be replaced. She watched them lick at the black grate and remembered her son. She worried whether he had left the island and the thought of him travelling with Wey made her uneasy. Her brother was excessively preoccupied with his new adventure, the girl and the trouble she was bringing. The small charge of her son would do little to entice him onto safer ground, which meant until Llew reached *the Mirage* he was vulnerable.

There had been commotion in the fields. She had seen smoke in the hours after she had bid farewell to her son and knew her family name had once again been scorched into the island as Wey autographed his journey. After the flames came commotion. There were shouts, shots, then silence. It would only be a matter of time, she knew that and she would wait.

PART III

One

The boat creaked and groaned in response to the gentle lapping of an embracing ocean. A breeze cruised through the sails, kissing the unlikely sailors on their foreheads and cheeks, like a lustful, dangerous maiden dancing with married men. A breath had been taken in Juliet's harbour and was held within the hold, expanding without relief.

The rescued, red stained men stood mindlessly watching the dark ocean. With loss in their hearts the icy waters lured them with hopes of emptiness and finality. The victory of their Captain and her companions was small consolation for their isolation.

Rees Miner realised he was holding the side of the ship and had been for sometime. If he closed his eyes he could see the final moments of life, before the soldier ripped it from him and tore it to pieces. He had thought he was lucky, his family had survived the plague, his children, his wife, all remained healthy. Then they came for him and it became clear the bodies in the street had been the fortunate ones. His newborn was murdered in front of him. Then they removed his wife and son, ignoring her pleas for death. Just like the other men, his woman was taken and he would never see her again.

The Captain was talking. He tried to listen but she was too far away. Since they had lost sight of the island his confidence had grown in her abilities. Although she looked so fragile, her eyes glared at the watery world with experience. Nobody knew her name, or how she had come to the island and nobody cared to ask. She was there, she was succeeding and for that they held her in regard. The young boy with her seemed to be heading unknowingly into a riptide. His smiles came as quickly as his grimaces and both were usually overshadowed by a look of utter confusion. The other two men were harder to read. They had risked their own lives for camaraderie and yet neither were particularly interested in their arson adventure. One carried the world on his shoulders, which was so heavy he stooped, while the other looked as though the world had been thrown at him and somehow he had taken a lucky side step to avoid a full collision.

Rees was tired; he could feel his body aching from his earlier field work. A farmer by trade, he knew he was no use on a ship and it would only be a matter of time before the others realised as well. His belly growled with hunger and unnatural motion. He had nothing but bile in his gut and that was already in the back of his throat.

Adiah watched her crew with unease. She was waiting for most of them to commit to an exodus into the ocean. She had seen too much to be able to empower them with an inspiring speech and so instead she waited patiently to see what would happen.

"It suits you," Finn said to her. "You could do with a hat though."

“Maybe I’ll ask Wey, he seems to be able to pull anything out of his pockets at the minute.”

Finn smiled, although it looked nothing like the smile she was used to. His face was tired and sad, she realised this was how it would always be for him now.

“I need you to do me a favour. I need you to speak to the crew.”

“You’re the Captain,” he moaned.

“Aye and you’re my first mate so do as you’re told.” She stopped and turned to him seriously. “You know what they’re going through and you know how to console them. Please Finn I need a crew and they need your help.”

“What good can I do, I can’t even console myself!”

“Please Finn.”

Reluctantly he agreed. Straightening his jacket, he headed off to talk to the despairing man clinging to the side of the boat. He thought about Laura. Remembered how much it hurt and he remembered consoling the widows and widowers in the Temple. It seemed impossible to connect the two honestly, but the men around him didn’t need honesty they needed drive and he only had one.

“My name is Finn,” he said to the first man.

“Miner, Rees Miner.”

“You lost family?”

“Wife and kids,” Rees said quickly and coughed away his emotions.

“I lost my wife,” Finn replied. “They won’t get away with this Mr Miner. They will be punished.”

“They’re the Royal Guard, only the Gods can punish them.”

“And advocates of the Gods,” Finn whispered. “You need to rest. There is some food in the stores, please take what you need and then sleep. We have a tough journey ahead of us.”

“Where are we going?”

Finn paused. Their destination was totally insignificant to him. “We’re going to obtain answers Mr Miner, if you wish to join us you are more than welcome.” Finn turned to speak to the next pitiful soul.

Adiah watched curiously as her crew started dispersing off deck. It wasn’t quite what she had hoped for. Finn circled the deck like his father had done at fine parties and balls.

“Quite the charmer isn’t he?” Wey said.

She lashed around and spied him caught up, comfortably in the ship’s netting.

“Of course I’d have checked the reserves before offering full bellies to a bunch of homesick country folk.”

“You brought them here.”

He grinned. “Good job I did too, we’ll need something to eat if Master Finn continues like this.”

“Where the hell are we going?”

“You’ve got the coordinates.”

“Yes and I checked them too, no land just a big open space of ocean. Care to enlighten me?”

He jumped onto the deck. “We’re going to upgrade Princess.” He brushed the hair from her face before leaning in closer. “My ship and you shall be the honoured guest.” He straightened up. “It’s faster and will get us to Hermia in relative safety. Plus we’ll have a crew that can not only man a ship but that can crack a smile.”

“And then what?”

“That my darling is entirely up to you,” he whispered. “You know, I think you’re a Captain I might enjoy working under.”

“Bilge rat,” she hissed.

He started to laugh at her.

It was the final straw, this was her boat, she was Captain and she’d flogged sailors for less in her time. Taking a tiny blade she had concealed in her jacket she lashed out and held it against Wey’s neck. “Don’t test me Egan. Not tonight.”

Wey’s grin grew to astronomical lengths. “Just when I think you’re getting boring you give me a whole new side to get me through the night.”

“I mean it.”

She removed her knife coolly. “Mr Wey you will take first dog watch. Do not disturb my quarters. It’s about time I thanked Finn for rescuing me.” The knife in her mouth stabbed him repeatedly, each puncture more satisfying than the last.

Wey tried to think of anything witty, or cruel, his mind was blank. He tried to convince himself she was playing with him and yet the possibility she would choose Finn over him seemed all too likely. She would probably choose Finn just to spite him. He scowled until his head hurt.

Finn sat in Adiah’s cabin watching her sleep. He had thought the room was empty, but realised, once he’d made himself comfortable, that she was resting in the corner. She wouldn’t mind so he stayed. He’d made crucial mistakes when he spoke to the crew, mistakes that couldn’t be fixed. When he should have been wise and caring, he felt bitter and malicious. Yes they had suffered like him, but why should they have their pain eased when he was in constant agony? Everything he had done since he left the Temple had weathered away at the very core of his soul. He didn’t know who he was anymore. He had felt things he couldn’t explain or justify and he knew some of the feelings he would never experience again.

Adiah tossed and turned. She whimpered and cried out. The world had changed for them both, or they had changed for the world. He couldn't bear to think of what had been done to her, but she was strong, far stronger than he ever was. She had determination and ambition. He was just an unmanned vessel, a useless shell harbouring knowledge and sadness. He closed his eyes and saw Laura's face and he began to cry once more.

Two

The morning came quickly. Adiah opened her eyes, soothed by the natural motion of her cabin. She sat up and looked at Finn resting at the foot of her bed. His eyes were puffy and pink. She stroked his hair and woke him.

"You can't be comfy," she said softly.

He stirred and rubbed his face.

"Are you okay?"

He shook his head and put it on her shoulder. He didn't need to speak and he was grateful because he could no longer think in words.

"I'm here," she whispered.

A bell was ringing in the distance. She scowled and leapt from the bed. "What the..?"

The crew wandered aimlessly about the deck. Nobody knew who had rung the bell, or who was manning the ship. Adiah turned in circles, looking for Wey. Thorin had taken a place by the mast but she couldn't see Wey anywhere. Finn tapped her shoulder. She looked up at the flag. The ship was flying colours she'd never seen before and Wey was hanging from the crosstrees like a thief at the gallows.

"What is he doing?" Adiah gasped. "Wey! Wey get down here!"

She was about to climb up after him when a shadow descended on the boat. Her eyes tried to take in the sight of the vessel in front of her. She had been facing it moments before and there had been nothing there. It was almost as though it had risen from the sea. She stepped forward in awe at the craftsmanship. It was beautifully ingenious and deceptively cunning. The woodwork was meticulously painted in blues and greys and whites and silvers. Ropes and rigging were bleached white and tinged with hints of blue to blend in with the sky. The sails were almost transparent to the elements, but as she looked closely she could see they were expertly dyed to match their surroundings. The colours of the ship changed like mother of pearl camouflaging it masterfully. Every aspect to the boat was set back like a shadow in the sea. As she examined it further she realised it was old, bearing scars, and had evolved to prevent similar injuries from occurring. Envy struck her and her mouth salivated at the prospect of commanding such a vessel. It was then that she saw the faces.

Pale, lime stained men, grey ragged clothes. Her heart sank as she realised what was about to happen.

Like raging ghouls they flew onto the ship, attached to invisible ropes. *The Liberty's* crew were surrounded before they could put ghastly faces to fiercely armed bodies. She felt Wey beside

her, then he was gone. Her crew crumbled. Finn raised his arms and she realised she had no choice but to join him.

Silence. The ghouls relaxed themselves, holding their weapons confidently and without intent. They were waiting and that meant Adiah was waiting too.

The heavy clunking of hard heeled boots struck the deck of the ghost ship. The pirates respectfully parted and their Captain appeared on his chameleon ship. His tall, sleek frame shadowed the horizon, making him appear nothing more than an apparition. He rested his hands on his sturdy hips and glowered down at the ship with intensely sharp, grey eyes. His face and wild hair had been repeatedly dowsed in lime water making him look like an albino alligator, with the knowledge that his mouth alone would shred the flesh off a buffalo in three easy rolls. Captain Cod Napier was a marble emblem of the Fimorri and he'd slit a man's throat for doubting any charade in his appearance.

"Mr Wey," he bellowed in a beautifully low pitched voice.

"Captain," Wey said cheerfully tapping a salute at his forehead.

Adiah felt a fire ignite within her. She lashed around to find Wey. "You bastard! You set us up! You traitorous son of a bitch!" She dived into him, knocking him to the ground and pounding her fists into his face until one of the pirates pulled her away. "I'll kill you, you son of bitch! You're a dead man, you hear me!" She screamed as they dragged her back to the ghost ship. Finn followed her more amiably, keeping his hands in the air and hoping Adiah wouldn't get them into too much trouble.

Three

Conrad held the telegram in his fist. He was burning inside. Removing his rapier he charged at one of his officers and forced the blade into the man's heart. He stabbed at the man until there was nothing left but blood. The other generals looked on nonchalantly. He let go of his blade and composed himself, rising up from the bloody mess and straightening his ruined clothes. With a few more sharp kicks he was ready to leave the departed general be.

He turned and realised he was being watched. Eve folded her arms and shook her head at the mess. She was back to her old self once more, or not herself, Conrad could never decide. At that moment she looked very beautiful, although he knew beneath her headscarf was a head plucked clean of hair. The thought of it repulsed him, but he didn't need her for *that*. He swallowed his disgust and expelled a wide, unnaturally cheerful smile.

"More mess," she said in disappointment. "You cannot dispatch the help and create all this chaos in my laboratory. Where will I work now?"

He sighed, "You!" He yelled at another inconsequential officer. "Clean this mess and get me Pandora!"

"What's wrong?" Eve asked clinging to his arm affectionately.

He knew better than to shrug her off, but continued pacing the room with her hanging off him like an unwanted coat.

"It's her, I'm sure of it."

"Who my love?"

"That sister of mine."

Eve laughed, "Don't be silly, she's dead."

Conrad stopped, he glared at his wife furiously. "Then show me her body! No she's alive. Somehow she's alive and she means to ruin everything. The poppy fields are gone. Burned to the ground. We've lost all our supplies."

"The fields are gone?" Eve's smile faded. "I must return to my work. Things will need to be changed."

"Can they be changed?"

"Everything can be changed Con." She rolled her head. "The poppies we have will last until new are grown, but we will need the land cleared. Yes clear the land, bleed the slaves, all shall be well."

Conrad held her firmly in place, she was slipping again and, although her best work was done in her own world, she was impossible to talk to.

"We will have enough?"

“We will have enough.”

He smiled slyly and turned to his generals, most of whom were on their knees wiping the floor with their coats and sleeves. Setbacks were always a problem, but if he could eliminate potential nuisances early his grand plan would still go ahead. Soon he would rule the islands.

“General Knocks, dispatch a telegram to Mercy. Tell him if he does not bring my sister back here I will cut his supply and send my own fleet after him!”

General Knocks nodded and hurried out of the room in case his own supply was severed.

“Lakley!” He yelled to a second General. “Get word to Juliet, we are on schedule, begin the second harvest preparations!”

General Lakley moved slower in response to his Prince’s calmer voice.

“And somebody get me some food!”

Four

"And they were natives, you're sure of it?"

Wey nodded, reclining in the leather armchair and chewing on the cut across his lip. It felt good to be back on his ship and he was in no hurry to return to his old Captain, not until she'd had a little time to calm down at least.

Napier toyed with his pipe, tapping it on his desk and scattering ash across his charts. He had wiped the lime wash off his face, but traces of it still streaked his thickly matted blonde curls.

"This changes things. Changes what we can do with our prisoners."

Wey sighed. "The crew are loose ends, might be worth taking them back to the Barge directly. Ship's intact, could be serviceable."

"And the charges?"

"Redundant," Wey replied. "Certainly in so far as the ransoming."

"You're suggesting we operate legitimately?" Napier looked surprised.

"Yeah, makes me feel dirty as well. Truth be told Captain this isn't exactly the straightforward kidnapping we were hoping for."

Napier curled two of his three fingers around his beaded beard. "So what shall we do with them, slit their throats and have done?"

Wey closed his eyes irritated by his attachment to the pair, "Finn might be useful. He's Temple trained and he's good. To look at him you'd think you could blow him over but I reckon he could teach us a thing or two, least till we next make port."

"He's a priest? That explains the sour look on his face. Trustworthy?"

"Stupidly so."

"And the girl?"

He groaned reluctantly. "Probably the same. But she did hit me."

"Extra day in the brig?"

Wey smiled. "You're too generous Captain."

Napier narrowed his eyes and looked at his charts. "So Rhoma's expecting war. Mr Wey I think that we may need to investigate matters."

"War can be very profitable."

Napier tossed a set of keys at him. "Keep your eyes on them."

"I'll kill him," Adiah said. She'd tugged at her shackles for a good hour before finally conceding she was stuck there.

“Someone’s coming,” Finn said calmly. He squinted to see the shadows moving towards him from the entrance to the brig.

The other men looked up. If they were able to feel anymore most of them would have been grateful the end was coming and then disappointed when they realised it was still a wait away. Wey approached the chained men with a merry look in his eyes. He jingled the keys triumphantly.

“Sorry about that gentlemen, slight hold up in customs, but matters are sorted now. Arms out and lets get you out in the sun.” He quickly unshackled the men and sent them on their way. “Welcome aboard *the Mirage*, finest ship to sail this side of the ocean.” Then he reached Finn and felt a pang of guilt come over him. “Sorry friend, an earlier obligation I needed to resolve. You understand?”

Finn shrugged, “Situations change. Sometimes for the better. You’re not going to make us walk the plank are you?”

“Hell no, if we’d do anything we’d hang you from the bowsprit.”

Assuring himself it was a joke Finn smiled and waited for Adiah. Adiah waited for Wey. Wey waited for Finn to leave. Finally Finn understood and excused himself bashfully.

“You’ll not get forgiveness from me,” Adiah turned her head away.

“Certainly not today Princess,” he said smugly returning the keys to his jacket.

“What are you doing?”

“Captain says you’re to spend another day in the brig.”

“What! This is your doing isn’t it?”

Wey winked and ran his tongue over his split lip. “Insubordination and violence will not be tolerated on this ship.”

“I thought it was obligatory for pirates.”

He sneered.

“Egan,” she said softly, “This is silly. I’m sorry, I thought you were betraying me, after everything we’ve been through. Please Egan, please let me go. It’s so dark down here.”

“Captain’s orders, you understand.”

She sighed in agreement. “Does your lip hurt?”

He shrugged apprehensively.

“Looks sore. I’m sorry I shouldn’t have hit you.” She held out her shackled hands and took his own. With a slight pull she moved him closer and pursed her lips. He tilted his head to kiss her. Forcefully she jammed her knee into his groin and he dropped to the floor, tears pooling in his eyes. The keys were out of her grasp, not that she had been trying to reach them. She sat down and watched with satisfaction as he writhed on the floor. Now the wait didn’t seem so bad.

She stood despite being offered a seat, her back was straight, and she exuded confidence. She was in her domain now and a foreign pirate ship wasn't about to shake her. After a day in the brig and a minor moral victory she had cleared her mind. Sure she had suffered in the Vaults, but she had done what Wey had said and severed that injury. They had taken the Princess from her, the young woman who would take a rich husband, carry children, grow old. What had been left was the ocean and the dark waters that now coursed through her veins. She had felt it before, the allurement of the sea pulling her closer, now she had no grounding, no morals to tether her to dry land. Now she would swim.

She had thought long and hard about what had happened to her in the darkness while the rats scurried across her feet. Her father, no her stepfather, had condemned her to death in the worst possible way, without reason. She had been tortured, robbed and raped. Her brother, the Prince, had left her to die. And then she was rescued, by a man who she wanted to kill but who she couldn't envisage losing, and her half-brother. Her half-brother had come; he had sacrificed everything, thrown his life into the black waters to bring her to the surface and was now drowning himself.

"A proposal you say," Napier said reclining in his chair. "Well I am intrigued your highness!"

Adiah stepped forward, rubbing her sore wrists; she would not be intimidated by this pirate. He was merely a man and she had no inclination to be a woman in his presence. "You were keeping me for ransom, yes?"

"Intuitive."

"Well for your services I will double whatever you would hope to get for me."

Napier's mouth twitched in amusement, the curls in his moustache rose. "Double it? Oh I do hope you can do better than that. We have gone to a lot of trouble."

Adiah had expected to barter and truth be told he could have named his price. "Have my fortune. The fortune of the King of Hermia and his son."

"Why thank you, I assume you'll be writing a cheque."

"You underestimate me Captain."

"Perhaps you overestimate yourself," Napier replied.

Placing her hands on his heavy desk she stared, sternly into his calculating eyes. "The King of Hermia and his son murdered my crew and condemned me to death in the Vaults. Now they are murdering more innocent men and women on Juliet, people who share your blood. They must be stopped and once they are I will be Queen and you can have anything you want."

Napier reached for his pipe. His eyes would not betray him, but the prospect of treasure and revenge was exceedingly arousing. "You want to commit treason?"

“It won’t be treason. I’m next in line to the throne with the two of them out of the way I will have power over the law. No charges will be raised against you, then I shall abdicate and sail off into the distance.”

“How delightful for you.”

“Captain Napier I am deadly serious. I will kill the King of Hermia, with or without your help. I just thought I would do you the courtesy of offering you and your people something for your services. If you’re not interested I’ll find someone else.”

Napier rose to his feet and turned his back on Adiah. She had presented a golden opportunity for the Fimorri, although she hadn’t realised it. With Adiah on their side they could slowly integrate themselves back into the islands, once again claiming a stronghold on dry land. The King of Hermia was constantly seeking them out and whittling them down, his departure could bring about the return of the Fimorri for good. He knew exactly what needed to be done.

Turning round he smiled slyly; he only ever smiled slyly. “My vessel and my title are owned by the Fimorri Elders and a mission such as your own would require a degree of consultation before I could agree to anything.”

“I can wait,” Adiah said calmly.

“Then please enjoy the benefits of being *my* personal guest until I receive a response. If there is anything I can do for you, please do not hesitate to ask.” He was belittling her slightly to see how she would respond.

She ignored his sentiments but not his offer, “I will need a cabin for myself and Finn. Clothes of some sort would also be welcome.”

“It will be my pleasure.”

“And the services of Mr Wey, to run errands and the like.”

Napier’s eyes narrowed. “Mr Wey in particular, I am sure he will be delighted to oblige you.”

Five

Finn and Wey shared a small plate of cured pork on *the Liberty*. Their inexperienced crew shuffled around on deck in a state of total bewilderment while the shadow ship towered over them, harbouring a crew of cut throats and villains. A handful of *the Mirage's* crew had taken up residence on *the Liberty* and Wey and Finn were only there to ensure no difficulties broke out. So far everyone seemed to be working together which made Wey very uneasy. In his presence good things always had a tendency to go sour.

A strong arm smacked into Wey's back. "Not bad you scoundrel, not bad. Could have been bigger, but beggars can upgrade."

Wey shook his old friend's hand warmly. "Finn, meet the new Captain of *the Liberty,* Marvin Benton. Bennie's been Quartermaster with Napier for, hell, more years than I thought I'd live through."

Benton nodded his head and took a large helping of the meat Finn was holding. He shook Finn's hand with greasy fingers, pleased to note he didn't recoil or even flinch away from his slippery hand.

"Wey's been telling me you're a dandy at the old fencing lark. Could never get the footwork right myself." He feebly side stepped in case Finn thought he was being modest.

"Who needs footwork when you can smash their teeth in?" Wey replied helpfully.

"Staying for the launch? We are near enough ready. Wade and Maloney are covering the first league. You want to see how she handles under a master?"

"Aye all right. Finn you're welcome to come with us and ascertain how good a master this old bastard really is."

"To where?"

"About twelve furlongs that way," he said pointing to the south.

"I think it will probably be better if I make my way back to Adi."

Wey and Benton wiggled their thumbs in childish amusement.

Coop, *the Mirage's* engineer, stopped by them. He was holding a leather-bound book and scribbling in it disdainfully. Coop, one of the smallest of the crew, walked with a limp after breaking his leg six years ago and was forced into more sedate duties on *the Mirage*. He totted up some figures and shook his head as he scribbled numbers that only he could understand.

"Bad news?"

"Not really, not much to her though. What have I told you? When you bring me a boat make her sea worthy."

"She got here didn't she?"

"Aye and she'll be lucky if she makes it home." He sidled up closer to Wey. "And your crew look fit for the morgue," he murmured.

"So doctor what's the verdict?" Benton asked, cheerfully rubbing his hands together.

"Ship her back to the Barge, get her careened and made fit for you and you might have a new sweetheart if you treat her right."

"What about the crew?" Finn asked.

Coop jumped having not noticed Finn at all. "Ship them back as well, not much good to us out here." He glanced up at *the Mirage* and nodded. "Captain wants me," he told Wey as he moved away. "She's ready when you are *Captain* Benton." He elaborately bowed before skipping across the plank adjoining the ships.

"What will happen to them?" Finn asked concerned the men they had rescued were going to be disregarded with the other useless cargo.

"You worry too much," Wey replied. "They're natives so we'll clean them up and send them on their way. Damage is already done, not much point in us interfering now. This is good," he said filling his mouth with more meat. "Your ball and chain is waiting Brother, off you go."

Adiah could see her companions. She'd have to negotiate a very unsteady bridge to meet them and just at that moment she wasn't that confident on her feet. They had been chatting, even laughing together. Logically there was no reason the two of them should get along and yet they both seemed to be able to talk to each other quite happily. She tried to imagine all of the things they could have possibly gone through together and whether that was what united them, or whether it was just to irritate her. Then she remembered what she had done with Wey, the beach, the fields and she wondered if they were ever going to speak friendly words again.

The crew of *the Mirage* watched with pride as *the Liberty* set sail. They cheered and jeered as Captain Marvin Benton took the helm and tipped his hat to his former Captain on his beloved, former ship. The three men he had loaned, together with the four he had permanently taken swore and cursed at their crewmates in merriment as they began to move away from *the Mirage.* Even the rescued men seemed in good cheer as they were finally heading for a safe destination.

"Should we go after them Captain," Beau Saunders said, eager to test *the Liberty* against her stronger, older sister.

"Quarter-glass and we'll give chase. See if that sluggard has learnt anything."

Adiah leaned over the side of the boat, watching excitedly as her former ship was redeemed to something glorious. She felt an ache inside her to be on that voyage, despite the alluring *Mirage*, *the Liberty* had been hers first.

“Ship ahoy!”

Immediately she turned her head. Her eyes diverted to the horizon as a large vessel was on course to collide with *the Liberty*. Her heart sank. She waited for the crew to react. Nobody moved. Nobody except the Captain, who took his telescope and inspected the threat.

“What is it?” She whispered to Napier.

“Royal Navy of Hermia. Galleon, forty guns.” His moustache twitched in annoyance.

“They’re going to capture *the Liberty*,” she panicked.

Napier replaced his telescope carefully. She was powerful, but clumsy and would be no match for the speed of *the Mirage*, but *the Liberty* was under threat and any Captain with half an eye would have spotted the small vessel, flying unfamiliar colours and hiding behind a mere four guns. Still there was no reason to stop *the Liberty* if she responded rationally. If Benton could ensure his crew behaved appropriately the ships would only exchange a handful of words and this would be over in moments.

“Lively now lads, time to blend!”

Adiah was pushed about in the frenzy. The men around her became armed and painted. Liquid was poured over her until her head and her hands were stained white. Faces transformed into grizzly monsters, bending down and merging with their beloved ship. She was held to the floor by a large man with light hands. She watched as *the Liberty* bustled into life, casting nets into the ocean like fishermen. Wey was shouting orders. From where she was she couldn’t make out the words.

Finn crawled over to her to get a better view. “What’s going on?”

The large man told him to hush.

“They’re waiting to see if the ship passes them. They haven’t seen us yet.”

“They look like they’re going to crash straight into them.”

Adiah swallowed, “I think they’re going to board. Are they pulling up port side?” She tried to get a better view.

“Not doing nothing,” the big man said confused. “Captain?” He hissed. “Scupper, sink and burn me! Captain they’re heading straight for them!”

Adiah sat up. The crew around her rose and watched dumbfounded as the galleon refused to change coarse. *The Liberty* made an effort to swing herself around. Captain Benton yelled at the oncoming ship. Wey waved his hands frantically to attract some attention.

“Captain!” Adiah yelled, shattering the silence on deck. “Captain we have to help them!”

Napier didn’t move. He ran the calculations in his head. *Forty guns to his eighteen; four hundred men to his eighty*. *The wind blew west, the wind blew in their favour*. “Down helm! Close-haul. Hands to halyards! All hands. Man the larboard guns!”

Adiah was spun around. The crew threw themselves at their stations. Napier took the helm. She ran after him, dodging the crew. “You’re going to attack?” She panted.

Napier stared at his destination madly.

“This is insane!” She turned to the crew, amazed and terrified at their swift efforts. There was nothing left to do. Jumping onto the quarterdeck she held her breath and watched *the Liberty*.

The galleon moved determinedly through the sea. She made no efforts to change course, fighting the winds and all in her path. Her dark shadow eclipsed *the Liberty* in daylight darkness. Wey climbed the spritsail. He waved a flag at the blind ship. She kept coming. Then she struck. The boats trembled into each other. The galleon moved forward, fighting a trap of cracking wood and netted sails. *The Mirage* was closing in. They could hear the ship snapping! The foremast smashed into the deck pulling the waist of *the Liberty* into itself. *The Mirage* drew herself alongside. *The Liberty* was taking on water. She was going down! The bowsprit flew into the air. Still the galleon pushed forward. Wey grabbed hold of the beam as he was launched into the sky.

“Fire!” Napier screamed.

Cannon punctured the deck of *the Liberty* pummelling the bow of the galleon.

Adiah jumped up, looking for a way to get the crew off the smaller Fimorri ship. A shot was fired her way. Finn pulled her down.

Wey closed his eyes waiting to hit water. Rope scraped against his hands. He caught it. Slid down. Tore the flesh off his palms. Then floor and a nasty crack as something below him gave way. Quickly he got up to his feet and drew his pistol, expecting to be on the enemy ship.

“Princess?” He said perplexed. “Duck!” He pushed her head down and fired at the figures on the galleon. Then he fell to his knees, groaning. “I think I’m going to be sick.”

“Get us out of here!” Adiah yelled to anyone who would listen.

There were more volleys of gunfire. Adiah pressed her head to the deck. The ship began to move. Napier shouted orders that sounded like dogs barking at her. She couldn’t see anything. Finn was lying on the floor, Thorin beside him. Her hands reached out and touched Wey. She squinted and saw him lying on his back. On her hands and knees she pulled him up and shook him. *The Liberty* had gone. She stopped shaking and stared as the galleon continued its course, through the sunken wreckage. She looked up at the red faced soldiers, unmoving on deck.

The Mirage was gaining speed. Wey leapt to his feet and spurred himself into action. Adiah followed him. “What can I do?”

“We need more speed. Find someone heavier than you and throw them off.”

“I’m serious, let me help.”

He conceded. “Fine, help me cut the cable!”

“Battle, murder and shipwreck to those that cross me!” Napier yelled. “Damn you laggards! I’ll slit you collar to cock next time!” He jumped up to the edge of the deck and dropped his breeches.

“Does he always do this?” Adiah murmured.

“Changes from front to back, but mostly.” Wey winced as his hands began to sting.

“They’re keeping course! They can’t catch us now sir!”

“Set course for the reefs!” Napier said, toying with his belt buckle.

Six

The mood to *the Mirage* had changed. There was no idle talking, no squabbling or joking. The brandy and rum casks were sealed. Six of the crew were injured. Ten were dead, together with all of the survivors of the poppy fields. Wey had managed to escape unharmed by pure chance but Benton, the newly resigned Captain of *the Liberty* had been knocked into the sea and managed, through will alone, to grip hold of *the Mirage* as she began her escape, hooking his arm in her netting. When they finally slowed their pace to assess the damage the crew discovered the nearly drowned crewman, his arm almost totally torn off. It was a small miracle for the crew and not enough to rejuvenate them amid their losses.

The Mirage creaked and swayed under a gentle ocean. Benton screamed in the distance as the remaining tendons were severed from his shoulder. Finn had helped treat the other men until all he could see was blood and burns. He sat on the deck, defeated, watching the horizon with distrust. Men he had spoken to, men he had helped to rescue were now dead, sinking into the cold darkness. He closed his eyes and tried to count them but their faces were indistinguishable from each other. It angered him, he should be able to remember their names. And he was still alive, bobbing around in the ocean like driftwood. There were so many moments he could have been trapped on that ship and yet it was only when he was free that the soldiers came. Looking at the new crew around him, his fourth in a matter of weeks, made him feel terribly apprehensive for their safety.

Adiah squeezed his shoulder as she sat beside him. She winced involuntarily as Benton wailed once more, then it appeared all was over and the crew seemed to exhale. She had inspected the injuries, feeling fully responsible for the damage her family's ship had caused. She hadn't seen Wey for hours, despite searching the battered deck.

"I've asked Napier to help me," she told Finn as she rested her head on his tense shoulder.

Finn frowned, "To do what?"

"To kill my father and Con."

He sat back dumbfounded.

"You think it's a bad idea?"

"No, after losing my religion I threw out all my morals as well. Of course it's a bad idea! Adi lets just go to Helena, away from all of this."

"People are dying Finn, they have to be stopped and they have to pay for what they have done." She looked about the deck frustrated.

"What is it?"

"I just haven't seen Wey in a while."

“Not since he fell from the heavens,” Finn replied. “I can’t believe he made it out alive. Or Benton for that matter. I can’t believe they’re allowing us to stay with our luck.”

“Maybe we’re the ones keeping them alive,” she murmured. Her eyes lit up as she saw the flying pirate coming away from his Captain. He looked tired, more so than he ever had before. Blood had soaked his shirt and hands. He hung his shoulders low and walked without any hint of swagger.

He had held onto his comrade for two hours, pouring wine down the poor bastard’s throat while a hacksaw was rubbed against his shoulder bone and he waited, holding onto his friend, until he had passed out. He was drenched in sweat, his own and others. His body ached as its union with the deck was beginning to bruise and he was ready to give in and collapse. The day had been bad and he was ready to end it. He was tired of keeping his head above water. He needed rum.

“Egan?”

Too exhausted to get into another argument, he feigned deafness and tried to walk past her. She grabbed his hand and he winced as she touched his latest wound.

“How’s your friend?”

“Dandy.” He replied.

“I’ve asked Napier to help us.”

He looked at her blankly. “Good for you.”

“What’s wrong?” She said, concerned at the sudden change in him.

He grew angry and pushed his face into her own, baring his teeth like a rabid dog. “What’s wrong? Six of my friends are dead, I’ve spent two hours watching a lad I grew up with have his good arm hacked off. I ache everywhere, and my testicles have swollen up like fucking plums. What’s up with you?”

“I was just asking,” she hissed.

He spat on the floor. “Why don’t you go care for your boy, he might appreciate your incessant nagging.”

She folded her arms and watched as he stormed away. Finn felt inclined to stand by her side, despite the desire to stay well away from the pair of them. Their perpetual heated discussions were getting tiresome.

“What was that about?”

“Just the temperament of a pirate coming out I expect.”

“Has something happened I should know about?”

“No!”

“Something happened I shouldn’t know about?”

“I’m going to talk to Napier, are you coming?”

“Where else am I going to go?”

Seven

They came with the dawn. There was noise outside, then in the house. Rhoma held a pistol tightly in her hand. When the first soldier entered she fired. Dropping the redundant pistol she shrieked when the *should have been dead* soldier caught hold of her arms. He was unnaturally strong, with red, malicious eyes. He hit her across the face until she was too weak to obstruct them. She was dragged out by her hair and tossed into a cart with the other families, families she knew, with members noticeably missing, all bearing the marks of a beating.

A hand wrapped around her own and clenched it tightly. She glanced up at Miran Kirk, a Fimorri woman who lived three miles away. Her sons were all missing.

"Where's Llew?" She hissed desperately.

"On his way to the Barge. Yours?"

Miran shook her head and squeezed Rhoma's hand tighter.

By the time they reached their new home the cart was full.

Raingate Farm had been the largest on the island and the first to sow the poppies. The soldiers infiltrated the farm as workers before the residents had succumbed to the allure of the red charm. Then the expansion began. All of the farms were now under royal command. It had been a process that had taken months and the initial subtlety of the plan had now come to abundant fruition.

Pandora watched as the soldiers brought their new stock in from the outskirts of the island. There had been a lot of death in the town. Another symptom Eve had not anticipated. They would now have to use soldiers to maintain the fields. Soldiers, perhaps even stock. When the Prince arrived the island would need to be perfect. She gestured to one of the men taking charge of the morning patrol. All under the influence were afraid of her, she controlled their supplies of Red and she could quite easily create a drought. Without hesitation the soldier hurried to bow before her, kneeling in the dirt like a worthless vagrant.

"Have the Governor's house ready for the Prince. Stock it with food and wine and have it staffed." The latest cart rolled in.

With one raised finger she stopped the driver. "Get them all out!" She ordered.

The natives were dragged into the open. They cried as their injuries were aggravated but made no attempt to fight. The soldiers endeavoured to have them lined up in front of her, although they only succeeded in creating huddled family clusters. "Those five," she said. "Have them under close guard at the house until the Prince arrives." She turned to give the soldier more orders.

"You will not get away with this!" Miran shouted as two of her daughters were being dragged away.

Pandora stopped. She turned to the woman coolly, “If they do a good job they’ll live, which is more than the rest of you.” She stopped and looked at the only woman still in the cart.

“You,” she said. “Get out of there.”

Rhoma raised her eyebrow. “If we are going to die what difference does it make where?”

Pandora marched up to the cart and grabbed Rhoma’s wrist, dragging her from the cart without much effort. Rhoma stumbled, forcing her limp and frailty.

“Who are you?”

“Rhoma Regan,” Rhoma replied. “Wife of Gerin Regan.”

Pandora smiled with amusement, it was rare she got to meet an established name. “You are weak, your use to us is limited, but I could reach a compromise. For the right information your life could be saved.”

“As you said I am weak and useless what would be the point?”

“Your death will be painful. I could make it swift if you tell me where I might find more of your people.”

Rhoma looked the other woman up and down. She had disguised it well, but there was no denying she was a native islander. Beneath her died hair and manipulated frame she shared more in common with the stock than the soldiers.

“Why don’t we start with your people first?” Rhoma murmured.

Pandora’s smile faded. “This one goes last.” She shouted. “A head like yours may need some time to evaluate the situation, give you chance to change your mind.”

Eight

Napier held the service for his dead men personally. He recited the names of the departed with honest compassion. He had already dispatched the news to the Barge. It would take a while for his birds to arrive, but soon the widows and children would know their men died an honourable death. Napier had held services more often than he cared to remember and he would hold more before the year was out. A good crew was hard to come by and with each year his tightly bound men became loosened. They were not traditional pirates; they were family men of the same blood. They were there for their people and their families and with each loss the pirates felt their burden grow.

Benton lit the ceremonial raft, this time empty of bodies as it began coasting across the ocean. It could have been him on the pyre and, despite his injury, he was grateful he had made it through another battle.

A ghostly silence fell upon the boat as the flames lapped at the sky, consuming the effigy of life. It was the emblem of loss and the Fimorri were so plagued by such sites it was becoming their motif. Each man saw the glowing timber and remembered those that had been lost and those that were long lost. They saw the raft break up and start to sink, knowing, inevitably, their bodies would lie on the ocean bed in good time. One or two pirates glanced at each other hoping they would be the first because the thought of losing another brother would be more unbearable.

Finn ran the death rite through his head. He wanted to say something profound to commemorate the brave men that had returned to the earth, but he felt too consumed by his own sorrow. He was alive while all around him ebbed away. His heart remained a constant thumping and Laura's was being consumed in the ground. Families had lost their lifeline, and Finn stood there, breathing air that should have been breathed by better lungs for no rightful purpose at all. He was a thief.

"Farewell brothers, known and unknown. Rest until you are reborn and be reborn back into our arms!" Napier removed his hat and bowed his head.

Adiah watched him awestruck. His presence dominated the ship like a rising sun in the morning sky. Here Napier was God. No whispers could be heard from any set of cocky lips and there were enough of them to spare on *the Mirage*. Her attention was so transfixed she missed the pirates picking up their instruments behind him. Then unexpectedly Napier began to sing in a heavenly, deep, baritone voice. His song was sorrowful and captivating. Adiah felt herself moving closer through the crowd, enchanted by the melody. The musicians started to play and the ship was filled with a beautiful harmony. Adiah closed her eyes to listen to the mandolin, accordion and harmonica; tattered instruments played by tattered pirates in mourning. A bow struck the strings of a violin and she was transported. She couldn't remember hearing anything more magnificent.

Leisurely she opened her eyes and watched Wey as he played out her soul on his fiddle. Her heart rose to her throat as the barbarian unravelled everything within her. Then there was drumming. Death had left the ship, now life took charge. The band was thrown into a shanty of terrifying proportion. Around her the crowd began to move and then erupted into a circle of dancing. She was forced to the edge of the ship as the music roared. In amazement she turned to the man beside her.

"Is this a normal funeral?"

Benton nodded. "Happens at the end of every funeral, every celebration and the start of every week. They don't call us *the Mirage Symphony* for nowt."

"It's strange."

"We mourn the passing and we celebrate the life," he replied loudly, tapping his feet. "It's therapeutic. Care to dance?"

"To dance?" She said blushing.

"Pigeon don't let it go to your head. If you turn me down I'll be asking Coop as usual and he has hips that can move as well as any petticoat."

Adiah smiled and held out her hand, keeping her other behind her back. Benton led her into the circle. The men separated to let him through and together two ex-Captains of the demolished ship began to move majestically to the symphony.

The music began to override the grief. Eventually there was only sound and movement. Adiah danced like she had always wanted to, released from the confines of ballroom etiquette. Her partner changed and then changed again as the music grew louder and faster. Punch and wine spilled into the crowd intoxicating and soothing as needed. Adiah turned to see Napier holding her hand and twirling her around. She glanced at Wey, but he was absorbed in hammering his instrument with every ounce of emotion he had left inside him.

Then she was released and sent hurtling across the deck. Out of breath and thirsty she quickly found a cup of punch, swallowed it in three gulps and took another. Finn was watching everything from afar. His mood was unaffected by the celebration. She reached out for him.

"Dance with me!"

"No," he said adamantly.

"Please, come on Finn one dance and I shall leave you be for the rest of your life."

"I can't dance."

"I don't care, come on." She pulled him to her and dragged him into the circle.

Finn moved like a puppet corpse. His face was twisted in unbearable agony as his stiff limbs dallied in the air. Adiah tried to entice him, tried to resurrect the old dances they performed as children, but she would have been better dancing round a maypole. Then something clicked in him. His feet took over, taking the opportunity to break away from his grief, and began to work quickly

on the deck. He took her hands and drew her close to him, matching her steps occasionally and mainly treading on her toes.

Wey glared at the pair. His fingers worked the strings of his fiddle in a fury. He struck each note, harder and faster. The band around him hurried through the song, forcing Napier to give way to a violent violin solo. Wey stepped forward and began to play like he had never before. The crew turned their full attention to the dancing pair and to the boy who was starting to flag. They waited eagerly for Finn to drop from the circle, ready to pounce upon the Princess themselves. Finn lost his footing and tripped. He gained his balance and saluted Adiah. His debt was paid and he retreated to his position away from the circle.

The crew breathed in, ready to take the plunge and join the frenzy of dancing and music. Wey strode into the empty circle. Adiah faced him, the punch taking hold of her confidence. She could dance as quick as he could play. They fought amid the merriment, each growing more ostentatious in their displays of talent. Wey's notes were perfect, Adiah's energy relentless. She turned and pivoted without stumbling. Wey slowed his tempo. He lowered his violin to the floor to bow to the Princess. The band accompanied him in a low hum of submission. Then he launched his last attack. His finger tips began to split as he burst forth with everything he had left. The music was so precise, so beautifully exact and passionate it caught Adiah totally off guard. She stopped, out of breath, conceding defeat. Victoriously Wey smirked and headed back into the bosom of his bewildered band. Napier struck up another song and Adiah took the smaller hands of Llew to end the night. When she got chance she glanced back at Wey who seemed content to blend with the crew once more.

The boat began to settle as the warm blanket of alcohol subdued the crew. Napier sat on an ornate throne he'd had pulled out of the hold and was so drunk he could barely sit up in it. Most of the crew lay where they collapsed, some blanketed in urine and vomit. A fight had broken out and the two fighters now rested against each other like lovers beside the mainmast. Finn had retired long before the drinking got out of hand and had managed to succumb to sleep in the cabin he shared with Adiah, but the night air and excitement had enticed Adiah to stay awake.

Benton was propped up against one of his sleeping comrades. The unconscious pirate was covered in sick and Benton couldn't remember if he had been responsible. Since *the Liberty* sank he had been in a perpetual intoxicated state, which gave him an advantage on his friends. He still couldn't move properly, but he could see and he spied the ship's guest glancing at the faces of the sleeping pirates. She saw him and acknowledged him with a quick wave, then he saw her look at her own hand guiltily. For a moment it struck him as strange until he remembered. The absurdity made him chuckle to himself; *don't mind me Princess I'm armless*. Then the smile faded when he

realised what his wife would make of him now, his left hand was going to have to get some practice in if he was going to satisfy her again.

"Princess!" He bellowed. "Princess," he reached out to her. "I need a hand." He exploded in laughter.

Adiah helped him to his feet. His huge bulk nearly toppled them both over.

"Where can I take you Mr Benton?"

"Pigeon you can take me anywhere. You know my wife says I'm very handy," he started laughing again, then began wheezing with the pain of it. "What's she going to say now?"

Adiah looked him up and down, "Certainly not that you're stumpy."

He collapsed to the floor giggling. Wiping his eyes he pushed away her attempts to bring him back to his feet. "He's in the brig."

"Who is?"

"Man you're looking for."

She wrapped her coat around herself. She hadn't been looking for Wey, not really. He was around and she might have bumped into him; that would be all. Only now she knew where he was, she could no longer wander and meet him by chance. She had a choice, leave him be or find him. Her feet led the way, ignoring the debate in her head.

It was dark and she nearly tripped over Thorin. He'd taken up refuge below deck and was determined not to be moved until dawn despite the number of pirates toppling over him. Adiah scratched his head before moving on. She felt her way into the brig and then felt moisture beneath her boots. A small lamp glowed in the distance, lighting up shadows and memories. She felt like this place was a second home to her and that she could map every corner with her eyes closed. Only there was something out of place.

"Insubordination?" She said to the chained figure.

"Worse, impromptu solo," he grumbled.

"How long have you been down here?"

"When did they finish the ham?"

"Hours ago!" She sidled up to him. "Am I safe here?"

"I don't know, monkey see."

His feet had been shackled, but his hands remained free. He wasn't very drunk, which surprised her greatly. After a moment's hesitation she sat down and tried to justify why she had come.

"I didn't know you played."

"You've obviously not read my biography," he sneered. "What are you doing down here?"

"Benton said you were here."

“So you fancied a tour?”

“Actually I came for the inspirational conversation.”

He cracked a smile. “Napier told me you hired me.”

“I want to kill the King of Hermia.”

“Nice easy job then.”

“Will you do it?”

“I didn’t think it was up to me.”

Adiah blushed, she realised she’d made another crucial mistake. “Sorry I should have asked you first. Will you help me?”

“You know I will.” He banged his head on the wall. “What are you doing here Adi, I thought you had a full bed in your cabin?”

“It’s not like that,” she said through gritted teeth.

“You mean he hasn’t gotten over his dead wife yet?”

“Don’t be an arsehole.” She sighed. “That was one party. I think I danced with everyone on the ship.”

He grunted, “Aye I’d say you’ve made a full recovery.”

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“If you have something to say...”

Bile was rising in the back of his throat. “Just for a girl who couldn’t bear to be touched you sure as hell had a lot of hands on you tonight and it didn’t seem to bother you!”

“So that was what the stupid competition was about. You told me to amputate the Vaults from my life and when I do you get all hot headed about it.”

She was right but he was damned if he let her win another battle. “You haven’t cut out the Vaults, you’ve become it. There’s nothing left of your virtue now.” He waited for a slap, when it didn’t arrive he looked to see her smiling sympathetically at him, as though he were a child that had discovered fairies weren’t real.

“Don’t be so naïve Wey. I was a Princess, every soldier, footman and stable boy was on standby for me.”

He eyed her with suspicion. “Why did you come down?”

“There’s something about seeing you chained up that really does it for me.” She rose.

“Stable boy?”

Nine

Llew's hands were bleeding. He'd tried to ignore the pain for the first hour, but as the blisters popped they began to sting relentlessly. The men had taunted him for being too slow, too weak, even too young; he was damned if he was going to give them another excuse to mock him. At least that was an hour ago. Now he felt fit to give in and throw himself overboard. He wiped his sweaty brow and stained it red.

"What the hell have you done to yourself you idiot?" Mr Hanse, the master gunner shouted. He roughly took Llew's hands and inspected them with distaste. "And so you think you'd get blood all over the ship did you?"

"No sir," Llew said exhausted.

"Fancied getting yourself off duty, eh?"

Llew shook his head exasperated. "No sir, I… I didn't notice." It was an obvious lie, but Hanse had been in Llew's position just like the others, albeit many moons ago, and he knew when enough was enough. "Get yourself cleaned up and if I catch you working like that again I'll flog you from port to starboard you hear me."

"Yes sir," Llew replied and reluctantly left the small handful of crew who were doing more than drinking and sunbathing.

He felt like crying and sucked back the tears with all the Fimorri pride he had left within him. He'd been dreaming of sailing the ocean for months, but now all he dreamed about was home. The crew treated him like the rats that infested the boat. He was exhausted and hadn't slept since he'd arrived. Most of all he was ashamed of himself and prayed his mother would never hear of the failure he'd become.

"Nasty," Adiah said looking over him. "Let me see."

She sat beside him radiantly. The days at sea had revitalised her and the grand attire she had been loaned from Captain Napier made her look like some exotic traveller. They sat on the floor in the crew's quarters. The senior crew claimed the hammocks and runts like Llew made do with gaps on the floor. He sat on his space, spreading out for the first time. Eight men slept around them loudly.

"It's nothing," he grunted snatching his hands away.

"Looks painful, you should have said something sooner, wouldn't be so bad then."

"It's nothing." He stuffed his hands beneath his armpits and held in a wince.

"I seem to remember, when I hurt my own hand, a young man helping me. Perhaps you'll let me repay the favour."

"Don't need any favours from you!"

She folded her arms indignantly. “I’ll go then, leave you here on your own.”

He screwed his lips together, forcing the growing hairs under his nose to cluster in a small dark square.

“You’ll get used to it.”

“It’s alright for you!” He snapped. “They like you, can’t get enough of you!”

She bent closer to him. “Honey if you were paying them they might be kissing your backside as much as mine. They’re just putting you through the motions, in a few days you’ll be lying in the sun with the rest of the drunks and this will seem like a fond memory.”

He didn’t believe her.

“Napier told me he’d not seen a lad work as hard as you before,” she lied.

He straightened up.

“Now let me have a look at your wounds, if you get them infected you’ll end up having them off and what good will you be then?”

Reluctantly he showed her.

Finn sat in his shared quarters. He’d been nursing a bottle of Hangman’s Blood for sometime. So far he had only managed a few gulps, but it was enough to spiral his mind into another moral dilemma. He was coming to terms with his mourning as he began to recognise the process. The bottle was just another stage and not one he was convinced he should be taking it. Surely if he could recognise his symptoms he could do something about them.

The sea swayed him into restlessness. He wanted to put his feet on dry land, land he wasn’t familiar with. He took a deeper gulp of liquor and felt another death within him. A young, idealistic priest could not be mourning the death of his wife on a pirate ship. No, the priest must have drowned in the dark waters that swallowed the rest of the world. He gulped down more, desperate to be intoxicated and angry his abstinence seemed to have bred tolerance rather than the contrary.

“Goodbye Brother,” he toasted.

The world seemed to flicker in front of him. He felt himself move, despite being stationary.

“Adi, last night…” Wey burst into the cabin and stopped. “Finn?”

“Adiah isn’t here,” Finn slurred.

Wey smiled, trying to look puzzled. “Of course not. I was… I was looking for you mate.”

Finn scowled and shook his head. The pair of them had dragged him down into enough confusion already.

“Not seen you for a while.”

He shrugged and finished the bottle.

“Easy there big fella. Not so easy to come by that stuff.”

"I'm not surprised, it's horrible."

Wey nodded in reluctant agreement. "Still thinking about *her*?"

"Her, me, this place. Home." He put the empty bottle down. "I don't know what to do."

"Seems like to me you have two options. Go back to the way you was before, or move on to pastures new."

"That easy?"

Wey removed his own hip flask and offered it to Finn. "Life's as easy as you make it my friend." He took a mouthful himself before slipping the flask back into his coat. "Of course that woman of yours makes things more complicated, with all her talk of revenge and teasing, you I mean, not doing much for your grieving is it. All this sharing quarters, damn right imposing of her really. Then dragging us both off to kill her father. Makes you wonder why we rescued her in the first place."

"Is there something going on with you and Adiah?" Finn asked as Wey's image began to blur.

"What! Don't be stupid Finn. That's the grog talking, otherwise I'd be offended. Like I'd betray a friend like you. And we are friends aren't we Finn, wouldn't go around stabbing each other in the back over a doxy. Not one like her anyway. Weeks of her moaning I've had to listen to. You know I think I know why they stuck her in the Vaults in the first place. Not that I'm saying she deserved it. No probably a bit harsh, but in principle. Of course I see she needs to get her revenge. Fully support her there, and, well, she is paying for my services, so she must value my skill at least. In fact that's probably it; she needs a rogue like me to watch her back. Just her back mind, as I said wouldn't be treading on nobody's toes. Not even if I wanted to, which I definitely don't. Not my type at all."

"Simple 'no' would have been fine," Finn replied with a slight dizzy smile.

Wey cleared his throat. "Sorry, I'm sure she's a delight."

Laying back on the bed Finn felt the alcoholic warmth hold him. "She's amazing. After everything that has happened to her she still looks after me." He smiled sadly. "When you get to know her you'll love her as much as I do. I think she's probably the only thing stopping me jumping overboard."

Inside, Wey groaned. Then the bells began to ring.

Napier was restless. There had been no news from Juliet since they had dispatched the pigeons. Then an hour ago he received the last Fimorri words from the island.

Wey held the small scroll tightly. He'd withdrawn himself into the shadows and waited, mouth dry, fists clenched. Adiah was standing and ready to meet their Captain in the face if she

needed to. The news had all the potential to ruin her plans and she couldn't let it. Finn sat beside her with a grave glaze to his eyes. He watched Wey empathetically. Benton sat wide legged at the other side of the gallery ignoring the lot of them.

The message simply read: *Juliet is lost. Retreat. RR*

"And you are sure it's genuine, not just some ploy to get you out of here?" Adiah asked.

"Not by no manner of circumstance," Benton replied, wondering why such matters needed an audience. "Her hand, her words."

Napier held his pipe to his lips. He sucked at it hard until his lungs felt as though they were about to explode. He slowly exhaled. "She's dead Wey," he said bluntly.

"Yes Captain."

"Captain, she might not be," Adiah said interrupting them. "She could just be a prisoner."

"My dear woman," Napier growled. "Prisoner, traitor, worm meat, Rhoma Regan is dead to this ship. Rest of them too. Juliet's lost, we need to change course. Inform the Elders."

Benton rose to apply his orders.

"What about the King?" Adiah shouted, angrily fighting off Finn's attempts to quiet her. "He did this, you need to stop him!"

"Listen Princess," Benton began. "There are bigger things to think about than revenge here."

"Bigger! My father has wiped out that island. His army came after us! They took your crew, your arm!"

Napier held up his hand and Benton withheld his reply. "Commission a bird to the Elders, a falcon I want it there quickly. Explain the situation in detail. Just the facts Mr Benton. Request an immediate response."

"What about Llew?" Adiah said exasperated. She looked to Wey but could barely make his face out of the dull light. "Someone needs to tell him."

"Very well, you tell him Princess, but do it before his starts his watch."

"I didn't mean me. He looks up to you Captain. Or you Mr Benton. It would be better from you."

Napier's lip twitched. He had no intention of talking to the boy. Benton too stood defiant, hoping his Captain might crack before he did,. He was about to concede when he was interrupted.

"I'll do it." Finn said.

Napier grinned. "Good man. Before his shift though Brother Finn. Allow him some means to channel his aggression."

Napier indicated he had grown weary of his guests and waved them away impatiently. Wey was the first to bolt and quickly hauled open the door. His hands still clutched the note. He wanted to let it go but his fingers disobeyed him. There was anger inside, burning anger and he needed a

drink. Storming through the ship, he made sure everyone knew something was wrong. He banged on the walls below deck, kicked at the barrels around his feet. Thorin watched him from a safe distance for a few moments and then thought better of it. Adiah was braver.

She hurried after him, although she tried to be more discreet as she weaved through the other pirates. When he finally stopped she caught him. He closed his eyes wishing he could have a moment alone. Her hand touched his shoulder and he flinched.

"She might still be alive," she whispered.

He wanted to hit her, to shake her and make her see that this false hope would only make it harder. Rhoma was dead. They were all dead and he would not be the only man to feel it tonight. He had been fond of his sister, even if she did terrify him at times. And now he would have to look into the eyes of his nephew and they would share the knowledge that she was gone. He would see his other sisters and another would be missing. It never got easier, he didn't want it to, and fighting would only prolong the agony.

"Just leave me alone," he demanded. "Go tend to your own grieving widow."

"Egan, I'm sorry."

"Why?"

"What?"

"Why are you sorry?"

"Don't be difficult."

"Tell me, why? Did you do it?"

"Do it? Don't be stupid."

"Then why? It's no real loss to you, why be sorry about it?"

"I'm sorry for you. Bloody hell Egan I'm trying to be nice."

"Nice people would comfort me with rum."

"Naïve people would comfort you with rum."

He spat at the floor in disgust.

"Egan," she said softly. "I was just trying to help."

"Yeah well you should have come down with a bottle of rum between your legs. That would have helped."

He rubbed his face, sat down and fidgeted for a while. She ignored his hostile pose and tried to hold his hands and rub his shoulders in an attempt to diffuse his grief. Her hands were warm and he realised he needed to keep her attention to continue her caressing.

"Jai was the first." He abruptly said. "She got tangled in some netting, pulled under the water. Crew couldn't get her out in time. Then Bridget got sick and didn't make it to spring. We did

what we could for her, took care of her kids and what not. Now Rhoma." He tried to force tears to little success.

"Does it get any easier?"

He shook his head. "Not really. Longer they live, longer you like them or at least get used to them being there. Rhoma was the one who watched out for us all. I didn't have to check in with the others, just her. We all checked in with her and so we all knew what was going on." He scratched his head and groaned. "I should tell Llew."

"Finn will do it. He's good at that type of thing."

"Is there no end to that boy's talents?" Wey half-heartedly teased. "Go on I'll be fine. We Fimorri are used to heavy losses."

"Stand up," she ordered.

"What?"

"Just do it."

He moaned as he got to his feet. She snatched his hands and placed one on her hip, the other she held tightly. Then she began to sing, off key, the only song she could remember from the last wake.

"What are you doing?" Wey whispered, holding her close to him and smelling the salt on her hair.

"I thought this is what you do to remember the dead."

He almost smiled. "You sound awful."

"You smell awful, you don't hear me complaining."

"No, makes a refreshing change, my sisters should die more often."

Adiah closed her eyes. "You know he did it don't you? My father. He killed Rhoma and the others on the island. He needs to be stopped." She lifted her head up and pressed her lips against his.

Cautiously he pulled away. "Turning your talents to whoring now my dear?"

She scowled. "What do you mean?"

He turned away and tried to wipe the taste of her off his lips. "No I'm not playing this game."

"What are you talking about?"

Lashing round he grabbed hold of her. "I know what you're doing. Keep me sweet and I'll make sure Napier takes you where you want to go. Hell, don't think me prudish, I've had many a fine night writhing under your like, but there's more to you than curves and kisses poppet." He released her and held up his hands. "By all means my darling, part those legs and I will pay in kind, but I'll not be whispering your words in my Captain's ear."

His cheek stung and held a red image of her hand. She was furious.

“Little harder on the other cheek and I might change my mind,” he jeered.

She tried to hit him again but he caught her hand. “No more games Adi.” Beaten she stormed away.

Wey folded his arms smugly. Someone patted his shoulder making him jump.

“Smooth Romeo, real smooth,” Benton said as he barged passed.

Finn walked away from Llew. He’d said all that could be said. The boy had taken the news surprisingly stoically. He’d cry soon enough, when he was away from the men. Finn had done his duty, he’d offered his own wisdom, allowed a brief insight to his own experience and, in time it would be received.

He walked on deck with his hands behind his back. It had been a while since he’d moved like a priest and he was surprised to find it comforting. Several of the crew had stopped working. One openly wept, the others chewed at their fingers or intoxicated their bodies. Finn had seen the ship in mourning, this was far more intense. He spotted Wey standing on the bow of the ship and moved towards him.

“Bleak day,” Finn said.

“Not our best.” Wey replied looking at the water, “How’s Llew?”

“Stronger than he looks. Stronger than me anyway. How are you?”

Wey shrugged.

“When my mother died…” he began.

Wey held up his hand and forced a smile. “I appreciate the effort friend but there is more to this than death. When our people were forced out of our islands we lived in dire exile for years. Gradually we’ve crept back, found a stronghold on each island. We made valuable allies, kept a continual stock of our own people flowing through them. Juliet was a safe haven. We had enough people there to make it a stopping point for all of our journeys. Some of the men had families there. We all had friends there.” He took a deep breath. “A lot of them innocent. On this boat we expect to die, our time is borrowed and we’ll all meet our maker doing what we love. Men we lost last week knew where they’d end up. But them on that island didn’t want this life, they wanted to go back home. To their rightful home. They should have been safe.”

Finn looked around at the boat. The men were husks of their former selves.

“Maybe your Princess is right, maybe we do need to take some revenge.” Wey mumbled.

“Let’s wait to see what your Elders say first,” Finn reasoned. “There’s no point fighting a war you can’t win.”

“Winning is not necessarily the point Finn. Come on, let’s get pissed and make music.”

The falcon came back within the week. In which time the crew drank themselves into oblivion. Wey remembered very little of those weary days, although he was sure he argued with Adiah on two further occasion and had a distinct memory of been dragged from the mainmast by Finn. His head was pounding, his fingers were aching from the constant playing and Napier still insisted on his being present. He could barely stand, or sit for that matter, so instead he slumped himself in the corner of the room and rested his head on Thorin's back.

Napier sat back in his chair. He'd maintained a degree of sobriety over the week in anticipation of these letters. Benton held the most important one close to his face. He skimmed the contents quickly before he read it aloud.

"In light of recent events the Elders recall all vessels home by the new moon." Benton's finger tapped the word *home* longingly.

Napier poked the charred tobacco from his pipe and carefully refilled it, adding his own herbal concoction in calculated layers. "The supplies?"

"Be tight but not impossible. Might be worth taking a ship or two, be on the safe side."

"Wey," Napier said, "Still with us?"

"Barely," Wey grumbled through his intoxication.

"Our guests pose a potential problem."

"He's right, we can't bring them to the Barge, with things the way they are. The Elders wouldn't like it."

"You want to ditch them, leave them floating in a dingy somewhere?"

Napier shook his head, "No, the Princess could be useful to us. We need to ensure she is kept sweet. *You* need to stay with them and escort them back to Hermia. Find out what you can and stay invisible."

"She wants to kill the King."

"She wants a lot of things she's not getting at the moment Mr Wey. You will have the next ship. Take it to Hermia and stay with Groader until I send for you."

"A ship?" Wey said confused.

"Aye, Mr Benton will Captain it with two extra hands. Six of you should make it there and back without much difficulty."

Benton's face dropped. "Sir?"

Napier ignored him. "Set coordinates for the Barge Mr Benton."

Disheartened, Benton left the room.

"He was hoping to go home." Wey murmured.

“He’s the best man aboard this ship, he stays with you. The girl must be kept safe; she could be our ticket to returning to the homeland. Sacrifices must be made. I am sure Benton would like to see his little ones playing in fields and not jumping over sharks on the Barge.”

Wey sighed and nodded. He looked at the table. “How’s Mora?”

Napier glanced at the note. He would have flogged other men for prying but Wey was permitted. He fingered the paper; its presence alone confirmed his wife was well enough to send him some acknowledgement to the filth he had sent her.

“As you’d expect.”

“Been a while. Does she know about Rhoma?”

“Not yet. She’s in the tropics, long way for news to travel.”

Wey rubbed his bloodshot eyes. “She’s going to be mad. They were close.”

“Time to compose yourself Mr Wey. You need to be on your game, I need you to be on your game. If you fuck this up the Elders will punish me and I will punish you tenfold.”

“Ship ahoy!” Bellowed Benton from the poop deck.

Ten

Balor slipped into the shadows as the boat unloaded. He could feel the Red burning in his blood. Thoughts of malice and violence were beginning to cloud his judgement again. The poison was taking more control. This was his third dose and already he felt like another might obliterate any natural consciousness he still held on to. It would pass though. He had been careful to monitor the amounts injected, he was surviving on less than a quarter of what the soldiers used and craved. Balor spent his coherent moments piecing together the knowledge he had acquired. Again and again the same thoughts repeated in his head, the thoughts being the barrier that was keeping his existence from slipping away.

The Red would only last a matter of days, and it concerned Balor that its strength was far greater than his initial dose. He worried he had taken too much, that he had been careless in his understanding of the drug. He grew angry with himself. His fists clenched; the crippling arthritis a thing of the past. The feet beneath him stamped violently on the ground and he began to look for something to hurt.

Native blood, mixed with the poppies, fermented in bodies, injected in soldiers. The native blood, mixed with the poppies, fermented in bodies, injected in soldiers. Soldiers grow strong, unaffected by pain, become violent and aggressive, then unstoppable. Balor lifted his head and could remember the rest. Quickly he weaved through the streets and slithered underground.

Eleven

The crew of *the Mirage* were hungry wolves circling a quivering fawn. Their mouths salivated in anticipation of fresh meat. The crew of *the Mirage* were white ghouls, rattling chains and wailing damnation to all in their path. Captain Napier clutched the hilt of his cutlass, the lime paint on his knuckles cracked with each movement. He licked his arid lips. The ship in the distance was a rabbit in a meadow, it grazed greedily, carelessly.

"Soldiers, sir," Mr Kent said after a brief glance through the telescope. "Looks like a Brigantine, not a navy vessel. Still got her fishing nets on deck."

Napier took the eyeglass. Sure enough the men were wearing uniforms, but they were not the usual soldiers stock. There were only fifteen on the ship regardless. The pack leader let his hunger take over. He would be the first to fiercely leap from his sanctuary. He would expose his neck to clamp down on another's. And he would do it without doubt, or hesitation, like every other man who stood beside him.

They had minutes, stealthily approaching, a mere shadow on the landscape. Their breathing unified with the rock of the ship as it charged through the waves. White stained savages held their weapons and skilfully controlled their vessel towards the prey. Seconds.

"Bring me blood!" Napier screamed.

They stormed the vessel.

Unsuspecting soldiers turned to see the image of a ship looming over them. They gawped as a seventy demon faced monster charged at them. Their polluted minds could barely process the danger. As cutlasses penetrated their flesh, they dropped to the floor and stared up at the bright sky. It was then that they understood. It was then that they took action.

The pirates cheered. The ship was theirs. Napier stood tall, leeching the victory for himself. He smiled, cracking more of his broken skin. And then his face fell.

The corpses rose. Men in soldier uniforms stood upright, blood pooling from their fatal wounds. They drew their weapons and they began to attack. Red eyes blazing, demons and monsters began to collide.

"Their heads!" Wey shouted. "Cut off their heads!"

Adiah ran to the deck of *the Mirage*; Finn behind her, trying to draw her back to safety. They stopped and watched as soldiers ran through blades to cut at pirates. One had Wey cornered. Adiah moved to join them.

"No!" Finn yelled. He removed his own sword. "You just stay here out of trouble."

He leapt to join the brawl. Instinct moved him against the soldiers. He stabbed the man attacking Wey, but it was like he had sliced air. Quickly he withdrew his sword and whipped it across the man's neck. His head toppled onto the deck and rolled to join four other comrades.

"Nice of you to join us Mr Fernwick," Wey replied out of breath.

"Not at all," Finn offered Wey a hand and drew him away from the edge of the ship.

"Well if you'll excuse me," Wey said tipping his head.

"Certainly."

He leapt into the brawl and was lost to Finn again. The soldiers' resilience was no match for the numbers of *the Mirage*, like bees, they engulfed the unholy crew and spat them out across the ocean, letting the waves finish what they couldn't. This time there was no jeering. The crew, five down from when they started, sighed in relief. Some men collapsed on the foreign deck in dismay.

Napier wiped the blood from his hands. "Dead men do not fight back!" He yelled at the ocean. "Mr Wey! Brimstone, shit and gall! Why are my men dead?"

Wey perched against the mast, breathless and dumbfounded.

"It's the poppies," Adiah shouted from *the Mirage*. The crew turned to look at her, desperate to receive some sane explanation for what had happened. "Look at their eyes, it's the same thing we saw on Juliet."

Napier spat on the floor. "Scabrous swine!" He flexed his muscles and inspected the ship. "Right you bilge drinking cunts prepare this vessel!"

The shock and exhaustion would have to wait. The crew began to move, inspecting the ship and repairing the damage from the battle.

Beau Saunders looked like hell had spat him out. Covered in blood and stinking of sweat he was the image of a horrific giant, hunting for tiny men. Even beneath the grime of a good battle he was still the ugliest son of a bitch to sail the ocean. Beau had a face only a mother could love, and she loved him enough to announce the fact every time his name was called. Beau didn't care, he was an oaf, he was clumsy and slow, but he made experienced soldiers piss their pants on sight and that was fulfilment enough. He had sailed on *the Mirage* for as long as he could remember, Napier claimed he had served for six years, some of them very long indeed.

As the giant descended below deck he cast a truly nightmarish picture for the prisoners beneath. They caught sight of his heavily tattooed arms and hands missing more fingers than was useful, worse still, the shadow that followed Beau filled them with terrified thoughts of cannibalism and sacrifice. The pirate Abram joined his friend's side.

Years before, Beau had managed to pull Abram's drowning body free from a sinking slave ship, whilst the rest of the crew pillaged and demolished what they could. The Fimorri didn't deal

with slaves, but the ship was already sinking. Abram was the only captive on the ship to survive and was now another Fimorri.

Abram's eyes glowed beyond his black complexion. He peered into the cages around him in amazement. Where he would expect to see his kin he found only his adopted tribe. Beau too was totally baffled by the sight before him and, as always when Beau felt confused, he drew his pistol and aimed it at the chained men.

"Captain!" He bellowed. "Captain, think you're going to want to see this!"

Wey and Benton made it down into the hold first, with Finn in tow. Men, women and a handful of children huddled in family groups within poorly constructed cages. They were starved, dirty and yet beneath the famine and filth wore respectable clothes and had merchant hands and innocent eyes. Finn was the first to approach the cages. He knelt down to the closest bars and inspected the mother and daughters inside. She glared at him blankly, clutching her two daughters to her sagging chest as though it were the only thing left for her to do. One of the girls, the smallest, was dead; the other stared off into the distance waiting to join her ghost sister.

"What the devil is going on?" He gasped. "We need to unchain them," he demanded.

"Nobody does anything until Captain says so," Beau replied, his pistol still drawn. "Might be these are some more dangerous crazies, sure as anything we don't want them running amuck under our feet."

Wey pushed Beau's pistol aside. "Only dangerous crazy is you, you focsle-head. Get Napier down here now!"

Beau grumbled and slumped off with Abram behind him.

"Can you speak?" Finn asked the woman. "We're not going to hurt you."

She was too weak to move, all her effort concentrated in protecting her young and she would rather die that way than chance losing them.

"Who are you?" A man called from the far cage.

"Men with guns," Wey replied sharply, "And keys. And a barrel full of questions. Who are you?"

The man clutched his bars proudly. "John Anderson, of Meadow Grove, Juliet."

"My name is Finnian Fernwick," Finn said softly. "What are you doing down here?"

"The soldiers arrested us. We are due to be transported to Hermia."

Wey and Finn shared a quick look. "So you're from Juliet," Wey said. He approached the cages and inspected the prisoners. "Aye you all look fairly native to me, I'll bet there's not a drop of Qatarian blood between you."

“Mr Wey report!” Napier said as he descended the stairs. If he was shocked he didn’t show it. He inspected the prisoners with disinterest. They were frightened of him, any further displays of his power would be unnecessary. He tapped the hilt of his cutlass and waited for a response.

“Prisoners, sir,” Wey replied. “Natives.”

Napier raised an eyebrow. “Mr Benton how many alive?”

“Half dozen. Not much use in them mind.”

“They’re just here,” Finn hissed.

“Not for much longer given the look of them,” Benton mumbled.

Napier turned his back and gestured for Wey to follow him. They reached fresh air and both men took several heavy breaths. “Report?”

Wey scratched his head. “Don’t know sir. They’re from Juliet. By the look of them I’d say most will be dead before sunrise. The women and children sooner. One of them looks fit enough for questioning, might be an idea to bring him above deck.”

“Aye, but under guard. I want all of them under heavy watch. We’ll take *the Mirage* into the horizon.”

“What about supplies?”

Napier’s moustache twitched. “Interrogate the prisoners. Send Benton up.”

“You’re going to put him in charge?” Wey sighed in jest and took a deep breath before descending back into hell.

Finn had found the keys to the cages and, with a little persuasion, got Benton to open the first one. Benton watched the scene cautiously. His hand hovered above his pistol, ready to stop either mother or child if it should come to it. He prayed it wouldn’t come to it. Finn sat in the cage and ignored the smell. The dead girl was beginning the onset of decay. Her eyes were closed, her body stiff. Her sister’s breathing was shallow. She was only conscious by some miracle, or some curse.

“My name is Finn, I’m a priest,” he said softly to the mother. “I was taught medicine in the Temple. If you would like I could take a look at your daughters. I might be able to help.”

The woman’s eyes flickered over him.

Slowly Finn eased the living girl from her mother’s arms. She flopped lifelessly into his own. Her pulse was weak. There was no muscle in her limbs, no fat on her bones. If she made it through the hour it would be a marvel. Gently Finn placed the girl back in the care of her mother. He glanced at Benton and shook his head. The mother closed her eyes; tears ran down her bony cheeks. Her face relaxed and the tears stopped. Finn went to the door and waited to be released.

“Disease?” Benton asked as he unlocked the bolt.

“No, something else. I need to look at the dead.”

“Bennie!” Wey shouted. “Captain wants you on deck.”

Relieved, Benton rushed from the prisoners. Wey and six others replaced him cluttering the putrid space. They were heavily armed and edgy.

“Is this really necessary?” Finn said shaking his head.

“Not taking any chances,” Wey replied. “Right Anderson, how do you fancy getting some air? Take him upstairs.”

“What’s going on?” Finn asked as the pirates began to shuffle Anderson away.

“That’s what we’re going to find out.”

Calmly the prisoner staggered with his entourage of bodyguards out of the hold.

He nodded to Finn appreciatively as he left.

“I need to do some autopsies,” Finn suddenly said. “To find out what’s happened.”

Wey frowned. “You have some very strange hobbies.”

“It might help.”

He shrugged and handed him his small knife. “Go have fun.”

Wey sat in the dingy with his pistol pointed at John Anderson. The captured ship was behind them as the sun rested into the ocean. Anderson looked tired, thick bags hung under his pale eyes. He was in his forties and looked at least ten years older. The other men in the dingy were waiting for him to attack, Wey was more confident.

“You’ll forgive our caution. Your kidnappers weren’t your usual soldiers.”

Anderson rested against the side of the dingy, resolved to his predicament. He breathed the fresh air deeply, savouring the taste for as long as he could hold it.

The Mirage revealed herself as the light began to etch out her frame against the paling sky. She swayed gently under a comfortable breeze. Her crew watched the approaching boat cautiously. Anderson was hauled aboard and immediately taken down to the brig. Wey again apologised for the shackles, but Napier was prepared to take no risks. It mattered little to Anderson, the smell in the Brig was a lot more comforting than anywhere else he had been in the past month. He sat down and accepted the glass of wine.

Wey was ready to make his way down to question the guest. *The Mirage* was quiet and he could see the captured ship in the distance. A hand grabbed him.

“Where’s Finn?” Adiah asked.

“Cutting up the bodies on the ghost ship, strange lad you’ve got there.”

Adiah frowned. “Where are you going?”

“To interrogate a survivor.”

“I’m coming with you.”

He didn't have the energy to object. Together they hurried down to the brig with Thorin close behind him. He set the wolf by the door so he was ready to pounce if it should come to it then gave Adiah his pistols.

"Shoot him if he tries anything."

"I thought you said he was a survivor."

Wey stopped and gave her his sternest look. "Sweetheart you were a survivor and you've brought more trouble than ten thousand hurricanes. Take no chances. He's the only one of them fit for moving, which means he's either lucky or cunning and lucky men don't get shot so you needn't worry yourself."

He led her into the brig and made sure she would have a good start if they needed to run. Anderson sat on the floor, swilling dregs of wine around his cup. He smiled sadly as they entered.

Wey sat beside him and eyed him in the lamplight. He was a tall, lean man with sharp features and a thick coating of blonde stubble. Wey gestured for Adiah to keep her distance. She was quick on her feet and could alert the crew if there was a problem. Not that Anderson seemed to have any intention of moving anywhere.

"You're from Juliet," Wey said. "Funnily enough we were just there, me and this bonny lass. Not in a good way when we left it mind. Any idea what might have happened?"

"All I know is the soldiers took over our farmlands. People got sick and those of us that didn't were put to work before being rounded up."

"Give you any indication as to why the natives were *rounded up*?"

Anderson had never been comfortable with his illegitimate birth right. He had always suspected his native mother had been less than pure and as he was transported with those of the lowest classes he realised she had corrupted him in the process.

"They want our blood," he finally said.

"What?" Wey and Adiah both exclaimed.

"They took our blood. Mostly from the women and children. The men were sent to work in the fields until the fire." Wey glanced at Adiah. "Then we were drained as well."

"How did they take your blood?" Adiah asked stepping closer.

Anderson rubbed his eyes. "There were these machines and needles. I don't know it was all a blur really. Most of the children died in the first go. I remember they were having difficulty knowing how much they should take." Anderson's stomach churned. He'd tried to forget the factories.

"What did they want it for?"

"I don't know," he replied honestly.

Wey stood up. The information had winded him and he needed to take some air. Adiah blocked his path and he found himself barricaded.

"It must have been awful." She let the pistol drop.

"The process," he said breathlessly. "Before they took our blood, we were injected with a liquid."

"Adi' the pistol," Wey murmured.

Anderson shook his head. "I won't hurt you. I'm dying. Like the others." A tear ran down his face. "The pain will start soon."

"How do you know?" Wey asked suspiciously.

Anderson took a deep breath, "I am a physician. I tried to save those people on the ship, but each one who underwent the process grew weaker and weaker. Then they suffered violent fits of pain, before succumbing to a catatonic state. It's the final stage when the soldiers really take an interest."

"Surely there is something we can do," Adiah pleaded with Wey.

"See what Finn says after he's looked at the bodies."

"You have a doctor on board."

"Better than that, a priest," Wey replied.

"If he's looking at the bodies I could help him, I have a day, perhaps less, but I may be of some use. I would like to help."

"We'll see," Wey replied. "Adiah." He took her arm and dragged her away.

"What are you doing? We should release him."

"Nobody's doing anything until I speak to Napier," he hissed. He stopped moving and pressed himself against the side of the boat.

"What's wrong?"

"Did you hear what he said, they're taking our blood. What kind of sick leeches are draining children's blood! This is crazy." Wey patted at his weary face, the boat felt like it was spinning around him.

"My father must be stopped."

Napier paced the deck. The men were unsettled and hushed meetings were only going to add to their paranoia. When Wey appeared he called all hands to gather around the mainmast. He stood in the middle, but the floor was open.

"They want our blood," Wey told his friends.

"What's changed there?" Coop called.

"They want our *actual* blood. They took the natives on the ship, hooked them up to some machine, pumped them full of chemicals and drained the blood from their veins."

A silence fell upon the ship as the men tried to comprehend what had been said. Many of them had friends and family on Juliet. They had accepted the genocide, not this, this was something far more disturbing.

"Anderson said everyone who undergoes the process dies. He thinks he's going to die. But Finn is trying to find an answer and maybe if we let Anderson go back on the ship he could help find a cure," Adiah said.

"This true?" Napier asked.

Wey nodded, "Says he's a quack."

"What do they want our blood for?"

Wey shrugged.

"Elders have requested our return," Napier suddenly said. "But this ship and others like it could hold the answers we need, what say ye, do we make for the Barge today or do we detour around the Hermian coast for a week?"

The crew grumbled and conceded. A further week was unlikely to hinder them. After a vote it was decided they would stay. Satisfied his crew were happy Napier pulled Wey aside.

"I want you to keep the girl safe," he said. "Get her off this boat and hide her away until we come back."

Wey nodded.

"You protect her with your life you hear me. Keep her sweet, whatever it takes."

"Whatever?" Wey asked surprised.

The Captain lowered his voice until it was barely a whisper. "She could be the end of our strife so you make sure she stays happy and out of trouble. You can do that can't you Wey? She has asked for you personally, I wouldn't like to think you weren't up for the challenge."

He shrugged his shoulders, "I'm up for anything sir."

Finn wiped his hands in a bucket of salt water. He'd made his way through his third body, all were the same. In the Temple he'd been present for several autopsies as part of his studies and he'd read up religiously on all things medical in an attempt to understand man's biological purpose on the world. When he'd asked Wey for the bodies he assumed he knew what he was doing. When he got the first one open and saw the mess he realised he was merely a butcher. The mother's insides were coated with a syrupy, scarlet substance. He had no idea how she died, or how the substance got in her. Her daughter was the same. Then a young man of Finn's age mirrored the females.

Benton had informed him an hour ago, the last prisoner on the ship was dead. So far none of them had got back up. The race to save the survivors seemed to be over and Finn was ready to admit defeat. He'd wrapped the third body in canvas and moved it with the other two. The prospect of doing any more seemed pointless, until he was interrupted.

The prisoner, Anderson, had returned and Finn realised that, for his sake, they should press on. He smiled and shook the older man's hand.

"You have done three autopsies already?" Anderson was horrified at the speed the boy was working.

Finn shook his head, "Not really, I tried to examine them but it's like nothing I've ever seen before."

"I am a doctor, at least I was. If you would let me have a look I might be able to assist you."

"Of course," Finn said. "But have you eaten first, you look awfully pale."

"Son I have a matter of hours before I am no good to you. Let's not waste any more time."

The two men opened the third body again. Anderson worked efficiently through the corpse paying particular attention to the organs. He tried to make sense of what he saw, tried to equate it to what he felt inside his own body, but it was madness. Eventually fatigue overcame him and he sat back on a small wooden stool in much the same way as he'd found Finn.

"This makes no sense. His blood is, well it's not blood. Surely that must be what killed him. What I can't believe was he was alive yesterday." Anderson wiped the sweat off his face.

"Are you all right?" Finn asked.

Anderson shrugged him off. "They have changed our blood. It don't know how, or why, but they have done it."

"The people on Juliet who died from the poppy pollen had a similar liquid oozing out of them." Finn said thinking aloud. "The natives weren't affected by the pollen, so they injected you with it instead." He pressed his temples. "They've changed the compound," he suddenly said. "I don't pretend to understand how, but those bodies are not housing blood in their veins. The crew found machinery in the hull. We might be able to use it, wait here."

Finn ran onto deck yelling for Benton. He was convinced he had found a cure and threw himself into saving Anderson. The crew took a few moments to match his enthusiasm, but after he explained it a second time, between pants, he inspired everyone to action.

It took over two hours to get the machinery set up correctly, in which time Anderson started to feel cramps surging up his legs. His faith in Finn was waning and he was afraid. When men finally came for him he was already starting to succumb to the delirium. They carried him up on deck, unveiling an open laboratory, clumsily arranged around the external frame of the ship.

Finn had a needle inserted into his arm. Thick, dark, red blood streamed through a dirty tube and into a large cylinder. Anderson was dropped onto a wooden chair, his arms and legs secured. He understood what the boy was doing and for a moment he felt a glimmer of hope.

"Doctor Anderson sir," Finn said. "It's a long shot and I must warn you I am not at all certain I know what I am doing."

"You are attempting a transfusion. I know of only a handful succeeding and these circumstances are very different," Anderson said through gritted teeth. "Your blood is unlikely to even match my own."

"It's up to you Doctor, if it works we will have a cure."

"And if your blood is not a match to my own I will die quickly." Anderson offered his arm. "I think this will be a better way to die. Please don't stop until you find a cure."

The crew watched in horror and awe as blood moved from one man to another. Finn closed his eyes and tried to ignore the weakness he was beginning to feel. Anderson too closed his eyes and slowly began to feel no more pain.

Twelve

"Finn," Benton said, shaking him. "Finn, Anderson's dead!"

Finn opened his eyes. The needle was being removed from his arm. He sat up and stared at Anderson's body. He'd failed. The crew moved silently around him, exuding their disappointment in slow sighs.

"I killed him," Finn murmured.

"He was a dead man anyway," Benton replied. "Could it ever work, this transfusion?"

Finn tried to stand but his legs gave way. Falling against Benton he found himself pushed back on the chair.

"Will you recover?"

"In time. It might work." He said still transfixed by the new corpse. "I don't know. I need to think. I'm sorry."

"Don't be too hard on yourself lad. Did your best, not one of us would testify you didn't."

"Hasn't helped though."

Benton was never very good with words, so he left Finn and began to make arrangements to have the equipment shipped over to *the Mirage* with the rest of the cargo. Finn stared at a sun threatening to rise as a new burden fell upon his shoulders. He closed his eyes and when he opened them he felt Adiah's hand touch his head and the gentle sway of a ship in motion.

Wearing a tattered coat Beau had been given him, Finn drew his knees under his chin. The ship still reeked of death and decay, forcing the new crew of six to remain above deck throughout the night. Napier had loaned three of his crew, together with Wey. Mr Benton was to take the position of Captain and from there Mr Saunders and Mr Abram could knock heads together until appropriate titles were apportioned to them. If faced with an attack the crew would be little match, not that there was anything on board to steal, bar the blood in their veins and all were quite determined to cling onto that until their dying breath. Supplies on the ship had also been depleted to the bare essentials to cover what was lost from the destruction of *the Liberty*. The six strong crew had only enough to last them to Hermia to ensure that, if it came to it, *the Mirage* could return home without much hardship. Napier had categorically decided a large deployment of men to Hermia to obtain supplies was no longer worth the risk and he would not set foot on dry land until he spoke to the Elders.

"But why Hermia?" Finn groaned as he forced a spoonful of overcooked fish into his mouth. His weakness had warranted the rest of the crew to increase his rations in secret and they each tried to ignore the grimace on his face when he swallowed.

“It’s the closest island to us now,” Adiah told him, “Benton said the ship has almost had it, wouldn’t survive another bout of bad weather and Saunders said if anyone knew about ships it was Mr, I mean Captain Benton. Besides they have contacts in Hermia and at least there we can get some answers.”

“What about going to Helena, surly you’d be more welcome there, and safer.”

Adiah squeezed his hand, “Aye, but first I need to understand why the King is doing all of this. Finn he’s killing innocent people for their blood!”

Finn rolled his eyes and sighed. When she got an idea in her head it was impossible to dislodge it. “You’re not still planning on killing him?”

She glanced away letting her eyes fall over the other men working about deck. The wind was good and nobody seemed to be breaking their back over anything.

“Adiah I really think we should make for Helena, tell your uncle about this, he’ll be able to do something.”

She patted his leg condescendingly. “You were really brave, stupid but brave with Anderson. I wouldn’t have hooked myself up to that machine.”

A figure loomed over them in the early morning sun. “So you’ve stopped snoring like a drunken elephant then,” Wey said cheerfully.

“Have you decided where we’re going to make port?” Adiah asked abruptly.

Wey’s smile faded, “I’m well thank you Princess, and yourself? Good to hear it. Bennie reckons we abandon ship off the south coast. Take a dinghy out and moor it on the beach.”

“Do you think the harbour is too dangerous?” Finn asked concerned.

“Let’s just say even if we weren’t harbouring some of the Vaults’ finest, three renowned pirates, an overweight wolf and a rebel priest, some of whom happen to be carrying liquid gold in their veins, we’ve got no papers, sod all coin and are the most unlikely party of fishermen banded together on a sinking rat ever to make port. I reckon a simple docking might well be out of our reach on this one. Chin up lad.”

Finn paused and rose to his feet. The prospect of landing in Hermia played heavily on his mind. He was not the same man that had left all those weeks ago and the life he suspended was lost forever. It was lost and he had mourned it, but new woes now occupied his head. All on the ship were now valuable to the King of Hermia, who had proved himself ruthless enough to destroy an entire island. Adiah had already suffered horrific atrocities, she would not survive another trip to the Vaults. Not to mention the fact they were now criminals. Hermia was just too dangerous.

He approached Benton at the helm apprehensively. The large Captain nodded his head and continued to stare out across the horizon, awaiting the first speck of greenery to appear.

“Sorry to trouble you Captain,” Finn said. “You’re intending to land on the south coast to avoid detection?”

“Aye,” Benton replied, feeling any moment that decision would need to be revised.

“I don’t know if you’re aware but when I left Hermia the beaches were being used in trainee scouting operations by young soldiers. I know makeshift forts have been erected on the south and east coast, although they did only house very inexperienced soldiers, nothing more than children, they would be able to spot us and alert someone though.”

Benton’s shoulders dropped, he knew this wasn’t going to be the walk in the park, ferry adventure Napier made it out to be. “I take it you have another suggestion, other than shooting our way through prep school?”

Finn took a brave breath. “The Temple on the west of the island has an isolated dock. We built it to allow for pilgrimage, although it’s rarely used. The dock maybe too small for this ship, but we’d certainly get a small row boat through, and the area is well secluded.”

“West coast? We’d have to change course,” Benton tapped on the wheel. “Okay, sounds like a reasonable plan.”

“You would be able to seek refuge at the Temple,” Finn added, “For as long as was required.”

“Don’t think me ungrateful but the less time on that island the better. *The Mirage* makes for home in a week and I am going to be on that ship.”

Finn understood.

Adiah quickly sidled up to Wey. Finn and Benton were looking at charts, and Saunders and Abram were playing dice. The only eyes that watched her were Thorin’s and he was unlikely to say anything.

“What will it cost?” She whispered.

Wey raised an eyebrow as he looked her up and down, “For you? A bottle of ale for the night. A casket if you want me for the weekend.”

“To kill the King.”

“Save your money.”

“Wey you saw what he did to this ship, how many others are there?”

He waved his hand at her, “Don’t play the moral conscience card with me it won’t work.”

“Egan,” she said touching his arm. “Come on, this is what you live for isn’t it? You could get the man who sentenced us to the Vaults, who sanctioned their bloody construction. At least let’s investigate, find out what is driving this genocide.”

“Listen, sweetheart, hands are tied on this one. We’re to be nothing louder than a dead man’s fart or my ass is flogged from here to the end of the deserts.”

“Napier told you that.” She folded her arms and wondered if perhaps she shouldn’t have tried to tempt Napier with more gold.

Wey shook his head, “No, Napier’s all for shooting, and stabbing, and eye gauging, but the Elders put their foot down and they know best.”

“Elders, who are they that they can control pirates?”

“Our forefathers. Men who’ve done all this and know a bit more than we do. They make decisions for the Barge and we all work for them. When the Elders say jump we bring them back clouds.”

“So the great Egan Wey is still as tethered as the rest of us,” she sneered.

Wey pouted a little. “You see Princess, our forefathers taught us everything. Put clothes on our backs and loaded the first powder in our pistols. There’s not many because you don’t normally live long in this life, but those that do either have good judgement or lots of luck and we Fimorri usually rely on both. I could leave the Barge today, abandon my kin to drink myself into a shallow grave, riddled with pox and laden with jewels. Hell I could even sell up and buy myself a little farm, raise a couple of young in perfect serenity, but I don’t. I don’t because I have free will and a little pride in the work my father did and his father before him. We may look like dishevelled puppet pirates on contract, but there’s not a man on *the Mirage* who hasn’t chosen to be there and wouldn’t stay there as long as he was fit and able.”

She let go of Wey sheepishly. “Sorry, I didn’t mean to offend you,” she replied coolly.

He shrugged his shoulders. “Let me tell you something darling, there ain’t a man alive who’s free in this world. We’re all tied to one thing or another, be it family, or alcohol, or temper. Nobody is who they want to be and you never get what you want, although some of us get close enough to feel the wind in our hair a little more than the rest.”

“So you’re close to the man you want to be,” she murmured doubtfully.

He scoffed. “Me, no you see there are those like me, who’ve seen the way of the world and who just don’t have an inclination to find peace.”

“And what about me?”

“What about you?”

“Well what am I? Close to what I want to be or not bothered either way.”

He inspected her closely. “No you’re something else. You have an idea what you should be, isn’t what you want to be, and you know you’re not going to be who you want to be so you try and be something different again. Technical term for it is *in a shitting mess*, I think.”

Adiah scowled, whether he was being honest or snide it was cutting too close for her to not be slighted. “My, we are philosophical today.”

He nodded in a sigh, “Sobering up.”

She moved to walk away but he caught her arm. Abram looked up from the game, startled by the sharp movement. Wey pulled her close and bent towards her ear. “Elders ordered me to keep you safe. Seems to me to do that we need to get to Hermia, then I need to get you to Helena. Also seems to me if you wander off it would be my job to find you and watch your pretty back.”

There was a glint in his eye that excited her. She understood him and she was surprised to leave him in good spirits for a change. As she walked away she dared to look back for just a second and caught his eye before making her way to busy herself. Wey shook his head, she was nothing but trouble and he would still piss the Elders off for her. He needed a drink.

Benton spied the faint glimmer of a scar across his ocean. For a moment his heart fluttered, although he wasn’t sure whether he was happy or otherwise. He moved to scratch his wrist and found emptiness where something should have been. This was then followed by the realisation his arm had gone and was unlikely to return any time soon. Sometimes he thought about it, where it was. The ship’s surgeon would have thrown it overboard he reckoned, but did the sharks get it, or did it make it to the bottom of the ocean awaiting the rest of him? There was always the niggling thought that it was still aboard his ship and would make an appearance in a barrel of something before the month was out.

His mood had been foul since he left *the Mirage*, not that it had been emanating love and harmony before hand. The situation bothered him, more than anything had bothered him before. When he closed his eyes he saw his own children in cages, guarded by intoxicated zombies, little more than corpses themselves. The Fimorri had always been persecuted, ever since the Treaty, but this was the first time he feared for his family. Now he understood why his wife grew so angry with him each time they parted.

From the corner of his eye he watched Adiah and Finn. They were good people, he was convinced of that, but the storms they carried with them were dangerous, too dangerous. They had drawn Wey in as trouble always did, only this time Benton wasn’t sure Wey’s luck would hold out. Saunders and Abram were idling again; Napier would have been kinder to provide him with two planks of wood.

“Land ahoy!” Benton yelled and with the sound of his voice the second mast crashed into the bow of the boat, crushing Beau beneath its bulk.

Adiah and Abram were knocked to their feet. Adiah hit the back of her head. She clambered up the deck, pulling herself to her feet, dizzy and disorientated. Abram leapt quickly towards Beau and tried to push the mast off his friend.

"Won't move," Beau said, trying to free himself.

Wey had his hands around the wood and he heaved. Nothing.

"Rope!" Finn yelled. "Get some rope."

"We're taking on water!" Adiah called.

Finn tied the ropes around the mast and all who were able pulled. The mast buckled and began to move.

"Come on!" Finn shouted.

Adiah skidded to Beau, knocking the splinters of wood from his hands and torso.

"Can you move?" She asked.

He groaned and tried to roll over. With all the will in the world she couldn't lift him, so she grabbed his hand and dragged him free. The mast crashed back into the deck. Adiah fell against Beau exhausted, while Wey inspected the mast.

"Damn water worm," he said distastefully. "Whole goddamn ship will be riddled with it."

"Abandon ship!" Benton called.

"Lifeboat won't be much better," Abram grumbled.

"Fine stay here! Beau are you dead or alive?"

Beau checked himself, "Alive, I think."

"Well we can't have everything," Benton murmured to Wey. "Get your backsides off this ship before it goes under."

They hauled themselves into the longboat. Beau took the oars, beaming a large toothless grin at the rest of them.

"Don't you think you should rest a minute?" Adiah said.

"Petal," Beau said. "You sit yourself down, least I could do after you saved me."

"Saved you!" Wey shouted. "You big dumb bastard, she lifted that mast by herself did she?"

"She pulled me free," Beau said proudly, Abram nodded his head in respectful agreement.

"Knothead," Wey grumbled. "Why the fuck didn't you check the stability of the ship?"

"Wouldn't have mattered if it was sinking, it was the only ship we had," Benton replied. "Here give me an oar."

After some scrambling, and the longboat almost capsizing, they assembled themselves beside an oar each, all except Thorin who watched the large vessel begin its descent into the ocean.

Thirteen

Brother Carlston and Brother Howard stood on the small balcony overlooking the ocean. The two men had been bickering for twenty minutes and, although Brother Carlston was tiring, Brother Howard had another half hour in him yet. Unfortunately, for the life of him, Brother Howard could not remember the point he was trying to make and, after concentrating all his efforts on remembering, he totally forgot what they were arguing about in the first place. Carlston, in relief at the sudden silence, glanced out at the ocean beyond the trees. His feeble eyes narrowed.

"My word is that a ship?"

"Don't be foolish Brother we don't get ships this way," Howard said. A spark of memory flashed in his mind and he was ready to go again.

"No it is a ship! Goodness it's sinking!"

The spark burnt out and Howard was forced to look out at the blurry ocean, his own eyesight failing just as badly. All he could see was a brown speck of something on a blue canvass. "Looks like a schooner to me," he said putting his hand to his brow. "Oh yes and she seems to be taking on water, cannon damage I'd say."

Carlston eyed him with suspicion before he caught sight of the rowboat entering their tiny dock. He leaned closer over the railings. "I say the survivors are making port!"

"What?" Howard replied alarmed. "Oh dear, this is indeed strange."

"It's Brother Finn!"

"No Brother, he's away on a pilgrimage."

"The devil he is you blind bat, he's rowing that ship! Finn!" He began to wail as he rushed towards the dock.

"Hungry," Saunders whined. "Didn't take any other food did we?"

Benton rolled his eyes and ignored the giant's comments. His arm was aching from the rowing but he couldn't show weakness. As long he maintained his standards his ranking with the men would still be held.

"There'll be food and water at the Temple," Finn assured him.

"What about women?" Abram asked excitedly.

"Oh yeah, there's loads of women, why do you think most of them never leave this place," Wey sneered.

Abram and Saunders licked their lips enthusiastically.

"Will we be welcome Finn?" Benton asked, taking the opportunity to let his rowing slack while he addressed the man behind him.

“Yes,” Finn replied. “And safe. I can arrange passage for a voyage from here; we won’t have to leave the Temple.”

Adiah turned her head away.

“Sounds good to me.”

The rowboat tapped the wooden dock making a gentle knocking sound. Beau quickly secured it and helped Adiah and Abram out. The others made do without him. The lapping ocean was overshadowed by the bird song echoing from the lush foliage around them. Each of them stopped and swooned in the serenity, momentarily subdued by peace. Surrounded by trees and water, all that could be heard was nature and the sound of Brother Carlston hurtling their way.

“Brother Finn! Brother Finn! You have returned!” He embraced Finn before noticing the *less desirables* accompanying him. “And you have brought guests. Excellent!”

“Brother Carlston, it’s good to see you. These are good friends of mine. Mr Saunders and Mr Abram, two very worthy sailors who managed to assist Captain Benton here. If it weren’t for their efforts I doubt I would have made it here at all. And this is Mr Wey my guide and friend. And this, well this is the Princess of Hermia, Adiah.”

Carlston gawped. “The Princess Adiah, forgive me. We heard news of your tragic death. We held a service for you.”

Adiah was touched. For anyone in Hermia to mourn her passing was a total surprise. “Thank you but the report was a fraud. I was captured and sent to the Vaults instead.”

“The Vaults?”

“Yes, the King sent me there.”

“But…”

Finn interrupted. “Come inside with me Brother, I have much more grave news to inform you of and I’m afraid we’re in great need of your help.”

Brother Carlston led them through the main garden. Before they could enter the courtyard Wey caught Adiah’s hand and pulled her back. He waited for the others to disappear before he whispered, “Do you not think that it might be wise to exercise a little discretion?”

“What do you mean?”

“I mean you don’t know who you’re talking to.”

“He’s a priest.”

“So is Finn and he’s rescuing damsels, fucking farm girls and butchering soldiers.”

“I’m sure we can trust him. Which is more than I can say for you!”

Wey smiled amused. “After you then your majesty.” He said bowing to let her pass. Smoothly he slipped behind her and pressed his finger between her shoulder blades. “Knife in the back,” he teased.

“Grow up!” She snapped and quickened her step to catch the others.

“Make me! No I mean it, make me, all ready for you Princess.” His smile faded. “Probably half the way anyway,” he said regretfully.

The Temple had been methodically planned six hundred years ago, its intention being to accommodate and inspire priests from the start of their ordainment to their eventual passing. In six hundred years no priest had sought to change or improve upon its design, although many spent hours repairing and maintaining the great stone structure. It was rare in so far as it had a plumbing system, although this was poor and the priests opted to use the water from the fountains in the gardens and springs throughout the encircling forest.

An air of tranquillity rested throughout the Temple and the forest surrounding it. The priests argued and bickered, but otherwise were peaceful. There were no women within the walls, although it had never officially been forbidden to allow the fairer sex entry. Instead there had been an unspoken understanding among the priests, that the world of bliss they had chosen would most likely shatter into stress and anxiety were women allowed in their midst. Many of Hermia’s forward thinking citizens thought the priests were chauvinistic, in actual fact they just understood that the introduction of women, would be the introduction of the dominant sex and their perfect ecosystem would be totally transformed. It was also required that a priest be celibate, both men and women (there were of course Temples run by the priestesses throughout the islands, although none as large as Hermia’s) and it was generally thought that this would be better achieved if the sexes were separated.

Wey thought it over as he was led through the ordered courtyard; it seemed like a perfect utopia.

The sky was grey that day, the trees and water around them moved with vivacity, allowing the scene to become alive. Jasmine blossoms filled the air, mingled with hops growing through the archways that marked their path. Priests wandering the gardens stopped in delight upon seeing Finn and Finn was able to recognise each one with fondness. He nodded, aware that soon they would sense a change in him if they did not already.

To the other guests in their home they smiled and politely turned to their business, be it gardening or idle soul searching. A coach could be heard leaving the Temple, a regular occurrence for the afternoon. Visitors to the Temple tried to be away before sunset and this marked the last hour such a task was possible.

Brother Carlston led the group into a moderately sized greeting room. The furniture was of quality, although well used and the priests held little regard for decoration other than plants. Each man found a seat beside the dying fire and spied priests keeping a respectful distance through the

several doorways about the room. Finn had used this room before to indulge in philosophical discussions with his peers and also with the public who graced them with their questions.

Immediately Finn sprang into action and began to light candles before the darkness claimed them. He placed logs on the fire and waited for it to spring back into life. His friends watched him curiously. He had never adapted to his brief spell on the ocean and it seemed he was also awkward and nervous in his own home too.

"Would you care for some refreshments?" Carlston said with sincere kindness. "Our evening meal is not yet served and we shall be very grateful if you would join us in the dining room. I am afraid it is nothing served up in a palace your majesty but nobody has ever complained before."

Adiah stood up and smiled, "We would be delighted, wouldn't we?" She nudged Beau and Benton beside her.

The pirates grumbled in agreement. Beau could taste blood in his mouth from where he had bitten his tongue. He was too terrified to move, or speak, or even make eye contact with the priest. His mother was a strong believer in the Temple and if he disgraced her she'd whack him across the six deserts before he was permitted a break. Abram found himself baffled and intrigued by the strange men, he watched blatantly as they went about their business, unable to make any sense of it. Benton and Wey sat back with arms folded (well Benton gripped his ribs with his one hand) waiting to depart with full bellies and rested bodies.

"I'll tell the cook," Finn said instinctively.

Carlston held up his hand, "I'll tell the cook, but I'd be glad of the company Brother." He turned to Beau. "Excuse me sir, but can I beg of you to tend this fire until we return?"

Beau swallowed hard and nodded.

"And we shall return with some tea for us all, yes that will be lovely. Shall we Brother?"

The two men left the room after Brother Carlston meticulously closed all of the doors. Beau finally breathed out and knelt by the fire, praying it would not go out. Heaven help him if it went out.

"This place would drive me crazy," Abram finally said after much evaluation.

"You cut off three of your toes last week you are crazy," Benton replied.

Abram shrugged and stood by the fire. He held out his hands to the growing warmth and nodded proudly at Beau's efforts.

"It's odd seeing Finn here," Benton said. "Still looks like a bloody fish out of water."

"He's just nervous," Adiah explained, slumping back in her seat. "A lot's happened since he left."

Wey scoffed, "And Bennie lost a bit of weight when we were at sea!"

“How do we get out of here?” Benton said before the squabbling started again, “My feet don’t like this stillness.”

Wey scratched his head. “You need to captain us to Helena.” He flinched in anticipation.

“Helena, what! You’re fucking kidding me you piece of shit! What are you talking about Helena. That’s six days if we’re lucky, and do I look lucky to you!”

Wey bit his lip, “Look that boat wasn’t supposed to sink and I was only planning on stealing me one ship.”

“Well you can steal one for me as well.”

“Do you know how difficult it is stealing two boats? One’s easy, you’re on it, you’re sailing away. How the hell am I supposed to steal two?”

“Eighteen months,” Benton growled. “I’ve not been home in eighteen months, so you’re going to steal me a boat and we’re going home!”

Wey waved his hand, “Yeah alright I’ll try and get you a boat, but you better be grateful.” He smiled and watched as Benton relaxed. “Don’t worry you’ll see your Missus soon enough. Be a relief for that poor goat after all.”

Brother Carlston wasted no time in organising food and provisions for his guests. He secured the men a shared room and a private chamber for Adiah. Against his better judgement he refrained from announcing his guests to the Temple quite so early and instead opted to take Finn to the pantry where they could at least speak privately.

“You look tired brother,” Carlston said. “I know very little of your adventure, only that it was a secret matter of the state. Now I do not ask you to tell me or any of the like, only know I thought it best to declare that you had decided to take a pilgrimage, not unsurprising given your father’s situation and that you would return when your soul was restored.”

“Brother…” Finn began.

“Now there were some that would go to find you, but I kept them at bay and I will only say this and then we shall speak of it no more. I trust that what you intended to do was done and that you are now at peace.”

“I’m neither restored nor at peace,” Finn confessed. “Brother I have done terrible things.”

Carlston held up his hand. “Listen to me Finn, your journey from here is nothing compared with your previous dedication to this Temple. Words uttered from your lips will be forever in my mind, so I will not press you to say anything. We can stand in silence and nothing more need occur.”

“I killed,” he said, “I robbed, I fell in love and married, and was widowed.” Finn felt himself beginning to sob. “I have betrayed all I hold dear.”

Despite his protests Carlston understood he needed to continue. “Go on.”

Finn released his clenched fists and with one single movement tales of sin and evil passed his lips. He left nothing out, no secret, no indiscretion. He explained Adiah, he explained Wey and *the Mirage,* the soldiers and the prisoners, the burning fields, sinking ships, until there was nothing more. He sat there on the pantry floor, a skeleton of his former self.

“You most certainly did a lot,” Carlston finally said. He had since forgotten Finn’s confessions and instead contemplated the terrible situation of the soldiers. “You’re sure it’s the King’s doing?”

“We think he locked Adiah away to question her about Helena. The soldiers are Hermia’s Royal Guard, at least they wear the uniforms. Truthfully I couldn’t say for certain, but whoever it is must be stopped.”

“And Juliet is really gone?”

“It was a wall of fire when I left, by then everyone was dead. I’m to travel to Helena with Adiah. Perhaps we can get King Harold to intervene, or do something to stop this madness.”

“I would beg you to stay if I thought you would listen. Your sins were nothing, brief glitches in an otherwise spotless existence. When you married you were not the man before me and when you killed and robbed you were trying to meet justifiable ends. This has always been your calling.”

“My calling has changed. I have changed. I’m sorry Brother. I would be grateful if you would be kind enough to accommodate us until we leave.”

“On one condition, the others, they will need to know of the situation, just not of your part in this. It would benefit us both if they understood you to be the protector of the Princess and that you will one day return to us.”

Finn hesitated, he didn’t like lying to his brothers.

“Not for us, but for them, they will look to you for inspiration.”

Reluctantly he agreed.

“So you spent how long here?”

“Four years,” Finn said assembling the items he wished to keep. He’d only had five minutes alone in his room before Wey found him.

Wey examined the books on Finn’s desk. “Sure is a weird place. Everyone smiling at one another.”

“As opposed to smashing bottles and cursing all the time.”

“Exactly,” Wey replied. “Anyway business. We need two ships now our nameless piece of shit sunk on us. Don’t suppose Daddy has two?”

“I don’t know. I’m sure he could acquire two.”

“Don’t have to be anything glamorous, just enough to get those who are going home, home and us who are going elsewhere, well elsewhere.”

“In the morning I will try to visit my father and arrange for two ships to dock here. By the time I arrive back we may be ready to depart.”

“Good. Being on this island makes me nervous.”

Fourteen

Wey turned over in his bed and received two adamant paws in his gut. He groaned and rolled back. The priests had laid out an old blanket for Thorin on the floor, but the beast still insisted on sleeping on the same narrow mattress as Wey. A thin streak of moonlight shone through the shutters above him. Thorin gave one final kick and Wey conceded. He clambered to the floor and wrapped the old, tattered blanket over himself. Thorin snorted victoriously.

The floor creaked with his every movement. He was cold and sore. Eventually he threw the blanket off and crawled over to Benton's bed.

Benton's eyes were lightly closed. His mouth twitched slightly in smiles and sadness. It seemed cruel to wake him.

"Bennie!" Wey hissed. "Bennie!"

"Fuck off."

"Bennie move over," Wey tried to push his way into the bed, "Come on you fat bastard, let me in it's freezing."

"Move the wolf."

"He bites in his sleep," Wey moaned. "Don't be a bastard."

Benton turned around ensuring he occupied all of the space he could. Wey grumbled and reluctantly moved back to his own bed. He reached for the blanket and it began to growl at him. Thorin had always been a loyal and faithful companion just not when it came to sleeping arrangements. Wey sat back on the floor and glanced over at the other two beds. Abram and Beau were snoring away ungracefully and one of them had horrendous gas. Slipping on his boots and coat he decided to try his chances with the landlubbers, slamming the door loudly as he left.

The truth was Thorin would never have taken control of the bed if Wey had been able to sleep, but he had tossed and turned all night until Thorin had finally had enough. Wey cursed to himself and wandered the corridors. The Temple was not entirely silent; movement below could still be heard as some headed for midnight prayers. He meandered, desperately trying to suppress the urge to steal.

Finn's room was at the other end of the Temple and Wey was fairly confident Finn would give up his entire bed for him. He stuffed his hands into his pockets and focused on that destination. Despite his resolve, his feet abruptly stopped. He sighed and looked at the door to his right. *She* was in there.

His hand hesitated over the latch. Then he realised who he was. He was Egan Wey, pirate, thug, and general evil doer. He took what he wanted, gave nothing back and to hell with anyone

who got in his way. His hand still hesitated. Forcefully he entered the room and stared at the empty bed.

"Bugger!"

Benton felt the slumber starting to take him again. His body relaxed and his eyes grew heavy. He focused on thoughts of returning home and seeing his children, seeing his wife, seeing her sister. Bang! He leapt from his bed with his pistol in his hand, blinking the light into his eyes, he frowned. Abram too had jumped up ready for action. Beau snored.

Wey grabbed his things, buttoned up his jacket and tightened the buckles on his boots. He was cursing to himself as he shoved his pistols into his sling and pulled the blanket off his bed. Thorin turned his head and, knowing Wey was serious, slowly mooched out of the warmth.

"What are you doing?" Benton groaned.

"Fucking Princess has fucking gone!"

"Gone where?"

"She's fucking gone to kill the fucking King hasn't she!"

"Wey," he warned.

"I know, I know. I'm going. Stupid, fucking, bloody, harlot is going to fucking get her-fucking-self killed out there."

"I meant we've got to leave in two days."

Wey nodded flustered. "Aye we will. Just make sure Finn gets you a boat. I'll be back."

The night was bitterly cold. A biting wind clawed at unconcealed skin. Adiah wrapped her cloak around her body, not that it made any difference. She had been stumbling in the dark for hours. It seemed totally ridiculous; she could navigate an ocean, but a bit of greenery blew her totally off course. She had a cutlass around her hip, which was more of a hindrance than a comfort. She was becoming frustrated with herself and getting anxious.

Kneeling down on the grass, she looked into the hopeless darkness ahead of her. Even if she tried to make her way back to the Temple she wouldn't find it. She was a fool to think she could make it to the palace alone. A tear rolled down her face as she tried to control her anger at herself. She slumped down into the damp foliage and admitted defeat.

"What have we here?" The voice echoed from behind her, clutching her like a bad thought. She quickly got to her feet and turned to face the group of bandits encircling her. They were shabby, loathsome rogues, with sinister eyes and fat bellies.

"I have no money," she told them honestly.

The leader, a stout man with two scars across his face, laughed, “Then we will have to find some other payment, pretty one.”

A year ago such a notion would have terrified her, sent her to her knees begging for mercy, not now. Now she was broken, it didn’t matter how rough the children were with her anymore. She removed her cutlass and held it out.

“Watch out boys,” one of them jeered.

“You think that is going to save you?”

Adiah looked at the blade feeling her body darken, “I’m sure it will cut one of you up before you take it off me.”

The leader edged closer, more cautiously than usual. As a rule they were scared, or at least desperate to please him. She was neither. He stood so close he could smell her and she smelt wrong.

“You can’t hurt me,” she told him.

“We’ll see about that, bitch.”

He moved and there was a loud bang. His body slumped against hers. She jumped back and he slid off her, onto the floor, blood spurting from the hole in his chest. Nobody could see where the shot came from. She scanned the tree line with apprehension. Another shot brought a second man down. Then another.

“One more before I reload,” Wey shouted. “Any takers?”

The men were scattering into the darkness. Wey emerged with Thorin in tow. He rummaged through the bodies, pocketing things of use.

“I thought you’d be here a bit earlier,” she said.

He scowled at her, “I’m not talking to you.”

“What did I do?”

“Two hours I’ve been running round this shitting place. Two hours!”

“You said you would follow me.”

Wey grabbed her wrist and pulled her away from the bodies. “Yeah, follow you in bloody circles. What are you simple wandering round a place like this with a sharpened stick! These fine fellows were going to kill you.”

“I think they were planning to rape me first.”

“Oh my mistake! Come on before Finn realises you’ve gone.”

“I’m going to the palace.”

He looked her up and down smirking.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“You quite clearly think something is funny.”

“How long have you been wandering round out here?”

Adiah ground her teeth in annoyance.

“Let’s just go back and forget all about it.”

“Damn it Egan I’m not going to forget all about it! He put me in the Vaults. Look at me! Look at what he did to me!”

“Killing him isn’t going to help.”

She blinked away tears, “I’m not going to kill him. I’m going to ask him why.”

Wey sighed, his actions were no longer his own. Slowly he embraced her and felt the only warmth in the entire forest pressed against him. She didn’t flinch or pull away and he almost felt her give in a little.

“Benton and Beau and Abe, they’ve been away from their families a long time. This will be their last chance this year to get home.” Wey swallowed his doubt. “You keep up with me, no stopping, no questions.”

“You’re coming with me?”

“I can give you a few minutes in the palace, enough to ask one question.”

She nodded, quivering with relief. “Thank you.”

He grabbed her hand. “Listen to me you keep your mouth shut and you trust me.”

“I do,” she whispered.

He felt giddy again. It was not a feeling that was particularly helpful. His cheeks blushed a colour they thought they had forgotten. Gathering his senses he knelt down to Thorin.

“Let them know what’s going on.”

Thorin whimpered and pawed at Wey’s leg.

“I know but it’s going to be hard enough getting her there. Go to Finn, he’ll give you all the ham you can eat.”

Instantly Thorin was scampering through the woods. He stopped briefly to check his friend was still standing there and then continued back to the Temple.

“How’s he going to tell them?”

Wey raised his eyebrow. “What was rule number one? Come on we’ve got to be quick if we’re going to have any shot at this.”

Adiah did her best to keep pace. Her heart pounded in her chest confirming her doubts about her own fitness. She had always convinced herself she was strong, but Wey had stamina she could only dream of. She admired him, as he covered the ground ahead of her and was grateful to him each time he slowed for her.

Wey calculated the times in his head. If he was lucky they would make it back before nightfall and all would be well. After that the King would know his daughter was alive and they would start looking for her. Adrenaline was running through his blood and it would soon affect his decisions. He wanted to take her there and he would, he wanted to get her home so he would. He wanted…

They caught sight of the road and Wey stopped running. He breathed several heavy breaths and recovered. Adiah mimicked him to little effect. The road was cobbled and she realised she was very near to her birth place. There was no sound from ahead or behind and not even the approaching dawn cracked sticks in its steps through the wood.

"The tree line thins out here," Wey explained, already walking the road. "This will lead us to Beggar's Lane."

"Beggar's Lane, that's the other side of town to the palace," she said trying to keep up.

"That's just what they say. Besides there's a direct route, for those that are in the know, which you'll be in luck to find I am. Just going to have to call in a favour."

Beggar's Lane snored. The ramshackle houses breathed and exhaled in quiet, drunken slumber. The fights had been lost, the beer was drunk and there was nothing left but to rest against a large chest and close your eyes. It was the real happy hour. When the sunlight lashed across the road the pain of earlier events would set in, but for now blissful ignorance was bestowed on the unfortunates.

Wey stormed through the street. His name had already been provided to the authorities, soon they would know Adiah was back so there really was little point in securing secrecy to his arrival. He banged on the door to the Red Dragon. Banged and banged.

"I don't think anyone's there," Adiah whispered.

"Shhh. No talking."

There was movement from within. Apprehensively the door opened and Groader poked his head out, clasping a small pistol in his hand.

"What the bloody hell do you want?"

"Safe passage," Wey replied barging in. He leaned behind the bar and grabbed a bottle of the better rum. Swallowing six large mouthfuls he replaced the cork and set it on the counter.

Adiah stood in the doorway, Groader beside her, scratching his balding head.

"What's going on?"

"I'll tell you about it tomorrow. I need to use the passage."

Groader hesitated, "Where to?"

"The palace," Adiah replied.

"The palace, why the Palace?"

"It was my home."

Wey rolled his eyes. "Groader, my friend, I shall sit and drink myself to oblivion with you tomorrow, but tonight we have very little time. Please."

He conceded and unhooked his ring of keys from the rope he used as a belt, then tossed them to Wey.

The burning torches in the tunnels were almost out. Wey charged through the corridors counting his turns aloud.

"Who was that man?" Adiah shouted.

"What man?"

"That little man, who was he?"

"You must have been imagining things."

"Egan!"

"Or I am imagining this because I distinctly remember telling you not to talk!"

Adiah felt the walls around her. Not even in her wildest dreams could she have imagined such a labyrinth lay underneath Hermia. She wondered who had walked these paths; who still walked them. There were so many exits, so many turns. She passed heavy oak doors and iron gates, makeshift blockades and archways of darkness. In an instant she had lost her bearings, making the whole journey seem like a dream. Then, suddenly, she ran into Wey as the last streak of light faded.

"Ye gods!" Wey cursed. He ran through the turnings in his head once more. "Hold on to me we're nearly there."

Reaching into the darkness she found his arm and then his torso. With her free hand she felt the rough edge of the wall. They walked swiftly until the light started to glow once more. This time it illuminated the end of a tunnel and an unadorned door made of cheap wood and painted pink.

"This is the entrance to the palace?"

Wey shook his head. "No they sealed that off years ago. Only there's one thing a sovereign can't do without."

"What's that?"

"A ready supply of whores." Wey tapped the door. "Now this is where it could all go wrong." He knocked louder and it was answered.

Two large women filled the doorway and eyed up the visitors aggressively. The largest woman, upon seeing Wey, rolled her eyes dramatically and grabbed the door to close it.

"You're barred."

Wey jammed his foot in the way, only they'd seen this trick before. He felt the tip of a spear pressing into his boot and held up his hands smiling. "Ladies please, you've got the wrong man."

“Mr Wey,” the smaller sneered. “Last time you were here we had to get rid of two bodies. Two paying bodies!”

“Where’s Maddy?”

“Busy.”

“Tell her I’m here. Tell her!” He snapped impatiently.

Finally one of the women conceded and mooched away. The door was closed, leaving Adiah and Wey in shadows once more.

“Who’s Maddy?”

“She works here.”

The door opened again. “She says to go on through, but if you make so much as a noise I’ll crush your balls.”

“Don’t tell me, you’re a big hit here aren’t you,” Wey said as he strode into the brothel.

Adiah knew about brothels. You can’t spend months surrounded by sailors without knowing about them, but she had never really tried to imagine them. Yes men and women paid for sex. There were rooms and whores that would cater for everything; that wouldn’t turn you away, or even raise their eyebrows in disgust. Every house held secrets and this place had them all presented in a display case with a useful plaque explaining everything. The rooms were quiet, behind the doors, sleeping clients rested, draped across silk sheets without their dignity. Women counted their earnings and wondered if that helped overpower the stench of the man embedded into their skin.

The house itself had been transformed to include more rooms than would ever be necessary in a family home. It was tastefully decorated with a vibrant pink carpet on every floor. Erotic pictures hung on the walls, under heavy, gold painted frames, the pictures themselves were so beautifully painted Adiah found herself stopping to admire them, before Wey hurried her along.

He reached the door he was looking for and stopped. An awkward situation was going to unfold and he had to decide which girl he would hurt. He entered the gaudy boudoir.

Madison had done all she could to make herself presentable. Her last client was over two hours ago, but she hadn’t had chance to bathe herself. Normally she would have never granted a man access without properly presenting herself, but this was Wey and he had seen her in far worse positions. When he burst through the door her heart fluttered and she couldn’t understand why she had ever betrayed him. She knelt up on her bed, allowing the bed sheets to fall from her body, revealing the red lace slip she was wearing. When she saw Adiah her lustfulness was bemused.

“Wey,” Madison said twisting her blonde curls around her slender fingers. She was of similar build to Adiah, in fact the two could have easily been sisters, only Madison was well aware of her virtues and keen to display them at every opportunity.

“Maddy,” Wey said through gritted teeth. He sighed to himself, “Can’t remember the last time I saw you.”

She glanced away. “I’m sorry,” she replied, pouting.

“Three hours I waited for you,” he hissed. “Three hours, in the fucking cold and rain.”

“I’m sorry,” she said again. “I couldn’t do it. It’s not me.”

Wey forced himself on. “You could have told me, could have come to tell me, instead of leaving me there like an idiot!”

She reached out for him, all her charm focussed in one pleading smile. “Let me make it up to you.” She said, glancing over to Adiah. “Anything.”

“You owe me,” he told her. “I want the key to your cupboard.” He demanded, gesturing towards the large carved unit in the corner of the room.

She shook her head. “Wey I can’t.”

“Fine I want the money you owe me. I paid six hundred for that wedding, you should have earned that in a month or so.”

It wasn’t as though she hadn’t given it to him before and parting with so much gold was sacrilegious. Reluctantly she removed a chain from around her neck. A small thin pendant hung from it. She handed it to him. “What do you want it for anyway?”

“Need to have a word with his majesty,” Wey said, finally at ease.

“Wouldn’t bother, he’s not had a girl in weeks, not even a young one. We had them brought in specially and they’re all still sat upstairs aging, be no good to us at this rate.”

Wey shrugged. There were things that took dominance over whoring, albeit not many, but the onset of a civil war was probably one of them. He smiled, winked at Madison and made his way into the cupboard, unlocking the secret door at the back. He slipped into the tiny tunnel and slid up so Adiah could get in. Carefully he closed the door and put his finger to Adiah’s lips. They moved slowly through the shaft, their shoulders pressing against the narrow walls.

“Why is this so tiny?” Adiah whispered.

“Your daddy likes his girls small.”

Adiah stopped walking. She looked behind her, a chill running up her back.

“What’s wrong?” Wey hissed impatiently.

“This,” she said gesturing around herself. “Who was that woman?”

“A whore.”

“A whore you were going to marry?”

Wey rubbed his neck impatiently.

“But she left you?” There were notes of sympathy in her voice.

“Not exactly.” He took a deep breath and continued walking. “I spent a crazy week ashore here ‘bout a year ago. Met Maddy in a bar, hit it off. Before I know it we’ve gone and arranged a wedding. I cough up my spoils from our last prize and the date’s set. Then I wake up sober, realise what the hell I’m doing and catch the first ship heading for Juliet.”

“But you said you were waiting for her. Three hours you said!”

“She never showed up either. She left by horse that morning, so technically I jilted her first. I thought she’d showed up, she thought I had. It wasn’t until I got with a friend of hers that I realised what had happened. So I figured, one day I’ll need to escort a pretty princess through a brothel to meet her father, might be worth letting her think I was heartbroken.”

Adiah gawped at him.

“Nearly there,” he said. “Last chance to change your mind.”

She shook her head.

“Okay once he rings for help we’ve got half a minute to get back here. Keep your back to the wall and run for your life. Don’t stop for me. Head straight back the way we came.”

He pushed open the wall.

Fifteen

They entered a dressing room. Her father's clothes were piled up in a corner. Most were turned inside out. There was nothing on the rails. Wey was unsettled by the state of things. He'd been in this room before, he'd rifled through many of the garments now discarded. What lay before him was an ancient ransacking and he didn't like it one bit.

Withdrawing his pistol he pushed Adiah to the side of the room. Slowly he opened the door into the bed chamber. The smell hit him first, it was old and not overwhelming. He walked slowly into the room crushing the husks of flies and other insects beneath his boots.

The body was still in the bed, sheets stained red, although any blood that might have once been there was now brown. The corpse was little more than bones encased in a dark, shrunken skin. It was still dressed, a breakfast tray rested to one side, the food long since rotten away.

"You know I'm thinking your father might have had less to do with this than we thought."

Adiah stopped at the sight of the body. She gasped, unable to turn away. That was him, the King of Hermia, dead in his own bedroom. Very dead in his own bedroom.

"How long?"

"Looks like a long time, maybe even before you were captured. Where are all his servants? Surly someone must have found him. He keeps this place filled with captured natives, where the hell are they?"

Adiah approached the body. If it wasn't him who was it? Who had done such horrific things to her? She stopped by the bed and looked at the red sheets.

"My brother's room is not far from here. What if he's dead too? Wey, what if Hermia has been invaded?"

Wey looked at their escape. It would be so easy to return home and get some real help with this. Finn at least could add some reason to what they saw before them. He needed to get word back to Napier, the Elders would need to be informed. And there was still that voice, still that nagging voice asking him what had happened to the slaves here.

"Follow me," he said. "I know where your brother's room is."

"Do you know where my room is?"

Wey smiled. "Aye and when I get you back to *the Mirage* you can have the things I took from it."

He led her silently through the palace. Nothing was as it should be. The flowers were dead. The palace was dirty. Usually it would be well lit and warm, now it was a crypt. Their footsteps echoed through the rooms. If Adiah closed her eyes she could remember her childhood in this place, that had all gone now. This empty shell was just bricks and glass.

“Conrad’s rooms,” Adiah said, nervously gesturing to the door at the end of the corridor.

Wey opened it cautiously. The room was lit by a handful of candles and something was sleeping on the bed. Wey held his pistol out. He reached out for Adiah’s arm, desperate to keep her close, then stretched out for the bed and pulled back the covers. A rifle struck his temple. He fell to the floor.

“Hello sister,” Conrad snarled.

Adiah knelt beside Wey. She tried to wake him up. Then she tried to reach for his pistol.

“Naughty, naughty.” He pointed the rifle at Wey. “Look at the company you keep nowadays, my if father knew he would have you hung.”

“*You* have done all this?” She gasped in anger.

“Come, let us go somewhere more comfortable, it’s been too long little sister. Don’t worry about him, he will be dealt with.”

“I don’t think so.”

“Come with me or I shall ensure he doesn’t wake up.”

She walked up to the King’s study, only it was no longer the King’s. Conrad encouraged her to sit down and rang for service. He sat himself, behind the disordered desk, smiling madly at her.

“Gosh, look at you, you’ve turned out quite well, could have perhaps done without those months at sea, but we can’t expect Uncle Harry to realise things like that. Of course you might have noticed we’ve made some changes. Cosmetic really.”

“Why did you send me to the Vaults, Con?”

He frowned and then laughed, “Oh that. You know how us older brothers can be. Do you remember when I made you leap from the nursery window?” He clapped his hands excitedly.

“They raped me Con, tortured and raped me!”

He was unmoved; his mind seemingly occupied by the woes that harassed a new leader.

“Why?”

His eyes narrowed as if he remembered her presence. “It was necessary. I needed answers. If you’d have spoken up earlier, instead of being a coward you would have been dead without any of this bother. But you’re here now so we can forget all that nonsense.”

The door opened and a red stained soldier entered.

“There is a man in my bed chamber, secure him and bring him here with the others. And bring us some tea, we have much to discuss.” The soldier nodded and left without a word.

“Now,” he said rubbing his hands together. “Let’s talk about new friends.”

Sixteen

"All I'm saying Brother is that you need to be done with this business before you make any final decisions." Brother Carlston had talked incessantly since they left the Temple at dawn. "You are an extremely promising priest; you are so well regarded in the Temple."

The carriage they were riding struck a rock and both men bounced into the air.

Finn groaned and made himself comfortable again. "I'll visit my father alone," he told the old priest. "In the meantime Brother I think you should visit the native families, warn them that they are at risk."

"Are you sure that's necessary? It might create a panic."

Finn stared at him with gravely serious eyes. "There will be more deaths."

Carlston grunted and shuffled about in the carriage. "You have become very pessimistic Brother."

"When you have seen what I have you would find it difficult to see anything bright." Finn sighed. "I have spent my life devoted to the light, such darkness is overwhelming. Brother I have been ignorant, and naïve, and damn foolish."

"Poppycock!" Carlston snorted. "You've done nothing more than seen the good, of which there is plenty. Remember Brother this is the will of men and mere men will stop it."

The coach pulled into the courtyard of the Minister's mansion. Finn grimly clambered out and went to enter the house through the servants' entrance. He waved to Carlston sombrely as the coach pulled away. Straightening his coat, he went to see his father.

A tired maid opened the door. She looked at Finn confused, but she was well taught and maintained her composure.

"Can I help you sir?" She asked with polite sternness.

"I am here to see the Minister," Finn replied coolly.

"My apologies sir, Minister Fernwick is too ill to take visitors today. Can I ask who it is that's calling?"

"Mr Finnian Fernwick madam."

The maid frowned and stepped back into the hallway.

"My father will be expecting me."

"Let him in," a voice called from the shadows.

Finn peered down the hallway. His hand tapped the hilt of his sword as he stepped inside. The man was already moving towards the stairs. Finn nodding to the maid in reserved gratitude and hurried to try and catch up.

The door to his father's room was open. He hovered outside for just a moment, then pushed himself forward. He stopped in his tracks and stared at the hissing machinery around the room. It was a complete replica to that found on their last ship. His father rested back in his bed, tubes had been inserted into his arms and diluted poppy powder ran through the needles piecing his veins. The process was already well underway.

Then he saw the figure sat beside the door. Balor nodded at Finn wearily. The poison had already polluted his eyes and some of the liquid had clustered at the edges of his mouth. He was still meticulously dressed, as though that alone separated him from the other zombies.

Finn drew his sword and pointed it at Balor. "You treacherous bastard. I'll kill you for this."

Balor remained calm. His fingers rapped at the arms of his chair.

"Father this man has betrayed us! He sent the guards after us! He is infected with a poison."

"Do shut up boy!" His father croaked. "Betrayed you maybe, but General Balor is working for me." He coughed and rested back in his bed. "Your sister?"

"She's safe. Father this machine will kill you. I have seen what it does."

"He knows," Balor stated. "He insisted."

"You are using him," Finn growled.

"Yes, I am." Balor stood up. "I didn't betray you Master Finn. My mission was always to learn the secret of the red poison. I am still very much dedicated to it. Just like you are the safety of your sister."

Finn lowered his sword. "I don't understand."

Balor walked across to the bed of his master. "We received intelligence of the militia's highest being supplemented with a new drug from Qataria. At first we put it down to hearsay and then gradually we noticed a strange alteration in the minds of men we have known for years. Your father enlisted me to understand what the drug was and its purpose."

"That's why you accompanied me to the Vaults?"

"The King sent his daughter there, I needed to investigate. He was responsible for supplying the militia with the drug and it seems he is very interested in the military position of Helena."

"You believe he's going to make war with Helena?"

"I do, but for what reason I cannot yet say. There is no talk of war or discontentment throughout the regiments, in fact there is no talk at all."

"Qatarian men crave power," his father croaked.

"But you're infected now," Finn swallowed the lump in his throat.

"Yes. And I must stay alive and in control for as long as I am able to find answers and a way to stop this."

“And you boy, you will now help him,” his father ordered. Grey eyes wide open, he stared at his son with reverence. “This process will kill me, but will give Balor enough serum to survive for longer. You must aid him now I no longer can.”

“I have to take Adiah to safety.”

Balor put a firm hand on Finn’s shoulder. “He will aid me. The process is almost complete. Everything shall be taken care of.”

Satisfied the Minister licked his dry lips and closed his eyes again.

“You should spend a few minutes with him, the end will not be long,” he told Finn as he left the room.

Finn hovered by the bed, still clutching his sword. His eyes glanced over the machines. He tried to get an idea of how they worked. Suddenly they stopped pumping, making him jump. He was about to call for Balor when his father stopped him.

“It will begin to drain in a moment and then I shall be gone.” He seemed pleased at the possibility. “You will finish this.”

“I will do what I choose,” Finn snapped. “You should have told me what was going on in the first place!”

His father grimaced.

“People are dying and you should have done something sooner!”

“We did not know what we were dealing with,” his father mumbled.

“You know now and you are leaving the responsibility to me alone! You are weak father and this last sacrifice will not redeem you.”

His father tried to sit up. “These would be your last words to your father?”

Finn blinked away tears from his eyes. “I have a right to be angry.”

“Finn,” he said tenderly. “You have always been strong and wilful. You were your mother’s son not mine. I will die childless, with more regrets than successes, alone and miserable. I was proud you defied me, proud you could stand against me with such conviction and fairness, and I was angry you took it to your heart.” He coughed again and the machines started up. Glass cylinders hanging from the brass network of hydraulics began to fill up. “I planned what I would say to you. Apologise for your mother, and for your sister. It doesn’t matter now does it? You will do what is right, because you have always done what is right. If we are lucky you may hold some of me within you and you will never stop until it is done.”

Kneeling by his bedside Finn took his father’s cold, bony hand. He could force sentiment to make a dying man feel worthy, but his father would know it was a lie, so he merely told the truth. “Despite all you have done I have always believed you to be a good man. The King will be stopped and Adiah will be safe, I give you my word.”

The Minister smiled, “I would have liked to have seen her one more time.” His eyes began to close.

Finn waited for the machine to finish. He felt his father’s pulse grow weaker and weaker until it drifted away with the wind. Strangely he felt at peace now and he rose to cover his father’s head with the blankets around him.

Hearing the machine finish Balor returned. The sight of an old friend’s body made his teeth grind. Sadness could not be used in his new body so it was converted to fury. He unleashed it, throwing the chair by the door across the room. Again he ran through his mantra until he could apologetically turn to Finn.

“The emotions,” he tried to explain. “I can’t control them.” While he was still in control he began to decant the cylinder into prepared syringes.

“There is more than I can carry here,” he told Finn. “You must take some to Helena. Perhaps there is someone there that can study it.” He forced them into Finn’s hands.

“Don’t you need them to survive?”

“The more I carry the more I am likely to take. It is best I only carry the essentials and find a new supply when I need it. Take this too.” He handed him a leather notebook. “Everything that was in my head is there. You will need to study it closely.”

“I can’t come with you Balor, Adiah and Wey are expecting me back.”

Balor agreed. “Of course you’re not coming with me. Your blood is like gold dust, it’s far too dangerous for you here. But you are clever and you can study what I have found out. Perhaps together we can find answers. I can’t think properly anymore, there is too much emotion, but I can still search.”

“How long before you lose total control?”

“Depends on the strength of the blood. Your father was weak, the power I will get will be barely felt, but I hope to regain some control by using it. Read my journal. You can take the equipment too. We shall have it transported to your ship now.”

“That’s what I came here for, I need two ships.”

“That’s impossible, we’ll be lucky if we get one out of Hermia without the navy on your tail,” Balor continued carefully packing away the equipment. “I will send a telegram to the dock, see if we can’t secure something for you.”

Seventeen

*A*diah watched her brother pace the room. In the candlelight he looked almost recognisable, but there were moments when something else lingered within his scrawny body. He splashed his face with water, keeping a pistol pointed at her all the time. She looked for an escape, finding nothing in the royal prison except walls and darkness.

"I shan't go on with threats and scare tactics sister. You know me well enough to be assured I mean what I say and I do not make it a habit to exaggerate or liven up my promises."

"I'd say I don't know you at all, brother."

He paused and stared blankly at her, "No perhaps not, but some of my blood runs through your veins and by now you must know the importance of blood. It is the very essence of our meeting. You know I was trying to find information regarding our uncle, he's an illusive man at the best of times and well, you were the only one of us who broke through his net, being the slippery little fish that you are. As we both know things did not go to plan and that is a lesson to us both, important jobs are worth doing one's self." He stopped and gathered his thoughts. "But I anticipated your return here; you would require answers, maybe even revenge and, of course, I would be waiting. In fact you took your time, I have had ships out searching for you and all have come back empty. You are quite the ghost at times sister."

"Where's Wey?"

"The vagrant you've been accompanying? He's alive. You understand his blood is very precious to me, as, my dear sister, is yours. I am quite aware of your illegitimacy. To tell you the truth I am almost envious. My monster father made me weak against the poppies, but you are immune." He moved to sit on his desk in front of her.

"You killed him, the King, your father?"

Con tossed his head back as though explaining much further was going to be a chore. "Yes Adiah, I killed him. I had been planning to kill him for several years, but the old bastard clung on for dear life. My god if I hadn't of allied myself with Qataria we'd be sat in his office and not mine."

"But he was your father!"

"He killed our mother! Smothered her in her sleep! I saw him and I knew that would have to be punished. Then there were the girls. That was why your real father had you sent away. You were getting to that age and I approved, I forced the King's hand to let you free. You should be grateful to me, heaven only knows what would have become of you had I not intervened. The King was weak, driven by perverse lust. To think what I have accomplished in my short months to his wasted life."

Adiah was silent, her eyes darted to the door waiting for Wey to spring through and save her. It remained closed.

"Now," he said calmly. "Where have you been hiding?"

She screwed her mouth shut and stared at him.

"I had a feeling you would be uncooperative." He moved to ring the servants' bell.

The doors opened and six guards hauled Wey into the room, throwing him to the floor. His nose bled on the already stained carpet. Adiah tried to get up. A guard forced her back into her chair with a slap. Conrad poured the rest of his water over Wey until he came around.

"Good morning Mr Wey."

"Morning? Already?" Wey groaned. "Don't suppose you have anything stronger?"

Conrad ignored him, turning to his sister victoriously. "Where have you been hiding?"

She stood her ground.

"Very well, kill him."

"Wait," she said. "I was in Juliet. In the basement of a house by the coast."

He rolled his eyes, "Yes, after that."

"At sea."

"Under who's command?"

"Don't tell him anything," Wey said, spitting blood down his chin.

She hesitated. One of the guards lashed Wey with his rapier, slicing the skin open and spilling his precious blood into his shirt. Wey clenched his lips shut.

"Captain Napier."

He grinned; the name had finally been repeated. Wey watched his expression with alarm. "On what vessel?"

"*The Mirage*."

He was growing impatient. "Kill him!"

"I'm telling you the truth. It's a real ship. Filled with Fimorri."

"Adiah!" Wey yelled.

"And where does she next make port?"

"I don't know."

"I will kill him."

"Adiah," Wey pleaded.

She looked her brother in the eye and then turned from him defeated. "Straif."

Dramatically, Wey sighed with disappointment, concealing the smirk beneath the blood and sweat dripping down his face.

"And where is Finnian Fernwick?"

“I don’t know.”

Wey screamed as another guard poured a clear chemical into his wound. It was designed to seal the gash and allow the torture to continue for many more hours. His flesh burned, steam rose from his back. He felt faint, clinging onto his consciousness.

“Tell me, or I shall kill your friend.”

Adiah swallowed her fear, “What do you want Finn for?”

Conrad’s mouth twitched in something like a smile, “Make a choice.”

“He’s at the Temple,” she finally said and tried to break free of her guard to get to Wey.

“Ready them for deportation,” he ordered.

“Deportation to where?” Adiah gasped.

“Juliet, for harvesting.”

“Juliet’s crops are destroyed,” Wey sneered.

Conrad grabbed the man’s face with distaste. “We finished harvesting the crops long before you burned them. Now we’re cultivating the key ingredient of our miracle tincture.” He examined Wey’s blood on his finger tips. “You should congratulate yourself Mr Wey, you have never been a more valuable commodity.”

“Con this is madness, people are dying, innocent people!” Adiah pleaded.

“Yes but only so more can live.”

“So what’re you going to do, invade Helena and cultivate that too? Then what Con, you’ll all die eventually.”

He sighed at her ignorance. “We are not going to cultivate Helena, that would be madness. Helena is being infected. They will join my army and we shall invade Straif together. Our united forces will be unstoppable. Straif, when properly managed will provide everything we need to be self-sufficient for eternity.”

“You’re crazy,” she hissed.

“No, I’m practical. Take them!”

Wey sat back in his cell. He’d found his escape route, it would lead him onto the courtyard and from there he could easily slip out into the town. If he made it back to the Temple he could hitch a lift back to *the Mirage* and tell the Elders all he knew. His head was full of priceless information his people desperately needed. He hadn’t moved. Adiah was unconscious in the cell beside him. If he focused he could see her body in the darkness. From where he was he could hear her breathing. He’d tried to wake her, but she was out of his reach and unresponsive to his calls. There were two choices: to wait, or to cut his losses. Logic was urging him through the loose grate in the ceiling.

Still he remained mulling over a decision she had made. She had chosen his life over Finn's; it didn't make any sense.

Adiah felt the coldness of the floor beneath her. Her brain thundered in her skull. She reached out her arms to lift herself. Her eyes opened and there was only darkness. Then she panicked.

"No, no!" Scrambling around on the floor, she cried, pleaded with her captors. The stone beneath her grazed her knees and hands as she tried to crawl free.

"Adi! Adi! It's okay."

She pushed herself towards the noise. "Egan, I can't see you!"

Wey reached his hands through the bars and tried to grab her. "Listen to me Adi, this isn't the Vaults." He caught hold of her jacket and pulled her towards him. "It's me," he said softly, reeling her in. "We're still in the palace, they haven't moved us yet."

She wiped the tears from her face. The surroundings were so familiar she almost believed he was lying to her. Pushing herself against the bars she held on to his arms and shoulders as best she could.

"I thought he'd taken me back there."

"For the moment we're safe, are you hurt?"

"I don't think so. I'm cold."

He held her tighter through the bars. "We've just got to wait here until they come for us, then we'll escape."

Adiah took a deep breath to steady her nerve. She pressed her head against the bare skin on Wey's hands to draw her from the nightmare.

"How long before they come for us?"

"Could be a few hours yet. Lay down beside the bars," he whispered. She did as she was asked, ignoring the filth her body rested in. He copied her in his own cell and threaded what limbs he could through the bars. She was shivering from the shock, this way he could hold her steady. His fingers curled around her small spikes of hair until she finally relaxed.

"I can't bury it," she eventually said. "I still get the nightmares."

Wey sighed, "They don't go away."

She rolled to face him. "You don't talk about it."

"It's not something people like to hear."

"I know nothing about you."

"Not many people do."

"What were you like, before you went to the Vaults?"

He thought about it, “A cocky boy. I was trying to be a man, be like my father. I don’t know what I was like really. Young and stupid probably.”

“And what about now?”

“Old and stupid,” he smiled and she could just see it in the darkness. “I still have the nightmares,” he finally confessed. “Not from the first time. You see the first time they got me they killed everyone, everyone but me and some other boys. Our families tried to rescue us. They shipped me out with the other bodies and when I felt fresh air on my face I ran. I always thought that would stay with me, being hidden in a pile of my dearest friends and family.”

“But it hasn’t?”

“The second time was six years ago and I knew if I stayed there more than a week I was as good as dead. There were two of us then - they got us for piracy - but your father knew we were Fimorri and wanted information. My friend, Kai, he was just a kid and they took a liking to him. He didn’t know anything so they kept at him, barely touched me, few beatings, nothing like the first time. Kai spent long enough in the room to find the incinerator. They… they cut off his foot, god only knows why, and he saw where they put it. With his dying breath he told me how to escape. I dream those last moments most nights and know that I failed him.”

Adiah’s mouth felt dry, she knew she was the only person to hear his story and it frightened her that he might be the only one to truly understand hers. “Then I owe you both my life.” She took a deep breath. “I always wake up at the same moment. The soldiers have boarded my ship. They line up all of us and separate us. They take the stronger men and tie them up. Then they take the rest of us and we are beaten and raped. I am so ashamed they have to watch it and so I turn away from them. There are screams and I turn back to see half my crew have been slaughtered. The Captain of the soldiers grabs me by the hair and stabs me. He tells me to beg for Mercy and I refuse so he rapes me again and beats me until I can take no more and when I am finished with he brings out Leigh. He ties her up in the centre of the boat to watch. They drag her husband out and shoot him. I always wake up seeing the look in her eyes and know nothing I feel could be as bad as what Mercy did to her.”

Wey released her as the words registered in his head. “Mercy? Captain Mercy?”

“You’ve heard of him?”

“Oh hell and fury.” He sat up and tugged at his hair. “He captured you?”

“Yes. What’s wrong? Who is he?”

“He’s the Privateer your father employed to hunt *the Mirages*. He’s already taken two and now he knows one is in these waters. Shit, shit, bastard, shit!”

“There are other *Mirages*?”

“You’ve put everything at risk!”

“What? How?”

“You gave up the name of the ship and it’s Captain. I need to get out of here.”

“We can’t until they come for us.”

Wey hesitated.

“Egan?”

“I can get out of here,” he murmured. “I just can’t get you out.”

Adiah sat up and clutched the bars. “Well go then.”

“I can’t leave you here.” His mind was screaming at him to move his backside and warn his kin, but her hand was touching his as though she were sewn to him.

“You have to warn Napier. Egan you have to warn Finn and the others!”

Wey swallowed the lump in his throat. “I won’t be able to come back for you.”

“Then don’t.”

“I tried,” he confessed, desperate for a clarifying drink.

She frowned. “Egan.”

“Yes I know it will probably end tragically, but I really couldn’t give a damn. So shut up and wait for the guards to come, we’ll get out that way, together.”

“No,” she said shaking her head in the darkness. “I am not worth all of those people. Leave me here. Egan just leave, I mean it.”

Wey folded his arms defiantly, ignoring her endless pleas, until he realised she couldn’t see him. “Okay I’m going.” He moved to the far side of his prison and sat down to think in silence.

Her heart sank as silence fell upon her. Tears streamed down her dirty cheeks and she tried to think of the sea and drowning in it.

Eighteen

He sat for almost an hour waiting and trying to make up his mind. At first it was a joke, but he carried it for too long and now he was almost regretting his decision not to leave. She sobbed softly the entire time, although any great declarations and confessions she might have poured out never came. So he sat there, not daring to make a noise and having no idea what to do next. What was worse was his bladder was now close to bursting and at some point he was going to have to do something.

Finally footsteps could be heard from outside. A thin beam of light shone over Adiah's face then over Wey's.

"You!" Adiah said in a fury. "How long have you been there?" She hissed.

"Few minutes," Wey lied.

The door opened and two soldiers stepped inside with tainted red faces. They were poorly dressed and heavily armoured. Wey checked the doorway; they were alone. Finally his luck had set in.

"You wait till they get you out of there you bitch, I'm going to kill you!" He screamed at her.

She backed away from the door.

"Yeah that's right you get back there and hide, I'm going to fucking kill you!"

The soldiers opened Wey's cell first. He was marched out and made to stand by Adiah's cell. Her door was opened. Before the soldiers had time to think Wey had leapt inside. He pounced on Adiah, knocking her back against the wall. His hand wrapped itself around her neck and he squeezed slightly. He yelled at her and screamed obscenities. The soldiers dived after him. They grabbed Wey and pulled him into the centre of the cell.

"Go!" Wey yelled at Adiah. He slammed his fist into one of the soldier's faces and kicked at the other. The room was only lit by a small gas lamp and with his back to it he couldn't tell who he had hold of. Taking no chances he threw the soldier into the bars, ramming his head against the metal until the body went limp. The second guard was stronger, knocking him to the floor. Wey quickly clambered up, throwing dirt into the guard's eyes. He bared his teeth and lunged at the man like a savage animal. The guard dropped to the floor. He pinned him down and grabbed his head, twisting it until the neck snapped. He sat back on the floor out of breath and smug.

The body to his left sat up. Wey leapt back. There was a shot. Blood and brain matter spattered against the wall. Behind the flickering candle light Adiah clutched the gun.

"Good shot."

"I was aiming for his back."

He grabbed a weapon of his own and strutted out of the cell, pulling her up along the way. With his arm tightly around her waist he led the way clear of the cells.

"Familiar route?" Adiah whispered, as she was led out into the open air of the courtyard.

"Done it a few times. Don't look so nervous, this is your home remember; you have a right to be here." Wey straightened his back and confidently marched through the courtyard. There were a handful of plain dressed townsmen bustling about the courtyard, all showing signs of the red poison. They went about their tasks of preparing the stables without giving the intruders a second glance. Even on his best day Wey had never been this lucky.

"I thought you were Princess of this place." Wey walked away from the security of the shadows and let the midday sun beam down on his bloody face.

"Wey," Adiah gasped, trying to pull him back.

"You there!" Wey yelled. "Saddle up those horses!"

One of the townsmen peered at him, then responded. He gathered the tack and began fitting the two nearest horses, eventually leading them out to the courtyard.

"What are you doing?" Adiah whispered.

"Do you want to walk all the way back to the Temple?" He said through gritted teeth.

The horseman approached them. His red eyes stared through Adiah. Wey smacked the back of his head. "Bow to your Princess you piece of shit!" He yelled.

The horseman bowed his head and handed the reigns over to Wey.

"Get on your knees," Wey ordered with the authority of a thousand kings.

He took Adiah's hand and led her up the horseman mount. The horseman remained kneeling, even when Wey mounted his own mare.

"Open the gates!" Adiah commanded.

Slowly the sanctuary of the town was unveiled.

"Thank the Prince for his hospitality," Adiah told the horseman bitterly. "And be sure to tell him we *will* repay the favour." She kicked the horse into a gallop.

The horses stormed through the cobbled streets. The sound of the escape was absorbed by the sudden influx of people filling the neighbouring square. They were forced to slow as the crowd swelled. Wey pressed them further until he could see a dark frame obliterating the light around them. He pulled on the reigns sharply. A body danced from the gallows ahead, a figure so familiar it gave him a chill. He dismounted and led the horse through the crowd until he could see the face clearly. His mouth twitched with displeasure. Maddy's feet stopped kicking and she was cut down and dumped with the other girls. Many men watched the event with tears in their eyes.

"What's going on?" Wey whispered to the bystander beside him.

“The King ordered the soldiers to storm the Lily Garden early this morning. The whores were spying on us, relaying information to Straif, damn bitches.” He looked at Wey as a streak of red ran from his nose.

“The King?” Wey growled. He turned sharply away, cutting a path back to Adiah.

“Who was it?” She asked apprehensively.

“Maddy.”

She exhaled in relief and Wey saw it. His hands tightened around the reigns as he hauled himself up. His mind clouded with thoughts of revenge and malice. Adiah led the route this time, ensuring they moved directly to the Temple. She tried to calculate how many hours she had been away from Finn and knew Conrad would have already attacked them.

The Temple doors were shattered, broken by axes and hammers. Wey dismounted and allowed his horse to move on. Adiah climbed down carefully and followed Wey inside. They were so late the bodies had been cleaned away. Wey had at least hoped for some kind of trail to follow, but any prisoners would be back at the palace or on their way to Juliet. He cursed himself for not leaving Adiah when he had the chance. She cursed him too.

“Finn!” She screamed. “Finn! Benton!” She turned to Wey panicked. “Where are they?”

He sighed defeated, “Not here.”

They marched into the heart of the Temple where the priests were mourning their dead brothers. The overwhelming serenity once bestowed on them was now replaced by emptiness. It felt cold and lifeless. The central prayer room held the answers to the transformation and they both cautiously entered, awaiting the culpability undoubtedly due to them. There they found Brother Carlston holding the cold hand of Brother Howard. The bodies had been reverently laid out and cleaned. Some were adorned with a few personal effects and the surviving brothers sat beside them in grief and prayer.

Carlston looked up at the guests in pain. “He was my best friend,” he said stunned. “We were here thirty years and argued every day.”

Wey knelt down and stared coldly at the bodies around him. “The others?”

“Captured,” an abrupt voice called.

Abram and Thorin stood in the doorway. Abram’s neck had been bandaged and, much to his relief, the wound had finally stopped bleeding. Wey nodded at Carlston and left the priests to mourn, knowing he could do nothing for those he had brought trouble on.

“Bennie and Saunders?”

“Taken,” Abram replied as they stepped into the fresh air. “Soldiers stormed the place four hours ago. They rounded up the natives, and left the rest of us for dead.” He rubbed the bloody bandage on his neck.

“And Finn?” Adiah gasped.

“He never came back from town.”

Wey chewed on his swollen lower lip. “Chances are they got him too. They’ve got Mercy working with them.”

Abram’s eyes opened wide and all thoughts he had regarding his lost friends were immediately overshadowed by the panic he felt for his ship.

Nineteen

The night was closing in as their carriage arrived in town. Abram steered the horses, Wey sat beside him. They had stashed Adiah and Thorin in the back. For the moment Wey needed to think straight and her constant whining over Finn was making him angry. The soldiers' increasing presence on the streets was becoming undisciplined and rampant. They made their way through the town unnoticed, red shirts and faces becoming an urban crop of poppies.

"Go in first," Wey told Abram and gave him a handful of coins. "Sit in the shadows and watch. Shoot anything that looks like it's going to shoot me."

Abram's pirate hands tickled at the touch of gold. He climbed down from the coach and, stuffing the coins into his pockets, he began to make his way to the Red Dragon Inn. Wey waited until he was inside then dismounted himself. He opened the carriage door and woke Adiah up. Thorin leapt out and Wey dragged Adiah out after him. His mood was beyond foul and he wanted to kill something.

"Listen to me," he growled. "You don't speak when you're inside right. You don't make eye contact with anyone. You don't acknowledge anyone you might know."

"Where are we going?"

"To get information, and to give information."

"But Finn…"

He grabbed hold of her angrily. "If I hear Finn's name pass your lips one more time I will cut them off. I know the bastard's missing, just like two of my lads are. If you would be so kind as to grant me a fucking hour to warn my ship what's going on and save their sorry souls I can then think about sorting out the mess you created."

She opened her mouth to say something until her common sense got the better of her. Satisfied, he removed one of the pistols from his sling and stuck it in her coat, then pulled her into the Red Dragon without sentiment. The bar was an explosion of life. Drunken women launched themselves from the tables into crowds of poisoned men. So many had been infected and those that weren't were lapping up the pleasures of the poisoned populace. Fights broke out and were absorbed into a crowd hell bent on singing and fucking to death. Only a spatter of native faces watched the scene in utter bewilderment, while they waited for friends that had already been taken.

Wey gripped Adiah's arm. Several unfamiliar hands pinched her as she walked towards the counter. Her eyes wandered at the sight of two men pounding fists into each other and a woman unconscious on the floor, her skirt over her head revealing every modesty she had to offer. Then she spied a familiar face in the darkness, a face that was more white eyes than anything. He blinked at her unaffected by the inferno of frenzy around him.

Wey slammed a coin on the bar and a small hand reached up and took it from him.

"Back room," Wey demanded, gesturing to Adiah. "Make it quick, she won't wait all night."

The little man at the bar glanced up at him in surprise. He scurried to open the cellar door and ushered them both inside discreetly. Quickly he locked the door and dusted his hands on the small apron he wore about his waist. He, at least, exhibited no signs of the poison. Wey's demeanour changed slightly. He let go of Adiah and became more flustered in his actions.

"I need a bird," he told Groader.

"A bird?"

"I need to get word to Napier."

"Is something wrong?"

Wey gawped and looked at the door he had just come through. "Hell has just spat up every low life scumbag into your bar to screw and kill each other in plain view and you think that's normal!"

Groader shrugged, "Typical Tuesday night at the minute."

"You've not noticed the red liquid pouring out of them?" Adiah asked surprised.

Wey scowled at her.

"That's just the after affects of the cure," Groader replied flippantly.

"Cure for what?"

"The pox. Bleeds the area affected, stops the disease in its tracks."

"Bull shit. That is a poison, a mind control fucking poison that is turning them all into pawns for the Prince."

"I think you might need a drink," Groader replied.

"Come on Groader, when have I ever pissed you about? Juliet was crawling with them, these soldiers that wouldn't die and they were marching the natives round like slaves. You go up there and count the regulars that are missing. Those old pirates that used to sail with us. See who they've taken."

Groader scratched his head and his smile faded. Wey was right; there were a lot of absent faces. "What do you need?"

"A room for the night and weapons." Wey scratched his head as he thought. "Need you to put the feelers out, see who they've got in holding, and the shipping news. Get me the name of anyone going to Juliet."

"That's a lot of work," Groader grumbled.

"Aye, even more for a dead man."

"Please," Adiah added. "Our friends are in trouble."

Wey glared at her now.

“Okay, okay. Come with me.”

His modest legs tackled the stairs with great stamina. Eventually he reached the top room. Drawing his hook of keys he removed one and unlocked the door to the attic. The noise from below was dampened but still loud. Groader pushed open the door and showed them inside. There was a tiny bed pushed in the corner and a chest at the end of it. It was surprisingly clean, even if there was barely enough room for Adiah and Thorin to stand side by side.

“Weapons are in the chest there,” Groader said. “Powder and shot too. Top room so no one should be up here.”

“Good, I’ll be down in a minute to organise the rest.”

Taking the hint Groader excused himself, ensuring he closed the door behind him. Wey wasted no time. He threw back the lid of the chest and inspected the weapons inside, removing a cutlass and second pistol. He had hoped being inside the Dragon would have lifted his spirits, instead he found himself growing increasingly dark. When he closed his eyes he saw Maddy dangling like a rag doll over a crowd as dead as she was. There were other ways to get into the palace, why had he chosen that one? He knew why, he wanted to see Adiah’s face. He was trying to provoke her, always trying to provoke her and this time he went too far.

“So now what?” Adiah asked.

Wey held up his clenched fist. “What about ‘don’t speak to anyone’ did you not understand?”

She clenched her lips together. His shift since their time in the palace was unnerving and she wasn’t going to stand for it. “What now?”

“Now! Now we sit here and hope the soldiers don’t come for us.”

“The others are still trapped, Finn might be out there looking for us!”

“Or they could all be dead,” he snapped.

She slapped his face hard. “You will listen to me Egan Wey! They are not dead until I have seen their bodies! I am going to rescue them and you are going to help me.”

“If you hadn’t put them all in danger we wouldn’t have to rescue them,” he yelled.

“So you’d rather I let them kill you?”

“Well you seem pretty intent on doing that yourself, sending me after them.”

“Fine, don’t come. Leave your friends to rot. Leave me, see if I give a damn!”

Wey marched to the door.

“Where are you going?”

“To get what I need to rescue *my* friends. Do what I say for once and stay here!” He slammed the door shut. The argument fuelled him down the stairs, although he couldn’t recall why he suddenly hated her so much.

When he reached the bar he gave Abram the nod. In an instant the pirate was by his side as though they were total strangers.

"She's upstairs, in the top room." Wey told him under his breath. "Keep her there until we receive word back from Groader."

"Where will you be?"

"Down here, keeping my eye on the place."

Despite his dissatisfaction at the arrangement, Abram sneaked into the interior of the Red Dragon and made it upstairs unnoticed. Wey now stood alone, he ached throughout his entire body and he needed it to stop. Everywhere he looked the lights were going out. He was drowning. The flowing seas and meadows that were once his were being fenced off. His world was slipping away so he did the only thing he could. He drank.

Mildly intoxicated he composed a simple note to pass to *the Mirage*: Mercy, Retreat. He passed it to Groader and was told the runners had been sent out. By the end of the night he would have all he needed. Wey took a bottle and forced himself onto a table. The musicians were murdering the shanties and the crowd loved it. Wey swallowed fast and hard. The hours needed to melt away. He wished his friends, those that would have dragged him from that hell, were waiting for him; he hoped they were.

Twenty

"He's lost it," Adiah told Abram. "I don't know what it was that made him snap, but he has. And now the others are going to die."

Abram stood by the door nervously. He was never very good at talking to women. He was also very wary of Wey, the man had a temper and he was always careful not to cross him. His feet were aching and he wanted to sit down.

"We have to do something Abe."

"He said to wait here," he replied anxiously.

"This is Finn and Beau and Benton we're talking about. Abram the things Con will do to them, we can't let it happen."

Abram was silent. Adiah fell back on the bed irritated. Wey had been gone for such a long time and she was hungry, and tired, and desperate for answers. Con could have left the island already, then there would be no chance to catch him. Or he could be searching for them, turning every home in Hermia upside down. Soon enough they would be found. And where the hell was Wey?

"I can't take it anymore." She jumped off the bed. "Lets go downstairs, we can at least get something to eat."

The prospect of filling his stomach was too tempting to ignore. They left the room with Thorin in tow. The sound grew louder and louder. There was a stale smell of beer emanating from below, that and cooking meat. Adiah slipped into the bar and scanned the room. She saw Groader and a stranger talking. A cauldron of stew roasted on the fire. And in the corner of the room there was Wey.

Abram spotted him too. Several witty thoughts came to his head, none of which were at all appropriate to utter. He sighed and lowered his head as he was forced to confront Wey and the two wenches that were happily spending his money. As far as pirates went, Abram preferred to keep confrontation to a minimum, he found raised voices stressful and would much rather settle matters with a quick box than argue.

"Time to move," Adiah said disdainfully.

Wey lifted his head from the chest of the brunette whore and growled. "I told you to wait in your room." He glared at Abram with deep malice. "And I told you to watch her."

"What right do you have to order either of us? Who says he can't drink and whore as well?"

Wey spread his arms wide. "If he's got the money."

"Leave us," Adiah demanded of the women.

Wey clutched onto them defensively. "I've paid for another half hour."

She pulled out her pistol and aimed it at his crotch. “You won’t be needing it.”

The whores removed their hands from Wey’s trousers and collected their coins. The blonde spat at Adiah’s feet and she walked passed.

“Get yourself together.”

Belligerently Wey got up and fell forward. Abram caught him and the two of them began to drag him out of the bar. Groader glanced over in time to witness everything, then turned back to his stranger with a disenchanted shake of his head.

It was difficult getting Wey upstairs and even harder getting him into the room. Abram had to thump his hands to stop him gripping the door handle. Eventually they threw him on the bed and stood over him like disappointed parents.

“What are we going to do with him?”

“Kill him,” she replied in a deadly serious tone. “Go get something to eat. You look starved. I can take care of him.”

“You won’t tell him I helped you when he wakes up will you?”

She shook her head and encouraged him out of the room. After checking he was on his way she moved back to the bed and shook the drunkard awake.

“Wey,” she said sternly. “Wake up.”

He moaned and rolled over.

“Wake up!” She grabbed him and with tremendous force turned him back around.

Reluctantly he sat up and put his head in his hands.

“What the hell were you doing?”

He looked up, bleary eyed and confused. He was sure he should have been in the bar.

“You’re drunk.”

He was always drunk.

“And if the soldiers had come for us what would have happened?”

He blew a raspberry and closed his eyes.

She sat on the floor exhausted. “Is this because of her?”

He shrugged, desperate to lie back down and stop the world spinning.

“It wasn’t your fault.”

He scoffed, “Then why didn’t I just scale the wall instead of being a tosser!”

“Because it was the best way to do it.”

He shook his head despairingly. “Because I wanted to see the look on your face when you saw her. When you knew what I could have had.”

“And after that didn’t work you thought hiring two whores for the night might get you a better reaction? What did you want me to do Wey, be shocked that you have a past, or that you pour

endless coin into a woman's purse to play with your cock in a room full of strangers? Did you want me to be outraged, amused, aroused?"

He cowered back, feeling foolish.

"Someone died to day, just like someone died yesterday, just like we're all going to die if you don't sober up and think sensibly about this."

"A lot of people died today," he growled. "Whose fault was that?"

She slapped him adding another hand mark to the one still visible. It made him feel better. "Don't you blame me for that! I told him what I knew to save your life."

"Letting how many others die?"

She was furious, at him and herself. He was right, but why did he have to condemn her for it? If she had to do it again the situation would still have been the same, the outcome would still have mirrored what had happened.

"I kept you alive," she said darkly, "I kept you alive because you can save more people. You can help me. You think you've seen death? This is just the start of it. Con will come for your people, for us all and we must stop him."

He rubbed his eyes and tried to drown out her voice.

"Are you even listening to me?"

"Can we just fuck and go to sleep?"

"You are unbelievable. Well you can sleep this off and I'll get our friends by myself!"

Wey grumbled as she opened the door. The words slowly soaked into his sponge head. Despite the dizziness he jumped to his feet and fell towards the door. "Wait," he groaned. "Just sit down and let me think." He pushed her to the floor and resumed his place on the bed. "As soon as Groader tells us where they are I'll go get them. That was my plan."

"The state you're in?"

"I'll get them. Now please be quiet."

"Can I ask you something?"

He groaned in protest.

"Is this how you do it, how you escape from what happened to you?"

Forcing himself to sit up he wagged a finger in her face. "Stop being all philosophical. There's not a man I know who has not been so drunk he's near dead with a whore beside him. I am conscious and unaccompanied, consider me a saint."

"What about Finn?"

"Pah, now he knows what he was missing he'll be drowning in it. Besides just because he's a wet fish doesn't mean everybody else is. And you can quit comparing us, I'll never match him and he'll never satisfy you."

She rolled her eyes. “Go to sleep Wey.”

“I’ll tell you something, Princess, you can stop with your little games as well. He’s about as interested in you as I am in Beau. There, that wiped that smug look off your face. You know he’d rather screw his dead wife than you.”

“And I’d rather Mercy screwed me again, than let you anywhere near me.” It was an obvious lie, but it chilled the air. He had pushed her too far.

“Adi,” he began.

“No, don’t start. This thing between us, it’s too much. I’m sick of the games and the arguing. At least if we were sleeping together we’d be gaining something.”

Wey mumbled something about rectifying the situation. She dutifully ignored him.

“It stops now.”

Things had to be better in the morning.

Twenty One

The ship *the Hawk* was manned by a temporary crew to take the cargo to the Temple and return back by coach. It was a simple arrangement and all who knew about the operation were heavily paid and just happened to be natives. Finn watched as the men readied the ship, finding their professionalism and sobriety refreshing. Balor leaned beside him with his eyes closed. They had not really spoken since they packed up the equipment. Balor was busy concentrating and Finn had no idea how he should behave around the soldier. Eventually he had to end the silence.

"Does it hurt?"

"I feel fit and strong, like a man as young as you. There is no pain in my knees, I have slept on the floor for days without feeling the effect. I am invigorated."

Finn was surprised.

"They wouldn't even see it coming Master Finn. Suddenly soldiers have found themselves stronger and faster without repercussions and, well, who cares if they feel angry all the time. They hit their children, rape their wives, but they feel amazing and they need to keep it up."

A young boy ran towards them. "Sir," he said addressing Balor. "The mansion has been ransacked. Soldiers came in and tore everything apart. Word is the King has taken some prisoners from the Temple too, traitors."

Balor handed the boy a gold coin.

Finn panicked. "Adiah!"

"Come with me," Balor said calmly. "It was on my way anyway." He turned to the sailors. "Go without us we'll rendezvous at the Temple."

Balor had thrown his fair share of scoundrels into prison and liberated enough radicals who found favour with Minister Fernwick. His appearance alone permitted him complete freedom among his fellow infected soldiers. Their mindless obedience created a red carpet to the palace and dungeons. Although Balor felt he was trying his luck, his exterior was cool and crimson. He slipped through the narrow passages known only by the soldiers and reached the entrance to the dungeons.

"They're not as big as they once were," he told Finn as his mind started to cloud again. "When the Vaults were built most of the prisoners were shipped there straight after trial. Sometimes before."

"Are you okay?"

Balor put his head in his hands. "It is gaining control over me again. Master Finn I am not a man as good as yourself, there are things I have done, things that shame my sane mind, but I am forced to relive them, reinterpret them. I enjoy them Finn and yearn for more."

Finn swallowed, afraid for the man and afraid for himself. “We may find a cure.”

Balor shook his head and in anger thumped the wall beside Finn. With his uninjured hands he fumbled for the keys to the cells. “Take these. I will do what I can in the time I have. If you see me again I beg that you kill me without question.”

“Even if I have found a cure?”

“You will not be able to cure what I am sure to do.”

Finn took the old General’s hand. “I will do my best to make some sense of this madness.”

Balor smiled, “And tell Wey to go fuck himself.”

“Eh, I will.”

“So what you’re saying is we all have predetermined destinies?” Beau asked Brother May.

Brother May nodded wearily.

“Our fate here is as it should be?”

Benton grunted, “Sounds a lot like bollocks to me. Destiny didn’t drag us here, those bilge-sucking zombies did.”

Beau screwed up his oversized face. “I suppose you could say they, as a society, have chosen the King who started this and we, as a race, opted to remain segregated, forcing a distinct difference in our genes; and also that we came here of our own volition, despite the dangers. It could be said from the offset we predetermined our ultimate capture.”

“You’re strangely coherent when you’re sober,” Benton replied.

There was someone coming. Benton nudged Beau in the shoulder. They moved to the front of the cell. It was a silly plan and they both knew it wouldn’t work, but it was better than sitting and waiting to be transported. Beau would grab the guard and Benton would disarm him. With their backs to the oncoming soldier they held their breath as he turned the key.

“Get off! Beau!” Finn hissed, as he tried to break free of the headlock he found himself in.

“Beau,” Benton said softly. “That’s not how we greet our friends.”

Apologetically he released Finn and, to make the pain in his neck go away, he ruffled the young man’s hair affectionately. “Sorry Finn, lad, thought you was one of those bilge-fucking zombies.”

“You get the ships?” Benton asked.

“Yes, well one, and the keys to the cell, and an escape route. Seems I have to do everything around here at the moment. Where’s Wey and Adi?”

Benton paused and realised he had no idea where Wey was, although he had been expecting to see him any moment.

“Damn land pirate has gone and done a runner I’ll bet you!” Beau said in outrage. “Bit o’ daintiness and he’s off like shits.”

“They’re not here?” Finn gasped.

“Your gal was heading this way, so I expect Wey’s got her safe somewhere.” Benton patted Finn’s shoulder. “Don’t worry lad he’ll show up, he always does.”

“Aye after having his way with something!” Beau joked.

The priests glanced away from him in silence.

“Shall we?” Finn said trying to reassure himself with a smile.

Twenty-Two

*A*bram sat in between Adiah and Wey. He pressed his fork against the over cooked eggs in front of him and hoped that one of his companions would say something. The pair had been making eyes at each other since they met, he had hoped that last night Wey would have been either castrated or sated. He certainly didn't expect there would still be tension in the air. Adiah had said she would deal with him and yet there they sat, glaring at each other, like loaded canon.

The little man that owned the inn was talking to them. Abram had tried to keep up, but the little man spoke too quickly and his accent was confusing. Then the conversation had been overshadowed by the tension and Abram couldn't decide how to get his eggs to Thorin without anyone noticing.

"So we meet them on route." Wey said. "Should be easy enough."

"They are well protected," Groader warned.

Wey shrugged and rested back in his chair.

"And there's no mention of Finnian Fernwick with them?" Adiah asked puzzled.

"Not in custody."

Abram slid the first egg off his plate and onto the floor. Nobody saw. Casually he moved the second, only this one caught his leg and ran into his socks. He felt Thorin's tongue around his ankle and stifled a giggle.

"Where will you go once you have them?" Groader asked curiously.

"Don't worry not here. Try and stowaway somewhere, see what's available. You've sent the message?"

"Of course."

"And you'll get yourself and the family off this island."

Groader grimaced slightly, "This is my home lad, we'll have to see what her ladyship says."

"Tell her whole families are being taken," Adiah replied coolly. "They'll not spare any of you."

"And on that merry note, we'll be going." Wey shook Groader's hand. "Good luck friend, hope to see you back at the Barge and we'll toast our fortune."

"Aye," Groader replied dubiously.

Wey concealed every weapon he could within his jacket. Anything he couldn't stuff in his pockets he passed on to Abram and Adiah. The prisoners were going board the *White Swan* at noon. It gave Wey a very brief window of opportunity to intercept them without attracting too much attention. He

wasn't confident of success, which was why most of his weapons were concealed well enough to ensure that he could use them when they transported him.

"So what's the plan?" Adiah asked enthusiastically.

"I'll get the prisoners, you two can find Finn."

Adiah grabbed him. "You can't do it on your own."

He raised his eyebrows daringly.

"Okay let's put it to a vote. I vote we stay together."

Wey ground his teeth, "We split up."

Both turned to Abram. He gulped hard and wondered if the wolf got to vote. They were probing him for an answer and he decided it was best to ally himself with the one he was most scared of.

"I think we should stick together."

Wey snarled, "Grow a pair." He barged past them irritably.

Adiah winked at Abram and she too quickly left the comfort of the Dragon. She was energized, they were doing something, fighting against her brother and it felt good. She could even ignore the fresh smell of alcohol on Wey's breath now he was helping. She marched through the streets feeling like a hero, like she was finally worth something on the godforsaken island.

Wey tried to focus. The last thing he wanted was an entourage of eager novices. Abram was a pirate and had no idea about the islands. And, Adiah, well she had no idea about anything.

He raged through the crowds of people, cutting his path with malice. His hands ran conspicuously through his jacket, checking his weapons were secure. From the harbour he picked out *the White Swan*. The large slave ship was poorly armoured and swelling with fresh cargo. He walked passed it, ignoring Adiah as she struggled to keep up.

Eventually they reached the small wooden bridge the prisoners would have to cross to reach the harbour. The road narrowed to pass over a small river, giving them the perfect opportunity to hijack the coach when it slowed. Wey hoped that the seclusion of the area would prevent chaos, he also hoped that the river would provide them with an escape route.

"Wait at the opening," Wey told them. "When the coach comes through block their escape. If they start shooting, jump."

Adiah nodded, foolishly confident.

"Watch her back," he told Abram.

Wey positioned himself by the exit with Thorin by his side. He studied the road, casually leaning against the supporting beam structure. It wouldn't be long. He glanced over to Adiah and Abram, noticing how out of place they both looked. The road was still empty. Impatience set in. It was late,

good things rarely ran late. Adiah caught his eye, puzzled; then her own opened wide. He saw red coats appear from nowhere. Rifles were suddenly aimed in his direction. Instinctively he raised his hands, knowing men who wanted to kill him wouldn't wait to pull a trigger. Abram mirrored him. Adiah moved for her pistol. Wey shook his head in warning.

He turned around, unsurprised at the chain of events. Unsurprised and pissed off. He felt the blackness grow over him. Removing his obvious weapons, he dropped them to the ground. The soldiers approached them, their stained faces as red as their shabby coats. Adiah and Abram followed suit. Relaxing, the soldiers approached.

"You are under arrest by order of the King."

"Long live the King." Wey waited until they were close enough. Then he unleashed. Grabbing the first soldier he smashed his forehead into the man's nose. He thumped and kicked, scratched and bit. The butt of a rifle slammed into Wey's back. He fell to the floor. Adiah screamed his name. He was thumped in the face. His mouth filled with blood and he spat it in the faces of the soldiers around him. They bound his hands behind his back and forced him to his feet, kicking him as he strove to move forward. Adiah and Abram were already being ushered into a cart under heavy guard. The soldiers hauled Wey in, winding him with three final blows.

He laughed, spraying blood over the floor of the cart. He rested against Adiah, grinning and grimacing. The pain was good, it was inspiring and he knew now what needed to be done.

Twenty-Three

The journey through Hermia was slow and rocky. Adiah sat upright, surveying her homeland in dismay. Too many empty red eyes glared back at her. They were being infected indiscriminately, men, women, elderly, children. The streets themselves were falling into disarray, buildings left desolate and deteriorating. Soon it would look as though civil war had broken out, with only the dead inhabiting the island.

Touching the skyline was the palace, with its glass domes and crystal walls. The Qatarian inspired buildings came into view, their gleaming surfaces becoming dirty and dull. The palace opened its gate. Bile rose in the back of her mouth. Things were not going well.

Wey took note of the six men marching with the coach, a further two were driving it, although somewhat haphazardly. He felt one of his concealed blades digging into his hip. The guards should have searched him, but their drugged minds had forgotten. He pulled himself up, pressing against Adiah.

"Put your hands down my trousers," he mumbled through gritted teeth.

She shoved him.

"Seriously, there's a pocket to the left, on the inside. Pull the razor out."

"Get Abram to do it."

He took a deep breath, "You've got smaller hands. Adi we're nearly there. Might be an idea to get a move on."

She glanced at Abram. He looked passively at the scenery, hoping she wouldn't manage to catch his eye. Slowly she inched forward until she touched his leg and then fumbled to unfasten his buttons. The first two were easy, the third and forth posed somewhat of a problem. There wasn't enough space to get her hands through. She was getting frustrated.

"Take your time," Wey whispered. "Do it gently."

"Why'd you have to hide the damn things in your trousers?"

"Razorblade in the trousers, shot and gunpowder in the heels of me boots and two skewers up my sleeves," he whispered. "Logical."

She finally unfastened the last of the buttons. After a moments hesitation she thrust her hand into the unknown and started to rummage. Wey suppressed a smile and began a series of gloating eye gestures at Abram.

"Got it," she gasped in relief. Her finger tips pulled out the wrapped up metal from its tiny pocket. She began to ease it into the open. When she felt air on her wrists and whipped her hands free.

“Damn you woman!” Wey hissed angrily and checked the cut above his groin. It was just a scratch, a scratch too close for his liking.

“Sorry, sorry, sorry.”

He shuffled to the side until their hands could meet. Taking the blade from her, he began to cut into his restraints. They fell off his hands without much effort. Keeping one hand firmly behind his back he slashed Adiah’s ropes and then Abram’s. Then they fell back into the cart.

The wheels creaked and the gates opened. Wey closed his eyes and listened to the random voices and footsteps. In the distance he could hear a familiar padding.

“Abe,” he whispered. “Run for the gate. Try to find Finn.”

Abram nodded. He was already convinced he was going to be shot, what did it matter if he was running or standing still?

“Good luck,” Adiah said with meaning.

He couldn’t count so he just leapt, jumping over the side of the cart and landing miraculously on his feet. He ran towards the light, waiting for the jolt of pain that would finish everything. Already he could feel his life ebbing away from him. He wondered whether he should be reflecting on what he had become, whether he should be running through his regrets. He wondered what it was going to be like on the other side. He wondered if he would see those that had passed. He wondered, he wondered where the hell he was. Stopping abruptly he saw he had passed the gate; long since passed it. He was free. Throwing his shoulders back he began to strut, until he heard a growl. Thorin stood behind him, glaring with disapproving eyes. Abram sighed and conceded. He began to creep discreetly back to the palace to rescue the others.

“Ready?” Wey asked. “Jump on the first guard you see and grab his gun.”

Adiah nodded, ignoring the voice in her head telling her she was out of her mind.

“Adi,” he whispered between his thumping heart beats. “Not a lot of room down there was there.” He leapt to his feet, his trousers falling about his ankles. Adiah rose beside him. Her momentum was suddenly lost when she looked down at eight hungry rifles. She raised her hands.

“And plan two is?”

From behind them there was a charge of voices. Wey dropped to the floor, dragging Adiah with him. Shots were fired. Men yelled. Wey pushed Adiah into the corner of the cart. He rolled onto his back and fastened his trousers.

“Stay here,” he said. “I’ll come back for you.”

Before she could protest, he leapt from the cart and drew out his skewers. He pushed one into the face of a guard and kicked him until he relinquished his weapon. With a rifle in his hand he

turned. It was too late. The soldiers were dead. Wey sucked in a huge gulp of air and raised his eyebrows. Three surviving priests, Benton, Beau and Finn stared back at him.

"You took your bloody time," Benton yelled.

"Could say the same about you," Wey replied.

Adiah poked her head from the cart and her face beamed at the sight before her. She jumped free of the wooden box and ran to Finn, wrapping her arms around his neck and dragging him to the floor.

"You're alive!"

"For the minute. Might I suggest we move."

Wey took point. He reached the courtyard gates and spied more soldiers in the streets.

"Psst. Way out!" Abram stood proudly in six inches of sewage to the left of the palace. Thorin growled at them all impatiently.

They began to climb down into the ditch and made their way out of the decaying town.

Twenty-Four

Wey made them stop in the woods. From their position they could see the road and monitor any search parties that might be sent their way. He'd permitted the priests' return to the Temple after they'd ignored his advice about evacuating. If they wanted to die he wasn't willing to fight for them.

"So we're sat in these cells, talking all this philosophy," Beau told Adiah. "And then the door opened and in pops Finn with the keys."

"But how did you get the keys?" Adiah asked delighted to be among friends again.

Finn looked at the ground in thought. "My father had them."

He was lying, Wey just couldn't work out why. "I'm sick of this place," he said.

"Good because we're leaving tonight," Benton told them all.

"There's a ship waiting for us at the Temple," Finn added. "With the short notice I could only secure one. Maybe with another day we can get a second."

"To hell with that," Benton replied, "We all leave this island tonight."

Wey agreed. "Make your way to the Temple and get the boat ready," he told the pirates.

"What are you going to do?"

"I have to pay my debts. Finn, are you coming?"

Surprised, Finn rose ready to help, totally ignorant of where they were going.

The night was approaching, but the street lights were still unattended. Soon the town would be shrouded in darkness and there would be no undoing it until the morning. As Finn walked through the streets he lowered his eyes, he'd already seen two bodies before he entered the town. Both seemed to have bright red liquid streaming from their faces. He was afraid, afraid of what he had learnt and of what he was seeing. He wanted to be off the island and readying himself for what was to come, not marching back into hell.

The roads became vaguely familiar. He noticed the small tavern in the distance and realised, with a degree of relief, their destination. So far he hadn't spoken to Wey; knowing he would disapprove of his meeting with Balor.

"I forgot to thank you," Finn said to break the ice. "You didn't have to go after her."

Wey kept up his thunderous pace towards the inn. "You need to keep that girl on a tighter leash."

"Adiah's always been a law unto herself," he said, noting Wey's hostility. "Do you mind if I ask what we're doing here?" He asked when they finally reached the door to the Inn.

Wey closed his eyes; fatigue was starting to set in. He placed his hand on the door feeling how unusually quiet it was inside. "Balor," Wey murmured, "He helped you?"

Finn nodded. “How did you know?”

“Somebody gave my name. If Balor’s still on our side it means it could only have been one man. What happens stays between the two of us.” He didn’t wait for a response.

He pushed the door open. The bar was deadly silent. Two candles placed in the centre of the room, illuminated Groader’s grave face. He sat at one of the tables, a small glass in his hand and a bottle on the table.

“Quiet tonight,” Wey said.

“They’re all gone now,” Groader replied sombrely. “You were right, the old faces disappeared. I closed up to *them*, those with the red faces. They didn’t want the inn, all they want is that poison.”

Wey approached the table. “You know why I’m here?”

Groader nodded and filled his glass. He swallowed the fiery liquid and looked Wey in the eye. “I didn’t have a choice.” He sucked in a deep breath. “They took them Wey, they took my family. They were going to kill them if I didn’t help.”

Wey felt a stabbing in his gut. If he tried he could hear a girl singing as she danced around the room. “You know they’re dead don’t you?”

He nodded and began to cry. “Aye, but what man would I be if I didn’t try. I’m not Fimorri like them. You always knew that I would put them first.”

“You are a good man Groader,” Wey said honestly. “In your lifetime you’ve helped us more than damned us. Nobody will know about this and I’ll look for their bodies, lay them to rest.”

Grateful Groader stood from his chair and made to turn around. He put his hands on the back of his head, inviting the darkness into his heart. Wey raised his pistol.

“Wait!” Finn shouted. “We don’t have to do this!”

“I didn’t bring you here to interfere.” He pulled the trigger. Groader fell forward. His fingers twitched against the sawdust floor. Wey pulled a chair out and sat at the now empty table. He snatched the bottle and swallowed several mouthfuls of the sweet liquor. Finn stared at the corpse.

“He had no choice,” he murmured in dismay.

“I know.”

“You shouldn’t have killed him.”

Wey took another angry swig. “If the Elders knew what he did they would come for him and he would be taken to the Barge and hung. Would have taken him about forty minutes to die. Least this way he keeps his reputation and can’t do any more harm.” Wey stared at the corpse sorrowfully. He had known Groader’s family, he’d even been fond of them. He rested his pistol on the table and toasted the end of a lucrative friendship.

Twenty-Five

Brother Carlston walked up the spiral staircase. He constantly checked the Temple entrance every time the windows faced west. They closed the gates shortly after the attack. Now they would not open until the red poison was out of Hermia for good. Carlston didn't think he would ever see them opened again. They were strong enough to withstand another attack and most of the priests were too old to be of use to the Prince of Hermia. Still, he kept a watchful eye on the Temple's entrance, as did all his Brothers.

He knocked on the door of the spire and opened it slowly. The people inside had brought such destruction to his home and yet he felt salvation emanating from their souls. They were all alive, a miracle alone, and they had returned some of his brothers to him, for that they could neither outstay their welcome nor ask for too much. They were an unlikely group of heroes.

They had seen him enter, but their conversation was too important to halt at such a crucial stage.

"All I'm saying is you've not had the best luck," the giant pirate said. He was addressing the one armed pirate, like a remorseful puppy. "Both your ships sank."

"That wasn't my fault," the one armed pirate replied. "They were both worm ridden and neither was seaworthy."

"A bad workman always blames his tools," the giant said, folding his large arms. "All I'm saying is you need to step down and watch how it's done."

Carlston coughed and drew Finn and Adiah towards him.

"I have provisions for you, food, water, you must take weapons too."

"Brother you can't leave yourselves defenceless."

Carlston continued. "I have had them loaded onto the ship. Finn I need one thing from you, we have taken in refugees. Two families, thirteen in total, the only native survivors we found."

Adiah interrupted, "Of course we will take them with us. We need as many hands as we can get. Have them escorted onto the ship, and forewarn them what they could face out there."

Brother Carlston bowed. "You are very kind."

"You all should come with us," Finn said. "It's not safe here anymore."

"Finn you know how many wars this Temple has seen and survived. This is another time of hardship and we shall remain here and welcome you home when it is over."

Finn shook his hand. He knew his Temple history and never had anything threatened the lives of each living man in Hermia before. Wars were fought, soldiers died, innocents were caught up in a tangle of raids and misplaced attacks. Genocide, however, would be a new addition to the history books.

The Brothers gathered around the ship as it began to sail from the harbour. Brother Carlston smiled, satisfied, at last that he had done something for the world.

Continued in Part II: Traitors' Day

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